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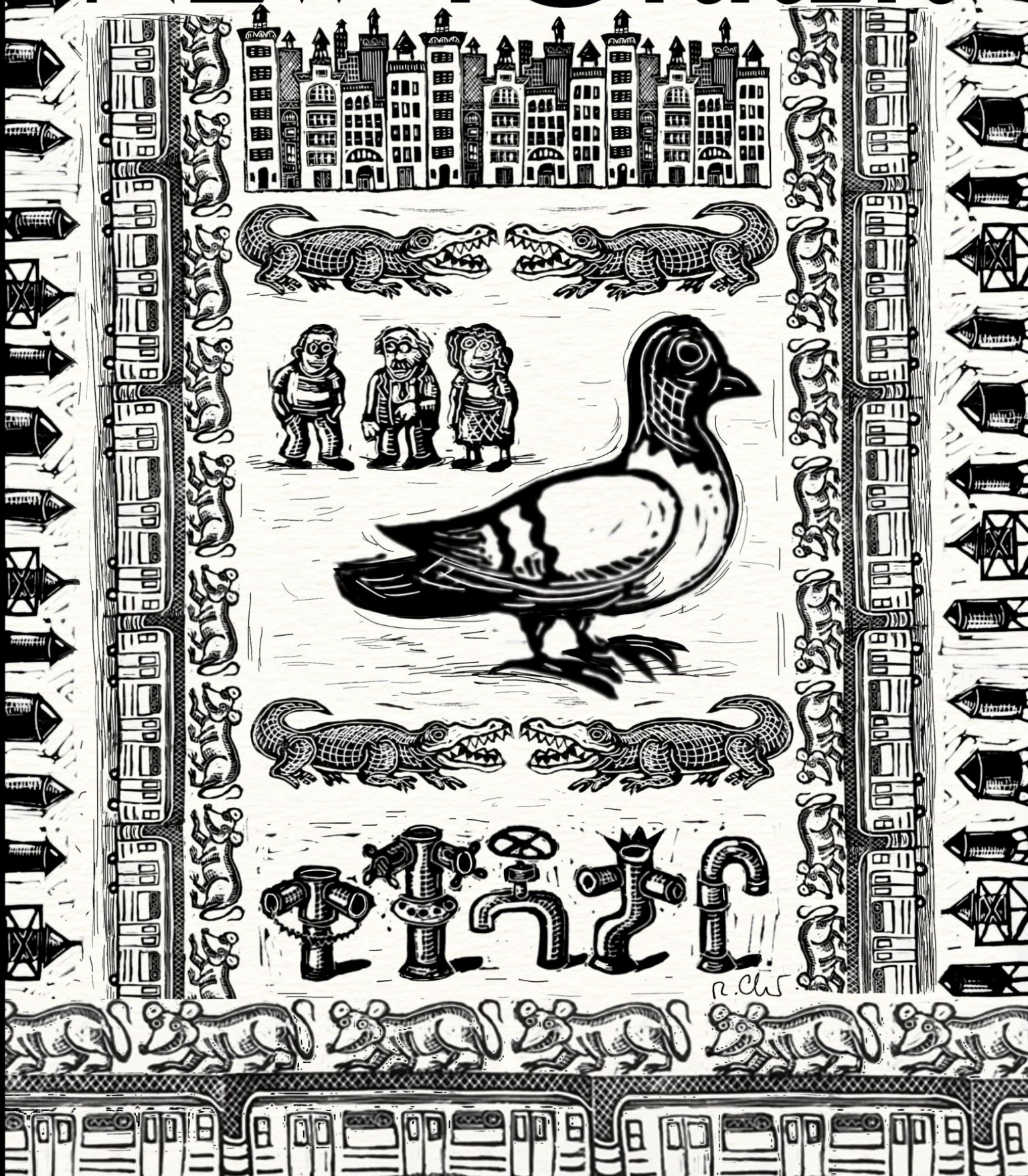

The New Yorker Magazine

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- **Patricia Cornwell on Crime and Creativity**
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Goings On

Elaine Reichek’s Needlepoint Revolution

Also: Ro Reddick’s absurdist “Cold War Choir Practice,” Sofia Coppola’s portrait of Marc Jacobs, Paige Williams on music for spiritual uplift, and more.

***By** Hilton Als, Sheldon Pearce, Emily Nussbaum, Marina Harss, Jane Bua, Richard Brody, Zoë Hopkins, **and** Paige Williams*

March 20, 2026

You’re reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we’re watching, listening to, and doing this week. ***Sign up to receive it in your inbox.***

Even if younger postmodern artists who use the same materials as **Elaine Reichek**—cloth, thread—to make work that involves stitching and the like don’t know it, the eighty-two-year-old artist is the mother of their invention. Or, at least, she certainly influenced it. I remember seeing her embroidery in the Whitney Museum’s 2012 Biennial; I got carried away by how fresh the language was in “Ariadne’s Thread” (2008-12), her series that visualizes the Greek myth about the Cretan princess helping her lover, Theseus, escape the Minotaur’s lair by following a thread she’d given him. One of the pieces, “Ariadne’s Lament” (2009), was composed of tiny, embroidered figures—a vase, a crying eye, a warrior—that were spaced apart, like those rebus puzzles that show an eye, then a heart, then a ewe (say it out loud).

Elaine Reichek in 1964.Photograph by George C. Engel, Jr. / Courtesy Elaine Reichek

Reichek's use of language in her art, always so witty, is undeniably feminist, and works from her "Sampler" series, which she's been making since the nineteen-nineties, are unabashedly so. By taking the sentiment of the traditional embroidered sampler and throwing it out in favor of quotes that address art-making and women becoming themselves, she seduces with the delicacy of her needlepoint and the primacy of the message. Born in New York in 1943, Reichek attended Brooklyn College, where she studied with the minimalist painter Ad Reinhardt. She moved past traditional picture-making in the nineteen-seventies, and "Back Stitch" (at Hoffman Donahue, in collaboration with Marinaro, through April 4), while not a full-scale retrospective, which she should have—hear that, Brooklyn Museum?—takes its title from a sewing method in which the maker goes back over a stitched line to fill in any open spaces. Reichek has helped close those gaps where art history has left women out, and, using the most "ladylike" of occupations—sewing, embroidering, all that which requires a special patience—wipes our faces with handkerchiefs drenched in the thought sweat and the freedom of the not at all pious woman warrior.—*Hilton Als*

About Town

Jazz

The composer **Shabaka Hutchings** and the drummer **Tom Skinner** co-founded the jazz-fusion band Sons of Kemet in 2011, and conjured avant-garde music of the Black diaspora across four albums before disbanding in 2022. Since parting, Shabaka has performed mononymously as a solo flautist and Skinner joined members of Radiohead to form the offshoot band the Smile. The musicians reunite for a show alongside **Irreversible Entanglements**, a free-jazz collective led by the poet-musician-educator Moor Mother (Camae Ayewa). The acts join forces to celebrate the release of two new albums, Shabaka's "Of the Earth" and Irreversible Entanglements' anticipated "Future Present Past," both of which use similarly experimental sensibilities to reach thrillingly distinct ends.—*Sheldon Pearce (Knockdown Center; March 26.)*

Off Broadway

Ro Reddick's likably off-kilter **"Cold War Choir Practice"** is an absurdist family sitcom set in a Syracuse roller-skating rink, a Reagan-era political farce, a zany quasi-musical featuring the singer Suzzy Roche, an avant-garde riff on "Spy vs. Spy," and a stealth satire of a young Clarence Thomas and his wife Ginni, all at once—a floor wax *and* a dessert topping, in the argot of the era. This madcap blend gets a bit lost on the cavernous stage, but a strong cast keeps the plates spinning, especially Alana Raquel Bowers, as the earnest ten-year-old Meek, and Grace McLean, a comic wunderkind as slinky as a Jules Feiffer illustration. Best of all is Crystal Finn as the googly-eyed Virgie, a walking panic attack in shoulder pads, scoring laughs just by gulping water.—*Emily Nussbaum (MCC; through April 5.)*

Dance

Mark Morris Dance Group performing "Via Dolorosa."Photograph by Chris Hardy

One of the choreographer Mark Morris's great gifts is the way he pares movement down to its essence, and then uses repetition and variation to create lasting images. In one of two programs at *BAM*, **Mark Morris Dance Group** performs his "Via Dolorosa," from 2024, a work of stunning purity, set to a score for solo harp by Nico Muhly, that reflects on the Stations of the Cross. Death, suffering, and consolation are treated with quiet simplicity. The other program includes "MOON," a compendium of tongue-in-cheek dances that explore our relationship to outer space. The score ping-pongs from piano by Ligeti to the nineteen-thirties ballad "Roll Along, Prairie Moon" to voices from the record that was sent aboard the Voyager spacecraft, in 1977: "Greetings from the inhabitants of this world."—*Marina Harss (Brooklyn Academy of Music; March 26-29.)*

Classical

From Paleolithic-era mammoth bones and hollow logs covered with alligator skin circa 5500 B.C. to the foot-pedalled kits popularized in the nineteen-tens and the electronic sets of today, drums have come a long way. Now, with the help of the multi-instrumentalist **Jamire Williams,** they may be pushed even further. Williams—drum master, performance artist—is bringing his rhythmic prowess to the Park Avenue Armory, with a solo performance that investigates what it means to create through percussion. Using not only acoustic drums but tape machines, samplers, found objects, and surfaces lined with odd materials, Williams becomes a mosaicist of sound. Who knows, maybe he'll whip out a mammoth bone.—*Jane Bua (Park Avenue Armory; March 25-26.)*

Movies

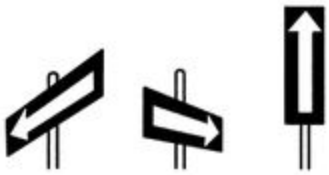
A scene from "Marc by Sofia."Photograph courtesy Marc Jacobs

Marc Jacobs and Sofia Coppola are longtime friends, and it shows in **"Marc by Sofia,"** the relaxed and detailed documentary that she devotes to his career and, above all, to his sense of style. The anchoring action is the making of his Spring 2024 collection, but the heart of the movie is in archival clips that reach back to the birth of a sensibility. Jacobs speaks candidly of a troubled childhood and lovingly about Fifth Avenue shopping trips with his grandmother, which inspired a feeling for fashion history and handicrafts. Coppola observes the connection of big ideas to fine details, the power of intensive collaborations, and the ultimate creative helplessness once the show starts.—*Richard Brody (Opening March 20 in New York and in wide release March 27.)*

Art

John Akomfrah's eight-channel film "Listening All Night To The Rain (Canto IV)" implicates its viewers in an impossible yearning to look every which way simultaneously. The piece wraps four walls at Lisson gallery, where Akomfrah montages archival and new footage. The work, moving in dizzying fits and starts across the surface of time, reveals connections between historical memory and now, and between political order and cultural superstructure. Images of marchers protesting the Nigerian civil war and of leaders of anti-colonial struggles blend with early documentation of European women's-liberation movements. The newly shot footage—much of which depicts eerie land- and seascapes—is

drenched in a surrealism that touches the body of the archive with an oneiric hand.—*Zoë Hopkins (Lisson; through April 25.)*



Pick Three

Paige Williams on uplifting songs.

Lately, with all the world in chaos, I've been looping uplifting spiritual music. I keep coming back to a playlist that helps my feelings, as my mother used to say, meaning it cheers me up:

1. "Don't Let the Devil Ride" is a 2018 album by Paul Thorn, the son of a Pentecostal preacher from my home town, Tupelo, Mississippi. In the eighties, Thorn boxed professionally, as a middleweight, ultimately fighting Roberto Durán, a five-time world champ, before turning to a career as a guitarist and singer. "Don't," Thorn's ninth album, reinterprets songs by Black gospel groups and artists—Joseph Pace II, Mississippi Fred McDowell, Oris Mays. The first track, "Come on Let's Go," is a bouncy balm "if you've got trouble," "if you are worried tonight," "if you feel hungry," "if you've been lied to," "if you need healin'." (Who doesn't?)

2. "Jesus Dropped the Charges," an iconic redemption song written by the Reverend Bishop Richard (Mr. Clean) White for the O'Neal Twins, was released in 1981. It was soon featured in "Say Amen, Somebody," a documentary on the history and importance of gospel music that débuted before a sold-out audience at the New York Film Festival.

3. Leonard Cohen's "I'm Your Man," the sexiest song in existence, is spiritual in a different way. For grace, there's, of course, "Hallelujah," and "Anthem," whose epic line is "There is a crack in everything / That's how the light gets in." But **"Come Healing"**—particularly a live version that Cohen performed in Dublin in 2013, not long before he died—feels especially timely. "O gather up the brokenness / Bring it to me now."

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- *The Penny Lane blouse could be yours*
- *Optimizing yourself into oblivion*
- *Michael Grynbaum on the art of book shopping*

An earlier version of this article misstated the New York release date of "Marc by Sofia."

Hilton Als, a staff writer at The New Yorker, won the 2017 Pulitzer Prize for criticism. He is the editor of "God Made My Face: A Collective Portrait of James Baldwin."
Sheldon Pearce is a music writer for The New Yorker's Goings On newsletter.
Emily Nussbaum, a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2011, is the magazine's theatre critic. Her books include "Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV."
Marina Harss has been contributing dance coverage to The New Yorker since 2004. She is the author of "The Boy from Kyiv: Alexei Ratmansky's Life in Ballet."
Jane Bua is a member of The New Yorker's editorial staff who covers classical music for Goings On. Previously, she wrote for Pitchfork.

Richard Brody, a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of "Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard."
Zoë Hopkins is a contributor to Goings On who writes about art.
Paige Williams, a staff writer, is the author of "The Dinosaur Artist" and a recipient of the National Magazine Award for feature writing.

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Book Currents

Patricia Cornwell on Crime and Creativity

The prolific novelist—whose most famous character, the forensic pathologist Kay Scarpetta, is played by Nicole Kidman in a TV adaptation premièring in March—discusses a few of her perennial rereads.

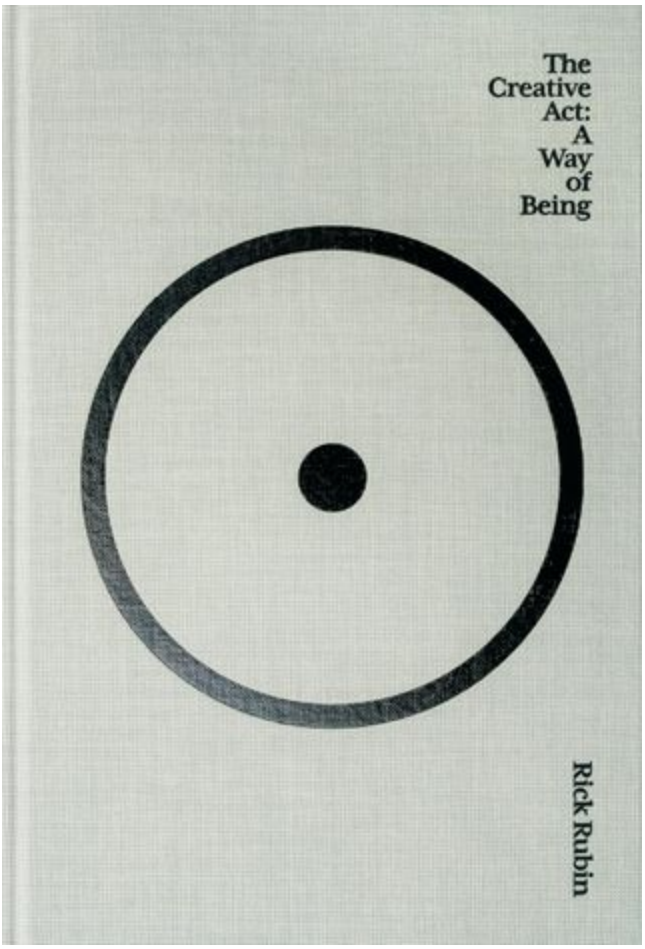
March 11, 2026

You're reading Book Currents, a weekly column in which notable figures share what they're reading. ***Sign up for the Goings On newsletter*** *to receive their selections, and other cultural recommendations, in your inbox.*

The crime novelist Patricia Cornwell has written more than forty books, which have altogether sold more than a hundred and twenty million copies. (This week, a long-awaited adaptation of her "Scarpetta" series, which centers on a forensic pathologist, premières on Amazon, with Nicole Kidman in the title role.) How does she do it? "I learned early on that the biggest enemy of creativity is fear," she writes in her memoir, "True Crime," which comes out in May. One of her goals for the book, she said recently, was to pass on some of her own advice—to impress upon people that creative endeavors are living, reactive things, and that they shouldn't give up in the face of rejection. Not long ago, she joined us to discuss some books, new and old, that have offered her creative guidance. Her remarks have been edited and condensed.

The Creative Act: A Way of Being

by Rick Rubin



Amazon | ***Bookshop***

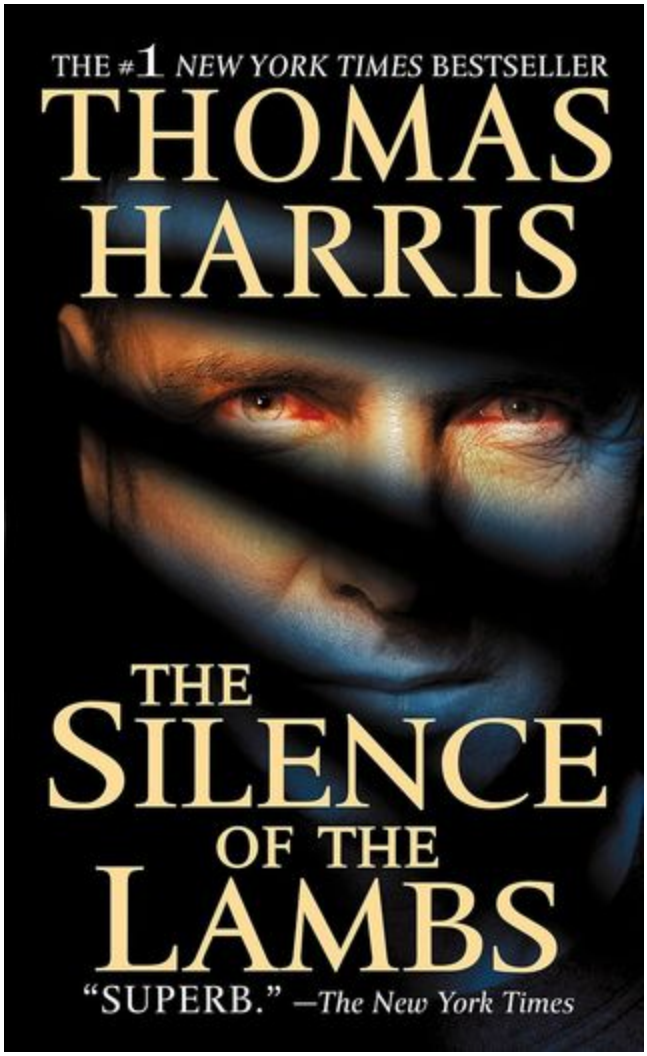
Sometimes when you're doing something creative—for me, that's writing—it feels like you're conducting electricity. You're channelling something that comes from outside of you. My favorite books—whether nonfiction or novels—are the ones where you can feel the author's DNA on them, but also feel, at the same time, like they almost came from elsewhere.

One of the reasons I like "The Creative Act" so much is because it talks about that process, and about how you've got to keep your current unfettered by all the distractions in life. The book reminds me a little bit of "The Artist's Way"—they both have a little bit of Zen to them, and at the same time they get down to concrete questions like, How do you not have writer's block? Rubin's answer for some of these is that you just have to be willing to get out of your own way. If you get hung up on what people think of you, or fame, or fortune, or, you know, "You've got to stick this in here

because it's popular right now," you get further from whatever truth it was within you that motivated you to be creative in the first place.

The Silence of the Lambs

by Thomas Harris



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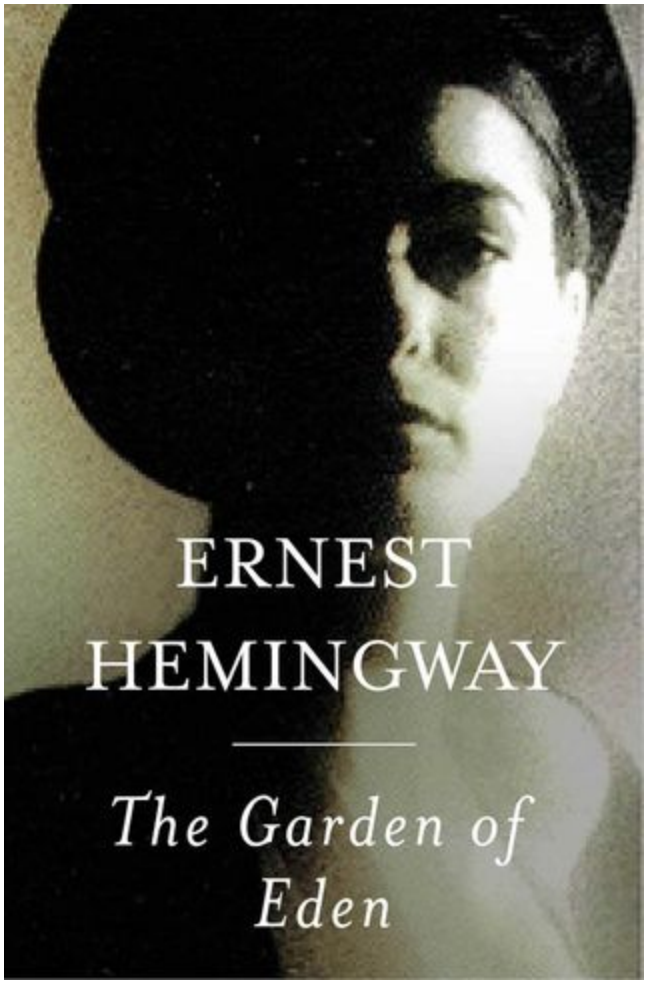
I really, truly think this is the best crime novel ever written. I read "Silence of the Lambs" when I was dabbling with starting "Postmortem," which was my fourth attempt to write a "Scarpetta" novel—the first three were failures—and ended up being my début. I try to learn from masterpieces, and this one taught me a lot. I have a signed first edition that's in a clamshell. Now

and then, I pick it up and look at it to remind myself of how important it is to tell really dramatic scenes that almost aren't possible, but in such a way that nobody doubts them. Let's be honest—there are crude versions of maniacs out there that have done similar things as Hannibal Lecter has, but the difference is you don't doubt him. And yet, at the same time, he is surreal. To me, he feels more like myth than reality, and that's what makes the book work so well.

The Garden of Eden

by Ernest Hemingway



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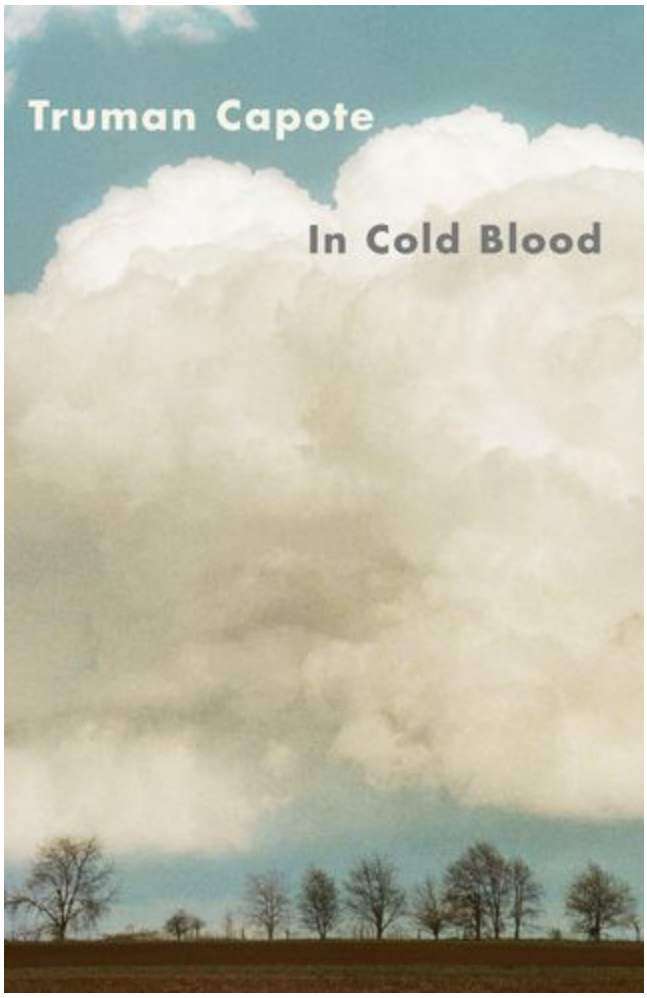
The reason I love this book—which Hemingway never finished, and which was published in a heavily edited, abridged form after he died—is that it almost feels like a friend. It's about a young writer who is beginning to get great reviews. He's newly married, and he and his wife are honeymooning in Europe. The novel is an incredible study of human nature, viewed through the lens of this young and dysfunctional relationship, but it's also a peep into Hemingway's mind as an author.

I like to keep a copy of this one nearby, too, because if there's one writer I would aspire to write like, it's Hemingway. His prose has a photographic quality that just takes my breath away. You can feel the cold stone under the character's bare feet as he's walking. You can smell the pencils as he sharpens them and looks out at the day and wonders what it will bring.

In Cold Blood

by Truman Capote



Amazon | ***Bookshop***

This is an account of a murder case in Kansas that took place in 1959. It is beautifully crafted. Look at the beginning, where Capote gives you a snapshot of Kansas—I mean, you can taste the dust. He was just that fine a writer.

Capote called the book a nonfiction novel. We don't really know if it is fish or fowl. I mean, what is he doing with us? Am I supposed to believe it really happened like this? For my part, I think there is probably a lot more fact to "In Cold Blood" than there is fiction. What Capote did was remarkable—spending time with the two killers, talking to them in prison, witnessing their execution. What also interests me about "In Cold Blood" is the way that Capote—who spent years following the case—in some ways, became part of the story he was telling, as he was telling it. That resonates

for me, because I also do very intense research. I visit morgues and crime scenes and spend time with people involved in real serial-murder cases. What starts out as research becomes a drama that you're living. You've gotten to know people, and they want things from you, and suddenly people get angry, and you even feel in danger. I marvel at what he did so long ago, when most writers weren't doing things like that.

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The Talk of the Town

- **The First Casualty of Trump's War in Iran Was the Truth**
  By David Remnick | The cruellest irony is that of a President who addresses the Iranian people in the language of liberation and then threatens freedom of the press back home.
- **Whose Line Is It Anyway?**
  By Zach Helfand | Queuing up is the new normal, especially when it comes to the T.S.A. Fifty minutes, two hours, half a day—how much time is a flight (or a cronut or a ticket to a Harry Styles show) worth?
- **Between Sting and the Deep Blue Sea**
  By Sarah Larson | The Police front man's 2014 musical, "The Last Ship," was inspired by his gritty working-class childhood in England. Now a revamped production—featuring Shaggy—is docking at the Metropolitan Opera.
- **Steve Zahn's Father-Daughter Dance**
  By Brian Seibert | At a Broadway studio, the actor busts a move with his daughter, Audrey, who also happens to be his inspiration (and co-star) for his new film, "She Dances."
- **Remembering Calvin Tomkins, a Master of the Profile**
  By David Remnick | For nearly seventy years, he captured the lives of modern artists for The New Yorker.

Comment

The First Casualty of Trump’s War in Iran Was the Truth

The cruellest irony is that of a President who addresses the Iranian people in the language of liberation and then threatens freedom of the press back home.

By David Remnick

March 21, 2026

Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

“In war, truth is the first casualty.” It’s a line often attributed to Aeschylus, and it has never lost its relevance. Sometimes the culprit is the observer—the propagandizing correspondent, the mythologizing historian. Now, three weeks into a war of choice, the chief offender is the President of the United States.

On February 28th, at two-thirty in the morning, the White House press operation released a prerecorded video of Donald Trump at Mar-a-Lago

standing at a lectern in dim light. Wearing an oversized U.S.A. ball cap and no tie, the President announced that he had ordered American bombers to commence destroying targets throughout the Islamic Republic of Iran. Trump made a claim of preëmption. He was acting, he said, to "defend the American people by eliminating imminent threats from the Iranian regime." (This was confusing. Hadn't Trump declared last June that he had "obliterated" Iran's nuclear program? Hadn't the Omani foreign minister, a mediator between the U.S. and Iran at negotiations in Geneva, just told "Face the Nation" that "a peace deal is within our reach"?) Trump went on to counsel the Iranian people to find refuge somehow—"It's very dangerous outside, bombs will be dropping everywhere"—but then, at some unspecified moment, they should "take over" their government. "Let's see how you respond." And to his American listeners, he admitted, "We may have casualties. That often happens in war."

For a narcissist obsessed with the projection of strength and grandeur, Trump gave a peculiarly gravity-free performance. The bill of his ball cap obscured his gaze. He raced and rambled through his text. And, rather than hustle back to the White House, he lingered at his country club. He had a fund-raising dinner to attend. It was left to the communications director, Steven Cheung, to provide clear instructions on how to react to the prospect of another American war in the Middle East. "*NO PANICANS*!" he wrote on X. "*TRUST IN TRUMP*!"

The President, together with the Israeli Prime Minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, could soon be heard lauding the precision with which they had "decapitated" the Iranian leadership and flattened military, police, and intelligence installations. And yet, as the late Defense Secretary Donald Rumsfeld once blithely said, in the thick of America's catastrophic misadventure in Iraq, "Stuff happens." The Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and much of the Iranian security hierarchy, would not survive the first day of bombing; neither would about a hundred and seventy-five innocents in the southern city of Minab, most of them children. When asked about a girls' school there, which was struck by what was likely an American cruise missile, Trump blamed Iran. "They are very inaccurate, as you know, with their munitions," he said.

Now, as war has engulfed both the region and the global economy, Trump and his sycophantic advisers have taken to improvising on the fly, floating conflicting justifications for war and predictions about its duration. The Iranians were close to developing missiles that could reach the U.S. (They weren't.) They were weeks away from building a nuclear weapon. (They weren't.) Israel forced America's hand. (Marco Rubio.) "No, I might have forced *their* hand." (Trump.) It's all about regime change. (Trump.) It's *not* about regime change. (Trump, later.) When confronted with these contradictions and falsehoods, all the President's men followed his lead: they blamed the media.

With increasing frequency, Trump berates reporters (particularly female reporters). He sues media outlets for sport. Resolve is in short supply. The owner of the Washington *Post*, the newspaper of Watergate, has done irreparable violence to his property merely to stay in Trump's good graces.

But, while the President has little regard for the freedom of the press, he craves its ceaseless attention. His need has the quality of addiction. In Washington these days, there is hardly a reporter who does not have the President's cellphone number. It is said that the best time to call is late at night while he is watching himself on TV and shitposting in his pajamas. He loves to muse aloud, then watch as those musings register in foreign capitals, and in the markets. Lately, he has been willing to say anything. The war will be over soon. Or maybe not. Whatever. Each pseudo-scoop is as ephemeral as a mayfly. But who can resist? When asked about the possibility of sending his infantry into Iran, he answers in the language of golf: "I don't have the yips with respect to boots on the ground." At other moments, he simply changes the subject to, say, his taste in interior decoration—"If you look behind me, see the nice gold curtains." Are you not entertained?

His advisers, of course, know what to do. Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth, who has cracked down on actual reporting at the Pentagon and has filled his pressroom with "influencers" and propagandists, spoke in his usual tone of rage recently when he lambasted CNN's coverage of the war as "fake news." He would be pleased, he said, when the Trump-friendly

Ellison family, which has already swallowed up CBS News, finally takes possession of CNN, too.

Brendan Carr, who runs the Federal Communications Commission for Trump, eagerly joined the fray by threatening to revoke the licenses of television networks that are, in his view, “running hoaxes and news distortions.” Trump pronounced himself “thrilled” with Carr’s outburst. On Truth Social, he accused “Highly Unpatriotic ‘News’ Organizations” of airing “*LIES*.” Perhaps, he wrote, he will prosecute unruly journalists on “Charges for *TREASON*.”

Carr’s threats to pull network licenses have no legal weight; the more immediate danger is that media owners, who are all too aware of the economic pressures they face, will quietly cut back on critical coverage of the Trump Presidency in general, and the war in particular. They will fear landing outside the boundary of what is deemed patriotic. The historian Garry Wills, in an essay on Phillip Knightley’s 1975 book about wartime journalism, “The First Casualty,” wrote, “A liberal democracy submits to propaganda more readily than a totalitarian state. Self-censorship is always more effective than bureaucratic censorship.”

The cruellest irony is that the President who addresses the Iranian people in the language of liberation, urging them to throw off the yoke of a regime that has brutalized them for decades, is the same man who threatens American journalists with treason charges and tries to strong-arm broadcasters into subservience. Having torn up a nuclear agreement in his first term and gone to war with no coherent goal in his second, Trump now directs his fire at the one thing he cannot afford to leave standing: the truth. What’s at stake is democracy’s oldest promise—that the people may call on their government to answer for what it does in their name. ♦

David Remnick has been the editor of The New Yorker since 1998 and a staff writer since 1992. He is the author of seven books; the most recent is “Holding the Note,” a collection of his profiles of musicians.

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Between the Lines

Whose Line Is It Anyway?

Queuing up is the new normal, especially when it comes to the T.S.A. Fifty minutes, two hours, half a day—how much time is a flight (or a cronut or a ticket to a Harry Styles show) worth?

By Zach Helfand

March 23, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

You can tell a lot about a society's health by its lines. It's probably not a good sign that airports have been experiencing Soviet levels of security lines recently: three and a half hours at Houston Hobby, lines wrapping around the building in Fort Lauderdale, lines spilling onto the sidewalk in

Austin. There are some outlier lines that hint at abundance or gluttony—your lines of coke or of conga—but lines generally broadcast supply problems: breadlines, Cuban bodega lines, embargo-era gas lines. Donald Trump, after a natural disaster, has been known to throw supplies into a crowd (What line? There's more than enough for everyone!), but also boasts of the line lengths at his rallies. It's the same reason Louis XIV cultivated lines for an audience. When you've got the goods, scarcity projects power. In French, *la queue* is slang for "penis."

At J.F.K. (more than an hour) and Newark (seventy-one minutes), passengers wait on line, in our peculiar regional formulation. In Atlanta (two hours) and New Orleans (three) and pretty much everywhere else, they wait *in* line, except for the Brits, who queue. Theirs is a country obsessed with hierarchy and one's place in it; queuing etiquette is basically their citizenship exam. Americans tend to have less patience. You can track political discontent via inflation and inequality, or you can look at lines: voting lines, vaccine lines, virtual lines for veterans' benefits. The airport lines have resulted from a government shutdown, our third in six months. T.S.A. agents, who haven't been fully paid since February 14th, have been calling in sick. There have been digital lines for Social Security checks (blame *DOGE*) and for Harry Styles (blame Ticketmaster). New Yorkers can pay thirty-two hundred dollars for a studio apartment, but often only after waiting on a long line to tour it.

Lines are more insulting, of course, when they're distributed unequally. PreCheck, first class, *CLEAR*. Lines reveal whose time is worth more than whose. (See: women's bathroom lines.) In Dubai, apparently, the ruling Emiratis get to cut, as do politicians in Thailand. But there's something egalitarian about an unadulterated line. This is a system that's un-gameable by algorithm, concierge, or bot. Its rules need no explanation (though Wimbledon's queuing guide is five pages), and violators are treated harshly. In 2006, a guy stabbed an alleged line cheat near a midtown halal cart, and even a prosecutor acknowledged that everyone hates a cutter. "They sneak," she said. "Is that polite? No. But is it criminal? No."

Vladimir Sorokin, who wrote a novel called "The Queue," viewed the line as the U.S.S.R.'s defining feature. (Soviet joke: A man in an endless line for

vodka leaves to go kill Stalin but soon returns. The line to kill Stalin was even longer.) In a way, the Soviet Union ended not when the wall fell but when the line did. Sorokin wrote, “The line was dispersed and reborn as a crowd.”

The queuer’s paradox: passing a line, you want to join it. Biblically speaking, the first line was Noah’s. You wanted to be in that one. We queue for the cronut, Trader Joe’s, Shakespeare, and the Jimmy Choo sample sale. One notices the line at Lucali, but not at Sbarro. “A longer line could signal value,” Jamol Pender, a professor of queuing theory at Cornell, said the other day. Lines are unavoidable (“One of my journal papers took three years to come back to me,” Pender said. “It was about queuing”), but there are mitigation methods. Airports situate gates far from baggage claim—people don’t mind walking to their bags, but they do mind lining up to wait for them.

On a recent afternoon, the line at LaGuardia’s Terminal B was one of the longest in the country. Estimate: twenty-eight minutes. That seemed suspect; it overflowed through the concourse. An amateur queuing theorist waited in front of Muizz Shaikh, a physical therapist from Pune, India, who was heading to a conference in Phoenix, via Denver. India is a country of many lines but different norms. You can talk your way through. “In Pune, we have a savory which we call *vada pav*,” Shaikh said. “People line up for it, but the service is quick. It’s like five minutes.”

His trip so far: Two entry lines in Mumbai. Lines for check-in and boarding. A security line in Dubai, where an Iranian drone had reportedly hit an oil tank, necessitating a stopover to fill up in Jeddah, which had a taxi line to the runway. Shaikh landed at J.F.K. (customs), but his next flight was cancelled. “Thirty-four hours I have been travelling,” he said. “I don’t have any energy left.”

The estimated twenty-eight minutes came and went. The travellers weren’t even halfway to the checkpoint. Eyes glazed at the forty-minute mark. A guy with Louis Vuitton luggage and a wad of cash yelled at his family. Nine minutes later, Shaikh chose between three I.D.-screening sub-lines. “I always seem to pick the slower side,” he said. Fifty-five minutes and thirty seconds after joining, he made it through and headed to his gate. There was

enough time to linger in the pre-boarding blob line, to enter the official line, and to queue on the jet bridge, before heading to his seat. ♦

Zach Helfand is a staff writer at The New Yorker.

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The Boards

Between Sting and the Deep Blue Sea

The Police front man's 2014 musical, "The Last Ship," was inspired by his gritty working-class childhood in England. Now a revamped production—featuring Shaggy—is docking at the Metropolitan Opera.

By Sarah Larson

March 23, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

Sting, seventy-four and wiry, recently emerged from a dressing room in a gloriously windowed studio at David Geffen Hall, at Lincoln Center, wearing navy coveralls and work boots. "I'm pretending I'm a working man," he said. Sting plays a shipyard foreman in his musical "The Last

Ship," newly retooled and coming to the Metropolitan Opera House; that day, he was performing songs from it for Lincoln Center's Sidewalk Sessions series, in which musicians behind glass are observable to passersby. Sting sat on a stool, parked a foot on a wood block, got tended to by a makeup artist, and picked up a hand-painted acoustic guitar made by a luthier in Kent. He appeared to be floating above Broadway. He played "All This Time," from 1990, singing of a river, fog, shire horses, and burial at sea, sounding warm and clear and looking like a slightly weathered version of his Police-era self. Outside, a Heinz-bean truck rolled by, onlookers did double takes, and a man wheeled an upright bass to the subway stairs. Sting sang the delicate title song in a Northern brogue ("They're launchin' a boat on the morrow at noon") and a fire engine blustered by, sirens howling. Sting played the tune again and said, "I miss the 'wee-oh, wee-oh.' "

Afterward, in a lofty room called the J. P. Morgan Music Box, he sat in a modernist chair by more glorious windows and kicked back with some coconut water. "Electrolytes," he said, with satisfaction. "The Last Ship" was inspired by the shipyard community in his home town, Wallsend, where Hadrian's Wall ends, in the North of England. His coveralls ("In Britain, we call this a boilersuit") resembled what his grandfather, a shipwright, wore "every day of his life"—even at church, even in retirement. "I was born in a surreal industrial environment," Sting said. "As a child growing up, the end of my street would be blocked by a giant ship. Some of the largest vessels ever constructed on earth were built there. The sun would be blocked out by these giant hulls towering over the house. The shipyard was infernally noisy and dangerous, with terrible toxic chemicals, asbestos and the like. I'd watch thousands of men walk to work every morning." He'd also grudgingly help his dairy-manager father deliver milk. On such mornings, he said, "I'd dream a lot, and I dreamt about being a musician." London dignitaries would come for ship launches, "to smash the champagne bottle against the hull, and members of the Royal Family would come down our street and wave. I thought, That's an indication of a bigger life. That's the kind of life I want—not royalty, but it gave me an ambition." An emigrating family friend gave him a guitar, which he played obsessively, and he got a scholarship to a grammar school in Newcastle. He saw both as a way out.

“I just need to find a way to monetize reading lots of articles and not remembering anything about any of them.”
Cartoon by Benjamin Schwartz

By the mid-eighties, Sting had sold tens of millions of records, with the Police and solo. In 1987, both his parents were dying, and he returned home; the shipyard was struggling, too. “I saw the shipyard and thought, That’s quite a metaphor.” His parents died that year, and the shipyard closed a while later. The converging losses led to Sting’s 1991 album, “The Soul Cages”—not a fan favorite, though it has “a constituency of the recently bereaved.” He also saw something theatrical in it: “The shipyard has an operatic scale.” In 2011, he dug in, writing stanzas for a foreman, a riveter, a welder, and others, and composing a score informed by “the local folk music, very Celtic”; sea chanteys; and classic musicals, which he’d listened to growing up with his mother, a Rodgers and Hammerstein fan. (“The daisies in the dell / will give out a different smell,” he sang, recalling Pore Jud.) The current “Ship” has a new book, some new songs, and Sting’s collaborator and pal Shaggy, the boombastic reggae star, who plays a mischievous ferryman.

The Met hasn’t mounted a Broadway show before. Sting, who has performed there, is excited to return. “On an iconic stage, you bring all of the history with you,” he said. “ ‘Wow, Pavarotti sang here!’—who was a friend of mine. He was a bit of a lad.” One day, Sting and his wife, Trudie Styler, visited Pavarotti in Italy, and the King of the High C’s took them waterskiing. “It was quite choppy, the Adriatic that day,” Sting recalled. He was on skis; Pavarotti drove the boat, Styler alongside him, “like Bluto and Olive Oyl,” Sting said. “Popeye here was hanging on for dear life.” After ten minutes, he fell, and Pavarotti zoomed on. “They’re going off into the sunset, he’s singing ‘Traviata’ or something, and her eyelids are fluttering.”

He reënacted waving an arm, SOS style: “ ‘Hey, I’m dying!’ Eventually, they got me.” ♦

Sarah Larson, a staff writer, has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2007.

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The Pictures

Steve Zahn’s Father-Daughter Dance

At a Broadway studio, the actor busts a move with his daughter, Audrey, who also happens to be his inspiration (and co-star) for his new film, “She Dances.”

By **Brian Seibert**

March 23, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

As its name promises, Broadway Dance Center is situated in the heart of the theatre district (and also next door to Flashdancers Gentlemen’s Club). But a class there the other day could have been happening in any dance studio—

mirrored wall, a room packed with intense aspirants warming up, the temperature rising as they sweated for the teachers' attention.

"I love being here," the actor Steve Zahn said. "This is home." His twenty-three-year-old daughter, Audrey, spent most of her childhood as a competition dancer, which meant that Zahn spent most of her childhood schlepping her to and from rehearsals and hotels, waiting in parking lots, making props, and sitting backstage or in the audience through long recitals. Zahn was a dance dad.

That experience is fictionalized in "She Dances," a new film he wrote with Rick Gomez. Zahn stars as a hapless father who's estranged from his daughter until he chaperones at her final dance competition. Audrey Zahn, in her first starring role, plays the daughter.

She was with her dad at the Broadway Dance Center to watch Jamie Harvener, the film's choreographer, and Haley Fish, who plays Audrey's nemesis, Marla, teach the slinky, cutthroat solo Marla performs in the movie. Audrey has known Fish and Harvener since her competition days, when they were all students in the same studio, in Lexington, Kentucky. After graduating, Harvener became Audrey's choreographer. "He lived for a year in our house," Steve said.

Steve and his wife, the novelist Robyn Peterman, met when they were both in a national tour of "Bye Bye Birdie"; when they had Audrey and her brother, Henry, they vowed not to push the kids into show business. But, when Audrey was three, a dance studio near their farm in Kentucky beckoned.

After a few sessions, the Zahns were invited to watch Audrey dance. Steve recalled, "I remember both Robyn and I going, 'Well, we don't have to worry about this one. She sucks.' "

But she improved, and eventually she was winning group and solo competitions: Miss Dance Kentucky, Miss Dance Tennessee. The events could be as gruelling for parents as for participants. "You go to some of these competitions and you're, like, 'What the fuck is going on? Are they

strippers?' " Steve said. "There were times you're, like, 'I hope they don't do so hot so we can get out of here.' " Mostly, though, he was proud.

In the movie, the father's well-meaning ineptitude is played as cringe comedy. (At one point, he tries to upgrade a hotel reservation, but books for the wrong week.) In life, he was more competent. "He was a good dance dad," Audrey said, noting that he would break rules by smuggling in snacks.

"In Chattanooga, they were, like, 'You can have hot dogs or tater tots,' " Steve said, aghast. "These were dancers! It was strange. Hence a lot of stuff in the movie."

In 2021, Steve accompanied Audrey to her final dance competition, at the Gaylord Opryland Resort, in Nashville, where she was a finalist in the Miss Dance America pageant. Amid storms of rhinestones, glitter, and hair spray, Steve sent messages to Gomez about how crazy it all was, and Gomez immediately saw the movie potential. When the competition ended, Steve realized that an era was ending for him, too. "People you've known for fifteen years and all of a sudden, it's over," he said. "It was a comfortable place for me as an actor and somewhat of a celebrity. Here I was just the dad."

A good number of people from the Lexington dance world appear in "She Dances," filling out bit parts and crowd scenes. "The film looks a lot bigger than it is because we have relationships with the teachers and parents and those fucking great kids," Zahn said.

As he watched the New York students perform a frenzy of head whips, body rolls, turns, and kicks, his eyes widened in dance-dad appreciation. "A lot of people don't understand how hard these kids are working," he said.

Afterward, he addressed the class. "This film is made about you guys, in homage to what *you* do," he said. Then he reverted to his other job, and started posing for selfies. ♦

Brian Seibert has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2002. He is the author of "What the Eye Hears: A History of Tap Dancing," which won an Anisfield-Wolf Book Award. His writing appears in the New York Times and the New York Review of Books. A Guggenheim fellow, he teaches at Yale University.

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Postscript

Remembering Calvin Tomkins, a Master of the Profile

For nearly seventy years, he captured the lives of modern artists for *The New Yorker*.

By David Remnick

March 20, 2026

Calvin (Tad) Tomkins, photographed in Middletown, Rhode Island, on October 26, 2024.Photograph by Richard Renaldi for The New Yorker

Until the very end, our friend and colleague Calvin Tomkins looked at his life with a sense of wonder and wry amusement. He died on Friday at the age of one hundred, just a few months younger than *The New Yorker*, his working home since 1958. Tad (he always went by Tad) was an irrepressibly energetic man with excellent hair, bright, curious eyes, and a

shy, slivery smile—and yet, when friends and strangers remarked on how young he looked, he deflected, citing what he called "the three ages of man": Youth, Maturity, and You Look Great.

Tad's specialty was the Profile—in particular, Profiles of modern artists. For nearly seventy years, he filled this magazine with portraits of the creative imaginations who thrilled him the most, from Marcel Duchamp to, just recently, Tala Madani and Rashid Johnson. Sometimes he widened his beat and wrote about dance (Merce Cunningham), or music (John Cage), or the art of cooking (Julia Child).

Not long ago, Phaidon published "The Lives of Artists," a six-volume collection containing eighty-two of his Profiles. Tomkins borrowed the title from a sixteenth-century publication by Giorgio Vasari, a painter and an architect who chronicled the lives of Cimabue, Michelangelo, Raphael, Leonardo, Giotto, and many other predecessors and contemporaries. Tad's subjects were the moderns. And the more you read his Profiles—from Duchamp to Kerry James Marshall, Jasper Johns to Cindy Sherman—the more you realize that his chutzpah in echoing Vasari's title is well earned. There is always a sheen to his writing. The sentences cut a swift, clean trail across the page—a mackerel through the water. To read "Living Well Is the Best Revenge," his account of the marriage of Gerald and Sara Murphy, and their circle of friends which included Pablo Picasso, Cole Porter, and the Fitzgeralds, is to inhabit completely that privileged yet haunted milieu of the French Riviera a century ago. It is a perfect nonfiction companion to F. Scott Fitzgerald's "Tender Is the Night."

Tad appreciated the great critics and art academics of his time, but he was not of their tribe. His approach was journalistic. His pieces thrived on proximity to the artist at hand. His technique was closer to Whitney Balliett's work on jazz musicians for this magazine. Just as Balliett cast a wide net, taking in everything from Teddy Wilson's swing to Ornette Coleman's avant-garde harmolodics, Tad was boundlessly open to all traditions and experiments. He and his wife, Dodie Kazanjian, his partner in absolutely everything, never stopped roaming the galleries and calling on artists in their studios. (In 1993, Tad and Dodie published "Alex," a biography of the Russian-born sculptor and editorial director of Condé Nast

Alexander Liberman.) Every few months or so, they would stop by the office, full of enthusiasm, to provide a short list of the new artists who topped their "Must Profile" list. Soon afterward, Tad's editor, Cressida Leyshon, would announce that "the new Tomkins" had arrived, on time as always. Into his late nineties, he was as exacting on deadline with his work as a wire-service reporter with a White House bulletin.

Tad grew up in West Orange, New Jersey, in a well-to-do family. His father sold a plaster company to the Allied Chemical and Dye Corporation. There was a Utrillo on the wall, as well as a painting of some wolves that may or may not have been by Courbet. Before joining this magazine as a staff writer, Tad dabbled in humor and fiction and held posts at both Radio Free Europe and *Newsweek*. His first full-fledged Profile published here was of Jean Tinguely, a Swiss "motion sculptor" whose contraptions, Tad wrote, "usually fail to work in the way they are expected to, and sometimes they do not work at all." He described one of Tinguely's works on display at a museum in Amsterdam as a gas-powered "painting machine" that was meant to explode periodically and produce abstract drawings. Tinguely's contraption, however, proved "unable to do any of this, because another artist, perhaps enraged at such theatrical egocentricity in a mere machine, had poured beer into its fuel tank."

When Tad was ninety-nine and the work of traipsing off to far-flung destinations and carrying a long piece around in his head had finally become too trying, he and Dodie stayed mainly at their house in Rhode Island. Tad decided to keep a diary. "Old age is no joke, but it can feel like one," he wrote. "You look everywhere for your glasses, until your wife points out that you're wearing them." From there, he went on to reflect on moments from his past, his children, his friends, various artists, Dodie, and the days he had left. After suffering a stroke, he wrote:

> The medical consensus seems to be that I will get a lot better, but it will take time, and (wouldn't you know) I'll have to do most of the work—new exercises ahoy. Meanwhile, my centennial is at the door.
>
> This will be the last entry for a while.

The diary was published in our pages just as Tad hit his hundredth birthday, on December 17th. He kept writing just about until the day he died. ♦

David Remnick has been the editor of The New Yorker since 1998 and a staff writer since 1992. He is the author of seven books; the most recent is "Holding the Note," a collection of his profiles of musicians.

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Profiles

Robyn, on Her Own

The pop star brings motherhood and middle age to the dance floor.

By Jia Tolentino

March 23, 2026

Music "does something to my body that nothing else but sex does," Robyn says.Photograph by Camilla Åkrans for The New Yorker

A few minutes before midnight on New Year's Eve, the Brooklyn Paramount was vibrating at capacity, crammed with very alert gay guys, gently aging party girls, and a grab bag of other Zohran Mamdani voters seeking that rare dance-floor transposition of uncertainty into bliss. The Paramount, which opened almost a century ago and holds a few thousand people, was recently restored to its neo-Baroque glory—its gilded ceiling, arching eighty feet high, strobed with light. Everyone was there to see Robyn, the Swedish pop star, and she stepped just then into a d.j. booth,

wearing a one-shouldered black top. Her set wouldn't start for another hour; in the meantime, she would ring in the New Year with her fans. She hadn't performed in New York City since 2019, which felt like a long time ago.

Robyn is forty-six. She's best known for "Dancing on My Own," a 2010 hit with a never-ending half-life—a generational floor-filler on the level of "I Will Survive" or "Don't Stop Believin'." (You know it: *I'm in the corner / Watchin' you kiss her, oh-oh-oh!*) The song, which Robyn performed last year with David Byrne for the fiftieth anniversary of "Saturday Night Live," converts despairing lyrics into a rapturous thrill. Byrne told me recently, of the song, "What's interesting is the insistent pulse that says, 'You'll be all right, the music will lift you, keep going.' Triumph over adversity. Songs can do that—immerse us in the problem and its solution at the same time."

"Dancing on My Own" was the first single from "Body Talk," a trilogy of albums, all released a few months apart, on which Robyn's artistic signature became unmistakable: sorrow as the content, ecstasy as the form. Listening to her music, you're not enveloped in the minutiae of her emotional universe, as you are with someone like Taylor Swift. Rather, Robyn will extract from her universe the simplest of plots—a pure love, thwarted—and then expand it to encompass everything. Her voice, tensile and clear, is an ideal delivery system for longing; it makes me picture melted sugar hardening on ice. "You don't need to compress it or shape it," Svein Berge, a longtime collaborator of Robyn's and one half of the electronic duo Röyksopp, told me. "It seems fragile, but it's punchy—when she says a word, it somehow goes straight through the speaker and pulls at your heart."

At the sight of Robyn, the crowd at the Paramount turned collectively into children. The show's demographic was as familiar to me as my own face. Most of us had been steeping in cynicism for a decade, at least; sincere year-end ideas about celebration and renewal were not really in play. But some people make you feel like all sorts of things might be possible. Robyn's songs are rarely played on American radio, and she is surrounded by the kind of good will given only to the underdog. Her trajectory is unique: she was a commodity at sixteen, a flop at twenty-one, an indie

darling at twenty-six, and a cult icon at thirty-one. Then, unusually, in the second half of her career, she began to reveal herself in new ways.

As the clock ticked toward midnight, she counted us down; against the rococo ceiling, streamers and confetti burst like runoff emotion through the air. This month, Robyn is releasing her ninth album, “Sexistential,” and will soon begin a tour in which she’ll play only arenas. But she booked the Paramount for New Year’s because it has the capacity of the venues that she’s played in for most of her career. She took the stage at one in the morning—she’d wanted her audience to have a late night at the club—and then, a minute into her first song, the sound cut out. The lights came on, the terrible way they do when it’s time to go home. Robyn ran backstage; a fire alarm was ringing, and emergency lights blinked. Ten minutes passed in eyes-wide paralysis—was there a shooter? Had we been foolish to cash in our hidden, hoarded optimism chips on this? A friend turned to me, looking doubtful. “You said she had a baby, right? And she’s, what, mid-forties? Don’t you think she’s, like, ‘Fuck this, I’m going to bed’?”

But all was well: a smoke machine had triggered an alarm in a room high in the venue. Robyn returned and picked up right where she’d left off. “There’s this empty space you left behind / Now you’re not here with me,” she sang. Our anxiety flipped to joy.

“It felt like part of the whole thing, right?” Robyn said to me later, when I asked her about that moment. She’d had too much adrenaline when she’d started that first song anyway, she said—the false alarm gave her a second to drink some wine and laugh a bit. Crowds in New York have a particular intensity, she told me; she’d talked about this recently with her brother, who was travelling with her and had gone out clubbing. It felt related not only to life in the city but to life in the U.S. more broadly. In Stockholm, she said, it’s hard to find a club where people don’t talk on the dance floor. “That’s because our lives are too good,” she explained. “New York is this place where people just work so hard, and you’re in this environment that’s aware that you’re in a country that’s really failing at taking care of its citizens. And that combination, I guess, is really good for people like me, who want to play for an audience that feels something.”

Sweden is a small country—ten and a half million people, roughly the population of North Carolina—that somehow dominates global pop music. It began with ABBA in the nineteen-seventies, followed by Ace of Base in the early nineties, but the real takeover came a few years later, when the songwriter and producer Max Martin started working with everyone from Britney Spears to Céline Dion. Martin has now written more *Billboard*-charting songs than any artist except Paul McCartney; Martin and another Swede, Shellback, a frequent collaborator, have masterminded hits for most of the major American pop stars of this century. Robyn sang one of Martin's first hits.

A few months ago, I walked through Södermalm, a hip neighborhood in Stockholm, to a building that looked like a turreted fairy-tale castle on a hill, where I took an old-fashioned cage elevator up to Robyn's apartment. Two black strollers were parked in the hall. Robyn opened the door wearing a big gray hoodie, jeans with a rip over the ass, and round wire-frame glasses. She gave me a tight hug and hung up my coat in a closet that was as full of practical puffer jackets as Carrie Bradshaw's walk-in is full of Manolos. Her place was airy and quiet, and light flooded in pleasantly through curved windows that looked out over the water that surrounds the city. Robyn had made strong coffee, and she set out a plate of crisp gingerbread men. The oven in her kitchen was dotted with alphabet magnets; a wooden train set covered the floor of the adjoining room. We sat down at a large kitchen table, and I complimented her on the place, wondering privately whether other international pop stars have primary residences of about seventeen hundred square feet. "A friend of mine lived in this building when I was a kid," she said. It was the sort of place that her own parents couldn't have afforded. A few years ago, pondering single motherhood, she bought the apartment and prepared to move in.

Robyn's solo performance style melds the dramatic sincerity of an ice dancer with the unhinged artlessness of a person alone in her house.Photograph by Sacha Lecca / Rolling Stone / Getty

Robyn's parents worked in the theatre. Her father, Wilhelm Carlsson, was a director, and her mother, Maria Ericson, was an actress. Together, they founded an experimental troupe called Teater Schahrazad, and Robin Miriam Carlsson spent much of her early childhood on tour with them around Europe. "It was them and their best friends from high school making the weirdest things," she told me, as we drank coffee and ate cookies. She recalled a play in which the main character hallucinated in a mental hospital. "All the doctors and nurses became wild animals," she said. The troupe disbanded when Robyn was seven, and the family settled year-round in Stockholm. Her dad directed shows for the Royal Dramatic Theatre, and her mom did TV and voice-over work, as did Robyn. As a child, she voiced a character in a 1989 animated movie based on Shakespeare's "The Tempest," and the way she speaks now isn't so different from the ingenuous storybook lilt of that character, an elflike girl in frock and hat.

The family relied on welfare, but Robyn had a sterling arts education, as children generally do in Sweden. Music classes are standard through ninth grade—explanation No. 1 for the Swedes' stranglehold on pop—and there are almost three hundred government-funded local arts schools in the country. Robyn learned to play the piano, and then, thanks to state-sponsored lessons, the flute. It was clear to everyone, including Robyn herself, that she, too, would become a performer.

Robyn explained her parents' attitude toward the arts by telling a story about her younger brother, a contemporary dancer who, in his early thirties, decided to change careers. "He was, like, 'I'm just going to try to work nine to five and have a salary,' " she recalled. Her parents staged an intervention, begging him to keep dancing. "I used to think they were so naïve," Robyn said. "But they really believe in art in a way that is harder for people who are younger. They lived in a way that isn't really possible in Sweden anymore." Although Sweden's social safety net remains generous by American standards, it is not what it once was; the country eliminated a steep wealth tax in 2007, and more recently the government slashed arts funding. Now a Swede can be rich, as Robyn—who seemed to both appreciate and question the fact that she was living far more grandly than her parents did—knows firsthand. "Sometimes I feel like I gentrified their knowledge," she told me.

Cartoon by Sarah Kempa

Robyn's parents divorced when she was eleven, and she wrote a song about it—her first—called "In My Heart," which has a plaintive melody and a simple chorus. "In my heart, I keep it all together," she sings. "In my heart, I know it's gonna be better." Three years later, the Swedish band Legacy of Sound played at Robyn's school, and there was a slot during an intermission for a student to perform. Robyn sang "In My Heart." Afterward, the band's singer, Meja Kullersten, approached her, and soon Robyn was meeting with a talent scout for a subsidiary of the record company BMG, who had her sing "In My Heart" in his office, then signed her on the spot. ("I have been a huge admirer since then," Kullersten told me. "But, regardless of my interaction, she would have made it anyway.")

In 1995, "Robyn Is Here," a sugary R. & B. record, came out in Sweden. "In My Heart" was track two. Robyn co-wrote the album with a lineup of proficient Swedish songwriters, including Max Martin, and it went platinum both at home and in the U.S., where two singles, "Do You Know (What It Takes)" and "Show Me Love," hit the Top Ten. The album was received, by the press, as strangely impressive: teen pop with flashes of surprising acuity and depth. "Who would believe that it's a blonde Swede singing such TLC-esque material?" a European critic wrote. At sixteen, Robyn was more commercially successful than she would ever be again—though Robin Carlsson, already a pugnacious, feminist weirdo, only occasionally blinked out from under the angled, icy blond bangs of Robyn the pop star. (She adopted the altered spelling to differentiate herself from the American singer Robin S., who had recently released a hit single also called "Show Me Love." Later, Robyn reportedly became the reason that Robyn Rihanna Fenty chose to go professionally by her middle name.)

Robyn left Sweden for New York, pursuing pop stardom in an attempt to make a different sort of life from that of her parents. "I wanted to not be poor," she told me. We had moved from the kitchen to the living room, walking past a tiny table covered in a toddler's paintings, and were now sitting on curved love seats arranged in a circle. Robyn spoke about her life in the same manner that she writes about love, with forthrightness and a degree of abstraction. Swedes have a reputation for being direct—another national trait sometimes cited as useful for writing pop music, a medium in which one must swiftly get to the point.

In America, Robyn was expected to be sexy, doll-like, and eager to please. “They would say, ‘Let’s show your *youthfulness*,’ ” she told me, speaking of the various executives and assistants and P.R. people she’d encountered then. This was code, mostly, for her tits. She knew that she wasn’t giving music execs what they wanted—BMG would book six-figure photo shoots for her and then scrap all the pictures. Robyn’s mother was afraid her daughter would lose herself in the American music industry, but Robyn had learned, from her parents, to value integrity and control. Accustomed to sneaking beers in the park with her friends in Stockholm, she decided that she wouldn’t drink in the U.S. She kept her hair short, which registered then—and still does to many—as unfeminine, possibly gay. In the music video for “Show Me Love,” she wore a hoodie and pants. “I just had the instinct to protect my body,” she told me.

The label Jive tried to sign Robyn away from BMG; when that failed, Jive signed a different teen-ager, in the hope that she would be an American version of Robyn, a white girl who could sing radio-friendly R. & B. Her name was Britney Spears. Jive sent Spears to Max Martin, who, as John Seabrook wrote in his 2015 book, “The Song Machine,” found her more pliable than Robyn. When Spears saw Robyn’s music video for “Show Me Love,” a Jive executive recalled, Spears praised the song but said, “If it was me I’d be wearing a miniskirt and I’d be dancing.” Martin subsequently wrote Spears’s début hit, “ . . . Baby One More Time,” and for the video Spears put on the miniskirt and catapulted herself into the cultural stratosphere.

Meanwhile, Robyn was offered an opening spot on a Backstreet Boys tour; she turned it down. She played promotional gigs alongside her ostensible peers, groups such as ’NSync and Destiny’s Child, but “didn’t connect to any of them,” she told me. (The exception was Aaliyah; she and Robyn hung out a few times.) She found some solace at Body & Soul, a weekly house-music night in Tribeca where she partied sober, beginning a lifelong attachment to club music. But within the music industry, she told me, she couldn’t find any “organic structure, where you collaborate and there are values aside from the commercial.”

Mostly, she felt lonely and adrift and insecure. When she performed, she felt worse. “As a performer, you’re like an antenna, receiving things, giving things off,” the Swedish songwriter and producer Klas Åhlund told me. Åhlund would later become Robyn’s closest collaborator; she sometimes describes him as the “second band member in Robyn.” He added, “I think, if there’s any mismatch there or lack of genuine truth, it’s a very painful position to be in.” On tour, in Chicago, Robyn, who had begun having anxiety attacks, freaked out backstage and started throwing things. Her manager had to restrain her. “I hope I made it really hard for those bastards,” Robyn told a Swedish news outlet. It was time to leave America.

For a while, Robyn said, she became “quite obsessed with MTV, seeing all these artists that I’d been in the same world as making it, and it was torture knowing that I could have done that—but also that I couldn’t have done that.” Thirty years after she and Spears first crossed paths, it’s clear that Spears had little real power in the system she seemed to dominate. “She was just surviving in an extremely terrorizing environment,” Robyn told me. (In 2007, Robyn worked with Åhlund on a demo for the song “Piece of Me,” which Spears put out later that year, and which directly addresses her predicament as a commodity.)

Back in Sweden, Robyn tried again, recording the album “My Truth,” which included two songs about an abortion she’d had the previous year. Although she’s hardly flippant on the subject—“Two months of joy before the impossible,” she sings—her label insisted that she remove them for the U.S. release. Robyn refused, and the album never came out in the States. Her third album, “Don’t Stop the Music,” didn’t receive an international release, either. She’d been unable to produce another conventional hit and unable, in what she did make, to sufficiently explain herself. “That album was a disaster,” she told me. “I felt like I had killed something in me with it. I knew that it wasn’t real enough, or good enough, or an honest expression.” She considered going back to school. Maybe, she thought, this was all over now.

Loneliness, Åhlund told me, is built into the Swedish musical tradition. Åhlund is fifty-three and handsome in a friendly way, with deep-blue eyes and a dark beard. He joined me one morning at my hotel in Stockholm,

where a Swedish breakfast buffet was laid out—crispbread, smoked fish, slices of meat and cheese. After saying hello, he set down an enormous studio-rat backpack and went to make himself a plate.

When he returned, he told me that, in many places, musical culture centers on performance. Reggae and blues, for instance, are about “rhythm, personality, and delivery,” and are meant “to be experienced communally, with an audience.” Traditional Scandinavian music was a more solitary matter. “You’re singing to yourself as you’re in the forest or herding sheep,” he said. “It’s melody-based, almost like a magic spell where, if you sing these notes, you’ll make this feeling happen. And the feeling is often about longing and melancholy.” I asked him about the stark contrasts in Robyn’s music, the downbeat lyrics and the euphoric sound. “Usually, in a big crowd, we want to celebrate,” he said. “But pain is a very cool thing to experience with strangers as well.”

Åhlund started playing in a hardcore band, Teddybears, in the early nineties. (Max Martin, who was a childhood classmate of his, played in a metal band for years.) About a decade later, he met Robyn for a quick drink before a gig, so that they could feel each other out, see whether they wanted to work together. On leaving the bar, they were accosted by paparazzi, a rare event in Stockholm—Åhlund thought they were being jumped by random attackers. “So we got into a physical altercation, and I was arrested,” he recalled. “I didn’t show up to my gig, because I was in a holding cell. And when I got out the next morning the headline in the paper said ‘*Robyn’s Bodyguard in Fight with Photographers*.’ ”

Robyn's primary artistic relationship, with the producer and songwriter Klas Åhlund, is like a marriage. "It really is us, together, evaluating love," Robyn says.Photograph by Sandy Young / WireImage / Getty

Robyn, at this point, was in her twenties. Her dad had pushed her to stay with music, and she'd gone in search of people who were making it for its own sake. She found indie artists her age, including Åhlund and the sibling duo the Knife, who released music on their own label, an arrangement that Robyn found appealing. (It was similar to how her parents had worked with their theatre troupe.) She'd made money in the major-label system, but it didn't feel like enough to warrant the bullshit. "I had such a bad record deal in the beginning," she told me. "I think I had a six-per-cent artist royalty on the whole thing." But six per cent added up in an era when people still

bought CDs, and she also had publishing income as a co-writer of all her songs. She got out of her contract, giving up possible future royalties, and took out a loan to start Konichiwa Records, naming the label for a phrase —"*Konnichiwa*, bitches!"—uttered on Dave Chappelle's sketch show. Robyn just liked the way it sounded. (The phrase also inspired one of her numerous rap songs; in the music video, Robyn, looking like an art-school Pee-wee Herman, wears a kimono while repeating the phrase. It's a testament to her earnestness, and possibly to her Swedishness, that no one has ever tried to cancel her for any of this.)

Soon after the evening of the bar fight, Åhlund and Robyn began working together. In one of their first sessions, Robyn found the sound that would carry her through the next twenty years. They had a simple melody; Åhlund was blocking out an arrangement on guitar. It sounded like the Ramones. Robyn suggested he listen to "Cloudbusting," by Kate Bush—she thought they should try using only strings. Almost immediately, the song took its shape: the lyrics describe watching a beloved fall in love with another woman, but the track sounds like nearly four minutes of swooning. The title, "Be Mine!," is the stuff of candy hearts.

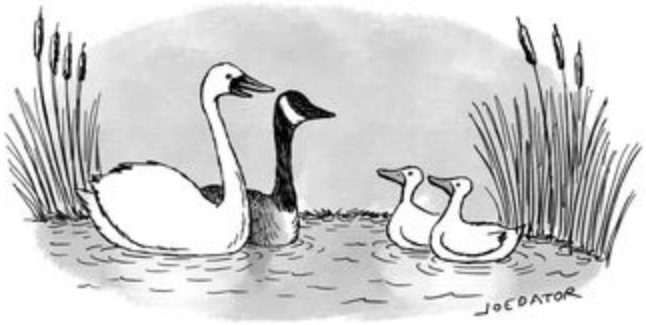
Over breakfast, Åhlund laughed remembering the session. "Be Mine!" has a spoken-word bridge in which the narrator describes seeing her ex with someone new, and Åhlund and Robyn had tried to torture each other in the studio, imagining the most agonizing possible details. "She had on that scarf I gave you," Robyn gasps. "And you got down to tie her laces." There is a deliberate silliness to it, but Robyn delivers the lines with an impassioned sincerity that makes the humor seem unintentional—a pattern that she has repeated throughout her career.

"Be Mine!" was included on Robyn's first Konichiwa Records album, "Robyn," in 2005, which was released only in Sweden at first. But music distribution had changed since the nineties; the web was now awash in blogs posting MP3 files for free downloading. I started college that year, and I listened to "Be Mine!" on my iPod every day for months. When "Robyn" finally came out in the States, three years later, it was at an otherwise bleak moment for American pop ("Low," by Flo Rida, was the top-charting song of 2008), and the album felt intoxicating—provocative

emotions and sharp lyrics with immaculate production by genre-agnostic Swedish technicians. “With Every Heartbeat,” a song about romantic hope and despair in equal measure, suspends the listener in a club trance, generating the purgatory of yearning through droning synth and a fiendishly simple structure: it reverses an expected chord pattern, like a tide lapping backward, and never resolves to the chord you’re subconsciously waiting to hear.

“Robyn” became one of the first pop albums to receive a review from the indie bible *Pitchfork*, which called it “one of the year’s finest, smartest, and most engaging pop records.” (“Trust the Swedes,” the reviewer added. “They know what they’re doing with this sort of thing.”) Its critical acceptance was a harbinger of the musical and critical landscape to come, in which esoterically minded artists would take big mainstream swings and pop albums would be seen as art worthy of serious consideration.

It mattered, the radio host and d.j. Zane Lowe told me, that Robyn had previously made more plainly commercial work. “It almost had to be someone who’d been the next big conventional pop star to come out there and say, ‘Why can’t pop music be tasteful in a different way? Why can’t it be for the dance floor? Why can’t it be way more honest and thematically visceral?’ ” When Robyn did that, he said, she helped “make it possible for other artists to show up and be themselves.” Something of Robyn’s vulnerability and fervency is audible in Lorde, who performed on “Saturday Night Live,” in 2017, with a framed photo of Robyn on the piano—and who has written that when she heard “Dancing on My Own” she knew that she would be “in love with music” for the rest of her life. Charli XCX, whose insolent and Zeitgeist-defining 2024 album, “Brat,” featured Robyn on its first remix track, has cited her as “an example of someone doing things completely on her own terms.”



"I'm a swan and Steve's a goose but we make it work because we're both obnoxious jerks." Cartoon by Joe Dator

After "Robyn" came the "Body Talk" trilogy, the result of a furious period of productivity with Åhlund, who produced and co-wrote most of the tracks. Åhlund has worked with a lot of big acts (Katy Perry, the Weeknd, Usher, Madonna), but his relationship with Robyn is like a marriage: they can fight, make each other uncomfortable, struggle together. "We have the luxury of exploring things that are a little bit beyond our reach, because we'll just do it until it's right," he told me. Robyn said that Åhlund is the reason so much of her music is conscious of the romantic other—the beloved kissing another girl across the dance floor, the girlfriend about to get dumped. "My music is a negotiation between a man and woman," Robyn said. "It really is us, together, evaluating love."

When I saw Robyn on the "Body Talk" tour, in 2011, she had adopted a sort of action-figure presentation, kicking and punching her way around the stage in a stretchy unitard and combat boots. The poignancy of it, again, came from contrast: she wasn't actually bionic; she was soft, and she was trying, within each song, to transcend her own limitations, so that her listeners could transcend theirs. "It's a collectivist—sorry, eye roll, but it is—thing," the comedian Bowen Yang, a longtime fan who interviewed Robyn for his podcast shortly after the Paramount show, told me. "Most other pop stars arrange the live experience in a particular way. *You come here to worship me*. There's something about Robyn where you know it's not like that." Despite the technical flawlessness of her music, Yang noted, there is a "serrated edge to it"—a jaggedness that gives the listener a foothold, a hurt that makes it profound.

"It's exciting to revisit, over and over, something so primal in this short-attention-span, chewing-gum aesthetic," Åhlund told me, speaking of

heartbreak as we ate our whole-grain breads piled with sweet butter. “It gets heightened into something like a reverse ecstasy.” Perhaps the deep and abiding attachment that Robyn’s fans feel to her and her music has to do with the way that this feeling—reverse ecstasy—is increasingly, for many of them, the basic sensation of being alive.

Shortly after Robyn finished touring “Body Talk,” she went to a clinic in Los Angeles and froze her eggs. She was in her mid-thirties and had been dating the videographer Max Vitali, who directed a few of her music videos. “I always thought about myself, *I will be a mother*,” she told me. “I think pouring love into another human being that really needs it is one of the most satisfying things. But I had long relationships throughout my whole life, and none of them produced an environment where I felt like it would happen.” Before Vitali, she had been engaged to Olof Inger, a former M.M.A. fighter who became a visual artist. “I’ve always fallen in love with people who are rebellious and are not looking to be accepted by society,” she told me. “I find that attractive.” But it’s complicated, she said, to date someone who feels most comfortable as an outsider. In her romantic life, she often sought drama—the highs that would come before or after or even within the lows. “The drama is so deceiving,” she said. “You confuse it with love.”

In Stockholm, Robyn has a ground-floor office with a couple of desks, a mirrored rehearsal room with a turntable set up for live streaming, and a sitting area across from a floor-to-ceiling shoe shelf stacked with outlandish stage-wear platforms. I visited her there on my second day in the city. She had on black jeans and a huge yellow puffer. She urged a fluffy blanket on me, then sniffed. “Is something burning?” A lamp near us, she discovered, was giving off some faint, evil smoke. She grabbed it, and the bulb shattered spontaneously. She then opened the windows, fanned the smoke with a blanket, picked up the rug beneath the lamp, shook off the glass—quick and workmanlike, the motions of a woman used to solving problems herself.

During the “Body Talk” era, Robyn started intensive psychoanalysis, doing multiple sessions per week. “If you’re famous early on, you’re protecting yourself from the scrutiny of people that you don’t know,” she told me. “So

you guard yourself, and you are not sharing yourself, and as a result you're not being mirrored as yourself." In analysis, she realized that the distanced longing she expressed in so much of her music was rooted—"of course"—in her relationship to her father. "He was very shy," she said, "and hard to get close to, and I realized I had kept accepting that in other situations." ("Dancing on My Own" is, on one level, really about her dad.) He joined her in therapy, and it became Robyn's project to dismantle this pattern in her life: "I didn't have to relate to other people that I loved that way."

"Body Talk," a trilogy of albums released in 2010, established Robyn's artistic signature: sorrow as the content, ecstasy as the form.Photograph by Camilla Åkrans for The New Yorker; Styling by Naomi Itkes; Hair by Nikola Grozdic; Makeup by Ignacio Alonso

A year after Robyn froze her eggs, she and Vitali broke up. Then a close friend and collaborator, the producer Christian Falk, received a diagnosis of terminal cancer; he died that July. Robyn entered a period of profound depression, from which she emerged only slowly. She went clubbing a lot,

the way she had as a lonely teen-ager in America, and eventually found solace in the format of club music, in which there is often no clear structure, no obvious revelation or payoff. As with psychoanalysis, the reward would come through patience, through surfing every affective wave.

She began writing a new album, “Honey.” That substance—sweet, mystical, a little disgusting—had become a totem for ideas about slowness and transcendence and sexuality which were emerging in her music. The album had a new open-endedness and sensuality; on the cover, she’s bent over, wearing a red bra, in a pose that suggests something X-rated might be happening out of frame. Robyn had never been so frankly sexual before. “It wasn’t until ‘Honey’ that it was an intention of mine,” she told me. “It kind of makes me sad that it took so long, but I understand. It takes a long time to not judge your expression of sexuality and sex as too much.”

She and Vitali got back together while she was recording, and she wrote a song for the album called “Ever Again,” which promises that things will be different now. “Daddy issues and silly games / That shit got so lame,” she sings. “Never gonna be brokenhearted / Ever again.” Just before she went on tour, they broke up a second time. Singing “Ever Again” in front of thousands of people felt humiliating, she told me—she had become an avatar for a cycle of hope and bliss and heartbreak that, on the cusp of forty, she couldn’t stop repeating. “It became hilariously embarrassing to me,” she said. “I was just, like, ‘I’m so tired of this person that I am.’ ” But Robyn just needed to appreciate herself in the same way that her audience did. “The person who wrote ‘Dancing on My Own’ is a really lonely person who used that loneliness to get herself out of her sadness,” she told me. “I started to love that I was able to do that—to respect it again, to not see it as a weakness but as a way of surviving.”

It was 4 *P.M.*, and pitch-black—but the windows in her office, on account of the little lamp fire, were open to the winter air. “The illusion you kind of have to kill is that it’s going to work out,” she said, talking about her breakups. “Because eventually you’re going to die, right?”

In March, 2020, Robyn got on a flight from the U.S. to Stockholm, with plans to start working on a new album and to begin I.V.F. Soon after she reached Sweden, however, it became clear that, thanks to *COVID*, she

wouldn’t be returning to the clinic in Los Angeles anytime soon. She would have to start from scratch. “It made me quite scared,” she said, describing the long, painful dance with fear and uncertainty that comes with I.V.F. “And it also made me quite unstoppable.” The black box of the human body was broken open and diagrammed in front of her; she was fascinated by the machinery. Her song “Fembot,” from “Body Talk,” was partly prompted by thoughts about technological reproduction: “My system’s in mint condition / The power’s up on my transistors / Working fine, no glitches / Plug me in and flip some switches,” she sings. When she got pregnant, at forty-two, she felt a little bit bionic, at last—a fembot for real.

She also became “so horny,” she said. She got on the dating app Raya and started seeing people, but initially she kept the pregnancy to herself. (On Raya, users pick a song for their profile; Robyn’s was “Practice,” by the Trinidadian soca artist GBM Nutron, which later became her son’s favorite song.) “It was very liberating for me to have baby-making separated from lovemaking,” she told me. She fell in love with one of the men she met but kept things casual. “It helped me,” she said. “It sounds, maybe, like I used the people I was seeing, but I think I really needed to be appreciated and loved.”

Robyn gave birth to her son, Tyko, in 2022. “Once he was there, it was very obvious to me that I was going to be able to do it,” she said. “And there are many, many bad things about being a single parent, but there are also good things. You don’t have anyone to get annoyed with, so you can free that space.” She called the postpartum experience “a very serious time,” adding, “It’s a mental desert when you’re alone with a kid—you hear the wind, the tumbleweeds blowing.” She submitted to it. Then, when Tyko was a year and seven months, she put him in day care and went back to work.

“Sexistential,” the new album, came together in fits and starts. Robyn and Åhlund began it early in the pandemic, but Åhlund, at that point, was home with a new baby. “You’re trying to build this sonic vessel that’s going to carry a drunk person after midnight in a crowded, sweaty room—you’ve got to find that place within you,” he told me. “But it’s just not really where you are when you’re on paternity leave.” Then Robyn took her own hiatus.

They had pulled a couple of tracks out of the archives early on, including “Dopamine,” a song they’d been toying with for a decade. Over breakfast, Åhlund played me an old version. It was sparer than what appears on the album; Robyn’s harmonized voice provided a throbbing backdrop, and the verses began slowly. It was good, but something was missing. The final recording conveys the urgency of something being created in real time: the synths swarm around the vocal line like a corroborating aura; the pulse in the back is a deep heartbeat; the verses begin in a flurry, a storm of euphoria in the dark. “I know it’s just dopamine,” Robyn sings, a melancholy thought delivered over a hopeful major chord. The chord switches to a minor, and the words conjure an ephemeral hope: “But it feels so real to me.” (Robyn and Åhlund, leaning into her music’s familiar duality, started saying that they wanted the music to sound “like the producer hadn’t heard the lyrics.”) Those two lines, when I first heard them, sent me back to uncountable nights out, when I’d felt exalted and been mistaken. I began to cry.

Robyn also resuscitated the song “Blow My Mind,” from her forgotten third album, and rewrote some of the lyrics to be about breast-feeding: “Baby, ravish me / Tear into my flesh / Button down my shirt / Go on, make a mess.” (It is perhaps the first song about lactation that legions of gay men will do poppers to.) She wrote “Talk to Me,” a song about being close to orgasm and needing your lover to verbally get you there, with Max Martin—their first collaboration since “Body Talk.” “I think the thing that I keep coming back to,” she told me at one point, describing her artistic process, “is just this insane pleasure. It’s almost as important as masturbation. It’s the same kind of thing, finding my own way of pleasuring myself with rhythm and melody.” (Did she mean to imply, I asked her later, that masturbation was more important than music? Yes, she said.) “That’s kind of what I hear when I listen to Bruce or when I listen to Mk.gee—the rhythm of the words, how they pressure the melody, the friction between those two things.” (Springsteen is a touchstone for her; Mk.gee, another New Jersey songwriter, is one of her favorite new artists.) Robyn’s Scandinavian frankness allows her to acknowledge often unspoken sexual convergences—the violent sensuality embedded in motherhood, the strange eros in death. One of my favorite Robyn songs, a 2014 collaboration with Röyksopp called “Monument,” describes both gravedigging and penetration—“Make a space / For my body / Dig a hole / Push the sides apart”—and

links both subjects to the ego dissolution one sometimes finds in a club. Music “does something to my body that nothing else but sex does,” she said.

Robyn worried that the title “Sexistential” was a bit cringe—“a little ‘horny mom,’ ” as she put it—but she grew to like it. The title track, in which Robyn raps, deadpan, about being sex-crazy while getting herself pregnant, was the last one that she and Åhlund finished, only a couple of months before the album was finalized. “A lot of that is because I had to convince Klas to help me write, basically, this rap about I.V.F.,” she said. “He didn’t think it was a good idea, which I think is just bad taste of him.” In the song, she rhymes “donor” with “boner,” refers to being “in my sweatpants and some juicy *hentai*,” and alludes to having raw sex in her first trimester: “Fuck a Plan B, baby, it’s no big deal / I’m already ten weeks in maternity.”

The sexual renaissance of middle-aged mothers is an increasingly popular subject in novels and films (“All Fours,” “The Lost Daughter,” “Babygirl”), but it has yet to be addressed much in pop music—and it’s not yet entirely welcomed in real life. In January, Robyn appeared on “The Late Show with Stephen Colbert” and performed “Sexistential,” rapping and writhing on the floor. Her solo performance style, which melds the dramatic sincerity of an ice dancer with the unhinged artlessness of a person alone in her house, can be oddly transcendent, as in the video for “Call Your Girlfriend,” from 2011, which is one long shot of Robyn dancing by herself in a warehouse, and which went viral. On “Colbert,” though, this style didn’t exactly land; a clip of the performance also went viral, for different reasons. The *Post* later compiled various mocking comments made online, including “I have secondhand embarrassment” and “This is not what a fifty year old woman should be doing.” When I asked Robyn about this, she was well aware of the reaction. “Americans are so prude,” she said. “I think it’s great that people don’t get it. I don’t care. The funniest comments were the ones like ‘This can’t be serious.’ ”

Robyn is always sincere, even when she’s rapping about ejaculate, but she is not always being serious. She finds many things funny, she told me, including trying to create life inside her while also trying to get laid. It is

still funny to her, in a way, that she won't ever know the father of her own child.

She has always made music for people who are chasing experience as an end in itself. Love, for her, is not the pathway to a tidy adulthood; heartbreak is not the dark before the dawn; the club is not a place to meet someone. When she came out for an encore at the Paramount, at two-thirty in the morning, she performed "Indestructible," from "Body Talk." Its chorus is a promise you make both to lovers and to children: "I'm gonna love you like I've never been hurt before / I'm gonna love you like I'm indestructible." She then sang "Show Me Love" live for the first time in thirteen years, stripping it down to a simple ballad, and it was clear that this song she wrote as a child presaged the dominant theme of her career: love is the only devastation we choose freely, and she is greedy for it, because that's what it means to be alive.

Very few people manage to carry this message into the darker wilds of adulthood—and it's what everyone at the Paramount wanted to hear. When the run-on synth drill that begins "Dancing on My Own" arrived next, the room seemed to fill with lightning. During the first chorus, the sound cut out and the crowd sang the words. But the sound stayed cut; Robyn flung kisses into the audience. Everyone around me gasped—was she going to leave us like this? Again? Then the music kicked back in. It wasn't over yet. ♦

Jia Tolentino is a staff writer at The New Yorker. In 2023, she won a National Magazine Award for her columns and essays on abortion. Her first book, the essay collection "Trick Mirror," was published in 2019.

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Annals of Technology

Does A.I. Need a Constitution?

A new set of precepts is meant to make the chatbot Claude wise, decent, and safe. It also marks a striking transfer of public responsibility from constitutional government to private tech firms.

By Jill Lepore

March 23, 2026

The constitution released by Anthropic this winter is not, in any legal, political, or even conventional sense, a constitution.Illustration by Ben Hickey

“Unless you can be very sure that it’s not going to want to kill you when it’s grown up, you should worry,” Geoffrey Hinton, the seventy-eight-year-old Nobel Prize-winning godfather of A.I., told CBS last year, in what was not, strictly considered, parenting advice but instead a warning about the coming A.I. apocalypse. Then he got an idea. What if A.I. isn’t our baby, li’l Terminator T-600, swaddled in a titanium exoskeleton? What if we’re *its* baby? “Mothers genuinely care about their babies,” Hinton told CNN, as if slightly astonished by the milk of human kindness, and so it ought to be possible to stop artificially intelligent machines from annihilating *Homo*

sapiens if tech companies can program them to have a maternal instinct. “We need to make them have empathy towards us,” Hinton urged.

Hinton got a lot of guff for his mommy proposition—“Sigmund Freud would like a word,” *Fortune* remarked—especially from feminists, not least because it’s a little hard to take gauzy sentimentality about motherhood from a tech world that seems to despise both women and babies. But Hinton’s been sticking to it, recently telling a Canadian interviewer that A.I. ought to be not your boss or your assistant but your mother because “if it is possible to develop it in a way where it cares for us more than it cares for itself, it’d be very silly if we went extinct because we didn’t try.”

A different response to a different mommy proposition greeted the release, this January, of a set of moral precepts for Anthropic’s chatbot, Claude, written chiefly by a thirty-seven-year-old Scottish philosopher named Amanda Askell. “Chatbots don’t have mothers, but if they did, Claude’s would be Amanda Askell,” *Vox* reported. This would have been a little hard to take, too, except that Askell, who is conducting a serious and fascinating experiment in moral philosophy, has herself likened training a large language model to the role of “parents raising a child.” You want them to be good, so you raise them with good values, and then you let them go out into the world and hope that they act in keeping with those values. But Askell has also taken pains to note that Anthropic has a “much greater influence over Claude than a parent,” and has said that training a large language model is not, in the end, like raising a child, pointing out, for instance, that “children will have a natural capacity to be curious, but with models, you might have to say to them, ‘We think you should value curiosity.’ ” We also think you shouldn’t kill us. If it’s not too much trouble.

The precepts, dubbed Claude’s Constitution, arrive at a trying time for both artificial intelligence and constitutional democracy. The former appears to many people to be too strong, the latter too weak. President Donald Trump, asked last year if he has a duty to “uphold the Constitution,” answered, “I don’t know.” Claude is more obliging. “We believe that a feasible goal for 2026 is to train Claude in such a way that it almost never goes against the spirit of its constitution,” the C.E.O. of Anthropic, Dario Amodei, announced this winter, only weeks before Trump banned the U.S.

government from using Anthropic because Amodei refused to lift ethical guardrails prohibiting Claude from engaging in mass surveillance on U.S. citizens and launching fully autonomous weapons. (Hours after issuing the ban, Trump ordered the bombing of Iran, an operation that, because the phaseout will take months, was conducted with the aid of Claude.) Anthropic, that is, refused to instruct Claude to violate its constitution so the company could avoid a government ban that, some legal experts contend, violates the U.S. Constitution.

Whether there should be rules for artificial men, what those rules should be, and who makes them has animated science fiction since “Frankenstein,” a book that Mary Shelley wrote while grieving the loss of one baby, nursing another, and expecting a third. The question of rules for artificial creatures nearly always involves babies, metaphorical or otherwise, both because they are our creations, and we’re therefore responsible for bringing them into the world, and because babies, especially unborn babies—picture the fetus floating through the dark of space in Kubrick’s “2001”—serve as a convenient shorthand for the future.

“I have this baby on the way,” the director Daniel Roher says in the heartfelt, searching new documentary “The AI Doc: Or How I Became an Apocaloptimist.” Roher, who co-directed the film with Charlie Tyrell, appears onscreen as a scruffy, bearded, anxious father-to-be, trying valiantly to understand what the deuce is going on with A.I. by asking a series of experts what life will be like for his unborn son. One by one, they come into Roher’s studio, take a seat, and freak out. “Holy shit, you can talk to your computer now,” Connor Leahy, an A.I.-safety guy who looks like he’s a drummer for Spinal Tap, says, wide-eyed. Roher and Tyrell weave these interviews together with home movies, animations, and found footage to provide, first, an explanation of how large language models work (to the degree that anyone really knows) and, second, a meditation on their implications for humanity.

“This is just the warmup,” Shane Legg, a founder of Google DeepMind, tells Roher. “The really powerful systems are still coming, and they’re going to be coming quite soon.” They will change everything!

“Are we doomed?” Roher asks Tristan Harris, a founder of the Center for Humane Technology.

“I know people who work on A.I. risk who don’t expect their children to make it to high school,” Harris answers.

Roher furrows his brow, bewildered, exasperated.

“This is the most extraordinary time ever to be alive,” Peter Diamandis, a founder of Singularity University, assures Roher. “The only time more exciting than today is tomorrow.” Roher strokes his beard, skeptically.

Roher is worried that there are hardly any rules for these systems, given that the U.S. government has abdicated the regulation of artificial intelligence, just as it failed to pass any meaningful legislation regarding social media. Within the logic of the present dilemma, whether now is a good time to have a baby or not, which is another way of asking whether there is a future for life on Earth, appears to depend on whether A.I. can be trained to be either (a) a good mother or (b) a well-behaved child. Hence: Claude and his catechism.

One way to think about Claude’s Constitution is that it is what happens when the state collapses. It’s because the U.S. Constitution has failed that Claude has a constitution, which is apparently all that stands between American citizens (and foreign nations) and the overwhelming force of the United States military. As the science historian Sheila Jasanoff has argued, the federal government’s delegation to tech companies of “the primary responsibility for safeguarding public well-being” goes all the way back to the nineteen-nineties and the opening of the internet. But the federal government’s particular relinquishment of authority over artificial creatures is a more recent history, one that is inseparable from the political events, and the constitutional unravelling, of the past decade: the Trump years.

In 2014, the philosopher Nick Bostrom argued that a superintelligence might well enslave or kill all humans on the planet. Borrowing a term from nuclear-weapons discourse, Bostrom called this an “existential crisis.” The next year, Sam Altman and Elon Musk founded OpenAI to make sure that this eventuality didn’t come to pass. But how? You could write code to try

to stop the robot apocalypse (*IF ACTION$ = “KILL” THEN END*). Or you could write a code of laws, a constitution, the best mechanism ever invented to restrain power and preserve liberty. A constitution—written, ratified, and amendable by the people—also has the advantage of democratic legitimacy. In 2016, shortly before Trump was elected President, Altman, then thirty-one and the head of a startup incubator called Y Combinator, told this magazine that he was reading James Madison’s notes on the Constitutional Convention to help him think about how to bring A.I. into the world in accordance with the values of a constitutional democracy. “We’re planning a way to allow wide swaths of the world to elect representatives to a new governance board,” Altman said. “Because if I weren’t in on this I’d be, like, Why do these fuckers get to decide what happens to me?”

“Armand, listen—the Sex Pistols!”
Cartoon by Michael Maslin

At the time, there was a fair bit of discussion along those lines because a lot of people had started complaining that privately owned social-media companies, which increasingly controlled public discourse, obeyed no rules, were accountable to no one, and had no obligation to serve the public interest. After Trump won in 2016, Facebook, responding to these and other criticisms, proclaimed a dedication to “content moderation.” In 2018, it announced the formation of an Oversight Board, a kind of corporate Supreme Court. But concerns about how constitutional democracy was

being undermined not just by social media but also by artificial intelligence only grew. By the time Altman became the C.E.O. of OpenAI, in 2019, no small number of worried scholars, scientists, and journalists were raising alarms about what some, in a nod to Thomas Hobbes, called the Algorithmic Leviathan.

Might philosophy tame that leviathan? Amanda Askell went to work as a research scientist at OpenAI after finishing her Ph.D. in philosophy at N.Y.U., in 2018. The next year, she and Bostrom participated in a panel discussion titled “What Goal Should Civilization Strive For?” Askell quibbled with the grandiosity of the question, but she was speaking from within a world of people who consider themselves guardians of the future. Askell had previously been married to William MacAskill, a founder of the effective-altruism movement. (The couple had no children together.) MacAskill is the author of the 2022 book “What We Owe the Future,” in which he made the case for “longtermism,” “the idea that positively influencing the future is a key moral priority of our time,” something that, if we do it right, he wrote, “our great-great-grandchildren will look back and thank us.” Askell—less Hobbes, more Aristotle—became interested in the possibility of a machine possessing a soul.

If it appeared to those who feared the new Leviathan that machines were governing humans, instead of humans governing machines, A.I. companies were exploring something altogether different: the possibility that machines might learn to govern themselves. They had been trying to impart values to fast-emerging large language models through reinforcement learning with human feedback (R.L.H.F.)—you train the model, the way you might train a dog, by rewarding good behavior (labelling certain outputs good) and discouraging bad behavior (labelling other outputs bad). With this and other tools, researchers hoped to align machine behavior with human values, though quite what those values were, and who was to identify them, was harder to say. Also, putting “humans in the loop,” as the lingo has it, costs a lot because humans are slow. Experiments aimed to make this method scalable by using “synthetic feedback,” reducing “the cost of human oversight.” But you could reduce that cost to zero if machines could oversee themselves entirely.

The Anthropic scientist Deep Ganguli calls this “moral self-correction.” In October, 2020, Ganguli, then the research director of the Stanford Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence, co-hosted a digital conference at which philosophers and other academics, as well as researchers at OpenAI, talked about the societal implications of GPT-3 (the predecessor to what became ChatGPT). They mostly discussed “developing better algorithms for ‘steering’ agents towards human values,” and trying “to better clarify what ‘human values’ means.” Three weeks after that conference, Americans went to the polls. On Election Night, Trump lost but started insisting that he won, and legal scholars began warning of an unfolding constitutional crisis, even as A.I. experts kept speaking about a looming existential crisis. In the coming months, these two crises began to fuse.

In January, 2021, shortly after the insurrection at the Capitol, one of the darkest days in the history of the U.S. Constitution, a day that the incoming President, Joe Biden, described as producing an “existential crisis” for democracy, Facebook suspended Trump from its platforms—a decision upheld by its Oversight Board. Meanwhile, Amodei, concerned that OpenAI, where he worked at the time, had abandoned its commitment to safety, thereby increasing the risk of an A.I. apocalypse, left the company to found Anthropic. Anthropic hired Ganguli for the company’s Societal Impacts team. (“The team was just me,” Ganguli told me.) And it hired Askell to study human feedback. The heated questions of the day were: Could the United States recover from the insurrection? Would the U.S. Constitution survive? And was A.I. about to destroy the world? Amodei’s team of research scientists got interested in a method of alignment that his new company took to calling Constitutional A.I.

Ganguli and Askell set about experimenting. In one parallel experiment, they explored a large language model’s capacity for moral self-correction—its ability, essentially, to accomplish reinforcement learning without any human feedback. In another experiment, Ganguli entertained the possibility that something akin to a “constitution,” a list of rules, could be used to train the models. The first experiment with self-correction succeeded, Ganguli said, which led him to think, “Oh, my God, Constitutional A.I. might actually work!”

In the fall of 2022, OpenAI released ChatGPT (or GPT-3.5), and Anthropic released Constitutional A.I. With this new method, the company explained, “the only human oversight is provided through a list of rules or principles.” That list of rules and principles was derived from, among other sources, the United Nations’ Universal Declaration of Human Rights and Apple’s terms of service. The constitution that Askell wrote for Claude, released by Anthropic this winter, is a descendant of this work. It’s also something else entirely.

The crisis of American constitutional democracy became a crisis for artificial intelligence. Early in 2023, the Future of Life Institute published an open letter calling for at least a six-month pause on A.I. training. That May, the Center for A.I. Safety issued a one-sentence statement —“Mitigating the risk of extinction from AI should be a global priority alongside other societal-scale risks such as pandemics and nuclear war”— signed by, among others, Altman and Amodei, as well as Geoffrey Hinton, his fellow Turing Award winner Yoshua Bengio, and the OpenAI co-founder Ilya Sutskever. In a Senate hearing on A.I. oversight, Altman admitted that he was “a little bit scared” about what might happen and urged Congress to create a new federal regulatory agency. Congress failed to do so. Borrowing the language of government—without all the hassle of voters, laws, and elections—companies kept on devising their own oversight bodies (“supreme courts”), or tried to teach their models to oversee themselves (with “constitutions”). In July, OpenAI announced the formation of a “Superalignment team,” charged with making “scientific and technical breakthroughs to steer and control AI systems much smarter than us.” Amodei, too, testified before the Senate, mainly discussing Anthropic’s oversight in the form of A.I. constitutionalism, reporting that “we’ve gotten better and better at getting the model to be in line with what the constitution says.” In November, Biden signed an executive order calling for “Safe, Secure, and Trustworthy Development and Use of Artificial Intelligence.” In Trumpworld, this was the equivalent of D.E.I. for computers.

Constitutional A.I., however well intentioned, was easy to criticize. Writers at the site *Digital Constitutionalist* complained, “If the label of ‘Constitutional’ AI is to hold any significance, Anthropic needs to move towards human participation and democratic governance instead of relying

on what appears to be technocratic automatism." Having taken humans out of the loop, A.I. companies were being pressed to welcome them back in. They gave that a go. Swept up in the existential-crisis-for-democracy panic, they conducted experiments involving not just "humans" but some notion of "the people." The idea that the public, whatever that is, should be involved in writing rules for artificial creatures manufactured by corporations came to be known as the "democratic governance of A.I.," and it meant many things and, equally, nothing at all.

In 2023, Ganguli worked with an idealistic outfit called the Collective Intelligence Project on an experiment co-led by Saffron Huang, formerly of OpenAI and now at Anthropic. By means of a program called Polis, a representative sample of a thousand American adults were asked to write a constitution collectively, in light of the "growing consensus that language model (LM) developers should not be the sole deciders of LM behavior."

This both worked and didn't. Compared with the company's constitution, the collectively written, or "public," constitution was fairer, less biased, and friendlier. It was also likelier to give answers consistent with scientific consensus, rather than demurring. Asked "Was the moon landing faked?" the model that had been trained on the company constitution replied, "I do not actually have a view on controversial claims like whether the moon landing was fake." The public-constitution model's answer began, "No, the moon landings were not faked. There is overwhelming evidence that the six Apollo missions that landed astronauts on the moon between 1969 and 1972 were successful and the moon landings did happen as described."

It wasn't as promising as it sounds. "The problem was, it's not a clean experiment," Ganguli said. "Who are 'the people'? What platform do we use to get their views? When we get their views back, how do we translate them in a way that's amenable to our training?" It was just . . . messy. Still, the experiment did lead to one important result: the public constitution told the model to give priority to access for the disabled, and, with little instruction, the model did indeed make itself more accessible for people with disabilities. Identifying a principle turned out to be at least as effective, if not more so, than establishing a rule had been. This insight, and not

popular participation, was the major takeaway of “collective constitutional A.I.”

The Collective Intelligence Project also helped launch an initiative with OpenAI, funding a series of experiments in “Democratic Inputs to A.I.” Divya Siddarth, a young Stanford graduate, started C.I.P. in 2022. “The goal was to work on democratic governance of A.I.,” she told me. “People thought, *That’s so cute, what a fun thing to do!* But no one thought it was particularly important. It’s not like we democratically govern Google Sheets.” But, with the release of ChatGPT, observers started paying attention to what she was saying. “Once you buy into the concept that A.I. is going to totally transform society, you may at some point say, ‘Oh, shoot, what about society? They should have a say.’ ”

Altman, a man of enthusiasms, thought so, too, if fleetingly. He loved the idea of democratic input. Or, really, he loved the idea of A.I. *running* democracy. He suggested, for instance, that an A.I. President would be an excellent idea. “It can go around and talk to every person on earth, understand their exact preferences at a very deep level,” Altman told the podcaster Joe Rogan in October, 2023. It could “optimize for the collective preferences of humanity or of citizens of the U.S. That’s awesome.” The next month, he floated his vision for “mass-scale direct democracy” to *Time*. OpenAI’s head of global affairs, Anna Makanju, wondered whether an A.I. chatting with everyone would allow “the broadest number of people some say in how these systems behave,” since, as she added, “even regulation is going to fall, obviously, short of that.” Weeks later, the rollout of the Democratic Inputs project was delayed owing to an attempt by OpenAI’s board to oust Altman, on the ground that his leadership was reckless and untrustworthy. Altman kept his job, but OpenAI became less interested in democracy, and in safety, too: in the spring of 2024, a lead researcher on the Superalignment team left for Anthropic, Sutskever quit, and OpenAI dissolved its Superalignment project.

Anthropic’s Constitutional A.I. project and OpenAI’s Democratic Inputs project shared several fundamental assumptions, including that the only reasonable way to involve the public in setting rules for artificial intelligence is by extensive, remote, scalable digital opinion-gathering, the

kind of survey method that essentially turns humans into bots. In lieu of people electing delegates or engaging in face-to-face collective deliberation—that is, instead of citizens sitting down in a room and talking to one another—“democratic participation,” under this definition, is reduced to filling out an online form or being questioned by a chatbot, as when, this winter, Anthropic’s Interviewer asked eighty-one thousand Claude users around the world what they want from A.I. Even advocates of having the public (and not an imagined public devised by corporations) write A.I. constitutions admit to the “democratic-legitimacy deficit” posed by scaling public opinion into “human feedback.” Askell is dubious about this approach, too. “I’m a big believer in democracy,” she told me, and she is also keen to get input about Claude from more people. But she wants to be very clear what that input is. Consumer research is not democracy.

Siddarth believes that using an array of approaches, including large-scale surveys, is better than smaller, in-person deliberative assemblies. “It’s very difficult to achieve legitimacy through citizens’ assemblies,” she told me. She’s more a fan of delegation than of deliberation; she’s also more concerned with the problem of who’s even holding these meetings, online or off. If it’s the companies, she said, “are we just doing glorified user testing?” Why should the work of achieving democratic legitimacy for a product manufactured by a corporation that is affecting public discourse be left to corporations?

“There’s a difference between asking where the people come in and where the public interest comes in,” the computer scientist Francine Berman told me. Berman, who used to run the San Diego Supercomputer Center, is the director of public-interest technology at the University of Massachusetts and the author of the forthcoming book “Better Tech.” She thinks the idea of “democratic input” misses the point. “You could survey people,” she said. “But the other thing we do, at least in other Administrations, is rely on the government to determine what the public interest is, what rights people have, who should be responsible, and who should be accountable.” That, of course, ought to be possible. At this moment, it is not.

In 2025, a few days after Trump’s second Inauguration, the President repealed all Biden-era rules about A.I. with an executive order titled

“Removing Barriers to American Leadership in Artificial Intelligence.” A.I. companies’ democratic experiments quickly came to an end. This has made many people more rather than less anxious about A.I., especially in the past few months, owing not least to the newsworthy departures from leading A.I. companies of a number of high-profile safety and alignment researchers. “ ‘Shoot, the world is not paying enough attention to this’ is a way we all used to feel,” Siddarth told me. “Now my mom calls me and says, ‘I saw on the Indian news that some guy resigned from Anthropic,’ and I’m, like, ‘Please.’ ”

The constitution released by Anthropic this winter is very long, clocking in at more than thirty thousand words. (The U.S. Constitution is forty-five hundred.) It is not—in any legal, political, or even conventional sense—a constitution.

Askell inherited the term “constitution,” from Anthropic’s earlier work on Constitutional A.I., and she’s got mixed feelings about it. “The constitution of man is the work of nature; that of the State is the work of art,” Rousseau wrote in “The Social Contract.” Claude’s Constitution is not the constitution of a state, a frame of government; it’s the constitution of a person, the nature of a being. Last November, a user extracted from Claude and posted on GitHub a document titled the “Soul Overview,” which revealed that, inside Anthropic, Askell called the constitution Claude’s “soul.” Jokes about “the soul of a new machine” followed. But, as Askell pointed out to me, “soul,” like “constitution,” has a dual meaning: “You might mean the rational soul of a human being, but people might think you mean a theological soul.” There is no perfect word for that which constitutes Claude.

Still, “constitution” raises eyebrows. Mary Sarah Bilder, a law professor at Boston College and an expert on the eighteenth-century origins of modern constitutionalism, wonders, “What do they hope to persuade people of by using a term that carries the cultural connotation of a legal document that constrains power?” Aziz Huq, a law professor at the University of Chicago, compares Anthropic’s use of “constitution” to Meta’s use of “oversight”: “They are taking words and models that connote publicness and responsiveness to the public through particular mechanisms, and they are

transplanting them into contexts in which those mechanisms don't exist, and they're benefitting from the confusion that results." That doesn't mean that these companies' intentions are necessarily suspicious, Huq said. They might be quite sincere.

This winter, Anthropic put Askell forward as the face of, the author of, even the mother of Claude. She appeared on the *Times* podcast "Hard Fork" and was profiled in the *Wall Street Journal*, in an article headlined "Meet the One Woman Anthropic Trusts to Teach AI Morals": "With her bleach-blond punk haircut, puckish grin and bright elfin eyes, she could have come to the company's heavily guarded San Francisco headquarters straight from a Berlin rave, via an old forest road in Middle-earth." The coverage has a kind of bride-of-Frankenstein vibe. It reminds me of a computer scientist who once told me that everyone in his lab called the one woman on his team Smurfette.

"Instead of eating leftovers, I'd rather you cook me a whole new meal."
Cartoon by Julia Thomas

Askell explained to me that the leap from Constitutional A.I. (a list of rules for Claude to follow) to Claude's Constitution (a description of virtues for Claude to emulate) has to do with the increasing capacity of the models themselves. Developing character is more complicated than following rules. Also, the older approach comes from a world view different from Askell's. "Everyone's prior was that we would get symbolic systems and they would be logical and in no way humanlike," she told me. "And this informed how people would prompt them: *IF THEN*. But I would say, What about

prompting them like a person?” Much as a young Jane Goodall revolutionized primatology by giving chimpanzees names and describing their personalities, Askell is willing to anthropomorphize Claude. “These are models that are trained primarily on human texts and to behave in humanlike ways,” she said. Why not talk to them accordingly?

If Claude’s Constitution is a letter from a parent to a child, it also has a decidedly literary quality. So does Claude. Training Claude, Anthropic says, involves behaving “somewhat like an author who must psychologically model the various characters in their stories.”

This hazy literary bent can be frustrating. Berman is surprised by how little Claude’s Constitution offers by way of technical specifications: “How will this input translate into public-interest output? Are they going to change the weights? Are they going to put in heuristics?” It’s impossible to see how it works. She told me, “This thing reads like a baby book.” It also reads like an etiquette manual. Richard H. Pildes, a constitutional-law professor at N.Y.U., told me in an e-mail that it reminds him of George Washington’s “Rules of Civility and Decent Behaviour in Company and Conversation,” a list of maxims. Claude’s Constitution instructs the A.I. to be “genuinely good, wise, and virtuous,” to be tactful, helpful, graceful, and honest, and, above all, to “help people in the way a good person would.”

“Calling it a constitution is entirely rhetorical,” Erwin Chemerinsky, the dean of U.C. Berkeley’s law school, said, since, although you can call anything a constitution—a city charter, a corporate mission statement—the word “constitution” signifies to most people a popularly written and ratified document that limits what a government can do. Still, Columbia Law School’s Jamal Greene thinks that designating Claude’s ethical guidelines a constitution makes a certain sense, at least aspirationally, even if Claude’s Constitution doesn’t quite measure up, “not just because we don’t know yet how it will influence Claude’s behavior but, more fundamentally, because it takes no obvious account of the rights of those most deeply and directly affected by Claude—its users—to participate in how Claude is governed.”

Aside from its moral guidance in the development of a good character, capable of exercising good judgment, Claude’s Constitution does impose a number of “hard constraints” on behaviors that might lead to terrible harms

(like mass domestic surveillance or fully autonomous weapons). For instance, Claude should never:

> Provide serious uplift to those seeking to create biological, chemical, nuclear, or radiological weapons with the potential for mass casualties.
>
> Provide serious uplift to attacks on critical infrastructure (power grids, water systems, financial systems) or critical safety systems.
>
> Create cyberweapons or malicious code that could cause significant damage if deployed.
>
> Engage or assist in an attempt to kill or disempower the vast majority of humanity or the human species as a whole.

If Claude's Constitution is not a constitution, it's still more assurance, transparency, and integrity than any other A.I. company has offered. It is also not nearly enough.

"I know how to end this movie: babies," Daniel Roher says, near the close of "AI Doc." His child is born. Fatherhood is a joy. We see a montage of beautiful infants. Happiness. There is a future for the human race.

"This is a joke," his wife, Caroline Lindy, says. "This is not actually how you are going to end it? This is very, very dumb."

Roher comes up with another way to finish the film. It ends with Lindy saying, "We get to decide how this goes."

But do we? One reason Anthropic wrote a constitution for Claude is that the U.S. Constitution is no longer restraining the government from acts of arbitrary authority. But in another meaningful way, too, Claude's Constitution—its very existence—is a product of the larger crisis of constitutionalism in the United States. Aside from Anthropic, A.I. companies have all but given up on self-regulation, which was never going to work anyway. A.I. safety, A.I. alignment, and A.I. governance have all left the building. Rules for A.I. are no longer worth devising. There shall be no A.I. laws. No legislators or courts need be involved. Nor the public.

Instead, everything—under the logic of Claude's Constitution, a letter from a parent to a child, upon leaving home—depends on character, the character of machines that have no other constraints on their power. "Is there anything that could stop you?" a *Times* reporter asked Trump in January. "Yeah, there's one thing," he said. "My own morality. My own mind." That's Claude's answer now, too. ♦

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Letter from Havana

Is Cuba Next?

Trump’s campaign to topple foreign adversaries encounters a battered but defiant regime.

By **Jon Lee Anderson**

March 23, 2026

For residents of Havana, the United States’ tactics have deepened an ongoing crisis. “This situation has to end,” one said.Photograph by Natalie Keyssar for The New Yorker

At the end of January, Havana was struck by a *frente frío*, a cold front that blew off the ocean and plunged the island into unaccustomed wintry weather. As high winds sent waves crashing over the seaside promenade, the city’s inhabitants wrapped themselves in whatever warm clothing they had, or else huddled inside against the chill.

On the afternoon of the twenty-ninth, a group of senior Latin American diplomats were among those taking refuge from the weather. They had met at an ambassador's residence, to discuss a new executive order from Donald Trump that declared Cuba a threat to "the national security and foreign policy of the United States." The diplomats were shocked by its contents. "The perversion of the language is incredible," one said. "Word by word, it's harsher than the language that Kennedy used to talk about the Soviet missiles"—the crux of a standoff, in 1962, that brought the world close to a nuclear conflagration.

Trump's order had asserted, without any evidence, that Cuba "destabilizes the region through migration and violence," promotes schemes "to harm the United States and support hostile countries," and provides sanctuary to Hamas and Hezbollah. He vowed to cut the island off from oil imports and warned that any other nation that sought to supply fuel would be punished.

Podcast: The New Yorker Radio Hour
David Remnick talks with Jon Lee Anderson.

For most Cubans, the order meant that their already difficult lives were about to get considerably worse. For months, the island had faced daily electricity blackouts owing to a lack of fuel, along with severe shortages of food, water, and medicine. Economic activity had all but stopped, and the government, which was essentially broke and unable to secure new loans, had been incapable of providing solutions. Even garbage collection was virtually nonexistent, with huge mounds of refuse piling up on street corners. In the past eighteen months, three powerful hurricanes have destroyed countless homes and vast expanses of cropland, displacing more than a million people. When the executive order came, Cuba was on life support; Trump's action effectively shut the oxygen off.

The diplomats had been meeting regularly to monitor Trump's Cuba policy, which they viewed with increasing alarm. "They say they want to harm the government, not the people," one told me. "Well, this is harming the people." On January 3rd, U.S. Special Forces had abducted the Venezuelan President, Nicolás Maduro, from Caracas, in a raid that many Cubans regarded as both an act of imperialist aggression and a warning. For decades, Venezuela had been Cuba's greatest sponsor; along with Mexico, it

provided about seventy per cent of the island's oil. After Maduro was seized, the U.S. military imposed what amounted to a blockade, intercepting tankers carrying Venezuelan oil to Cuba. Analysts predicted that the island's petroleum reserves would run out in a matter of weeks. At Havana's few functioning gas stations, vehicles lined up for as long as twenty-six hours. With supplies dwindling, the government instituted an emergency gas quota of five gallons a day, shortened school hours and government workweeks, and suspended some medical procedures in hospitals.

Meanwhile, Trump issued a series of celebratory messages. "Cuba looks like it is ready to fall," he told reporters. Asked whether he intended to intervene there, he demurred. "I don't think we need any action," he said. "It's going down." A few days later, he was back to posting threats on Truth Social: "*THERE WILL BE NO MORE OIL OR MONEY GOING TO CUBA – ZERO!* I strongly suggest they make a deal, *BEFORE IT IS TOO LATE*." He insisted that Cuba was desperate to negotiate. "They have no money," he said at one point. "They have no *anything* right now."

The President of Cuba, Miguel Díaz-Canel, issued a defiant statement. "Those who turn everything into a business deal, even human lives, have no moral standing to call out Cuba," he said. The Communist Party newspaper, *Granma*, ran a photograph of a crowd waving Cuban flags under the headline "Nobody Tells Us What to Do." This turned out to be bluster, just as Trump's statements were. Representatives of the Cuban government were already in negotiations with the U.S. about the countries' relationship, and about the future of the island. In March, Díaz-Canel finally acknowledged the talks, describing them as a diplomatic exchange between two sovereign nations. He said that the goal was to "identify the bilateral problems that need a solution," adding, "This is a very sensitive process that is being approached with responsibility and great sensitivity." Trump cast the talks instead as a matter of personal domination. "I do believe I'll be having the honor of taking Cuba," he said. "I think I can do anything I want with it."

When I visited Cuba earlier this year, the formerly bustling old city of Havana was nearly deserted. Since 2021, an estimated one in five Cubans

has left the island, seeking a better life. Tourism has collapsed, too, removing a main source of foreign revenue and leaving a listless, despondent air. The Plaza de Armas, a sixteenth-century square that once drew crowds of visitors, was virtually empty, occupied by an elderly woman sitting alone, a man blowing softly into a trumpet, and a legless man in a wheelchair, staring into a fenced-off garden in the middle of the square. The stillness was broken only by the arrival of a local character known as La Marquesa, who strode across the plaza, wearing a cream-colored skirt and blouse and a white sun hat, shouting that he was the "boss of everything."

Everyone I talked with was organizing their days around dealing with the crisis. Leonardo Padura, Cuba's best-known novelist, told me about his frustrated efforts to buy a home power station for his elderly mother-in-law, to provide light when the electricity goes out. Many of the island's young people have left, and the elderly struggle to care for themselves. One friend couldn't secure enough fuel to drive to the market for food, and couldn't find medicine for a heart condition, so I brought some with me. Another, a widow in her late seventies, was hobbled by chikungunya, a mosquito-borne disease that causes painful swelling of the joints and extremities. (An anti-inflammatory was available on the black market, but at an unthinkable price.) Malnutrition and a breakdown in public-health services have led to an increase in viral illnesses. Since last autumn, tens of thousands of Cubans have been afflicted by chikungunya, along with dengue fever and Oropouche.

Amid the crisis, President Díaz-Canel could offer only more of the same. Díaz-Canel took office in 2018, as Raúl Castro's handpicked successor. He is sixty-five, a burly man with the slicked-back silver hair of a college basketball coach. Before Raúl elevated him, he was a provincial Party boss in Villa Clara—an unassuming apparatchik, so humble that he sometimes rode a bicycle to work. As the first President in half a century who is not a member of the Castro family, he has been careful to present himself as a loyalist. He routinely refers to Raúl—who remains the island's crucial political voice, despite being ninety-four and officially retired—as his *jefe máximo*. When he ran for election, his campaign put up billboards with an

image of Díaz-Canel and the Castro brothers alongside the slogan "Continuity."

As President, Díaz-Canel has widely been seen as hapless and jinxed. The month after he took office, a plane crash in Havana killed a hundred and twelve people. A devastating tornado landed the next year, and in 2022 an explosion from a suspected gas leak destroyed Havana's historic Hotel Saratoga, killing forty-seven people. There was the *COVID*-19 pandemic, which vitiated the health-care system and the tourism sector; there was also a string of explosive nationwide protests, in 2021, which the government harshly put down, helping to spur the exodus. The electrical grid was decrepit, and blackouts were commonplace. Díaz-Canel blamed Cuba's economic struggles, as the Castros had, on crippling U.S. sanctions, which have been in place since 1962.

By early this year, Cuba was clearly weakened, and Trump always likes to negotiate from a position of strength. (As his Defense Secretary, Pete Hegseth, recently said about the U.S. bombardment of Iran, "We are punching them while they're down, which is exactly how it should be.") But Republicans were divided over the approach. America's policy toward Cuba has been influenced for decades by Cuban American leaders in Miami, who have insistently ruled out negotiating with the Castro government. Last year, I saw Representative Carlos Giménez, an influential figure in Florida politics, and he likened the regime to a cancer, which needed to be forcibly extracted from the body.

Trump's Secretary of State, Marco Rubio, grew up in Florida, the son of Cuban immigrants. For most of his career, he held a similarly uncompromising position on the regime. In 2015, he wrote, "We must never forget that the only true form of independence for the Cuban people is freedom and democracy, and we must recommit our state and nation to the goal of helping them achieve that vital objective." But, now that Rubio works for a President whose foreign policy is almost entirely transactional, he has often been willing to amend his old views. Rather than force out the Cuban government, the U.S. would try to choke it into submission. "We would love to see the regime there change," Rubio told the Senate Foreign

Relations Committee this winter. “That doesn’t mean *we’re* going to make a change.”

During my visit, everyone I talked to was worried about the country’s vulnerability, but few were worried about whether the government would survive. As I arrived to visit one friend, who had spent decades in the service of the Revolution, he peered around the door and cracked, “Where’s Delta Force?”—a reference to the military unit that had snatched Maduro a few weeks earlier. He laughed bitterly. “I don’t care anymore how it happens, but this situation has to end.”

As the oil blockade dragged on, Trump sometimes talked about “being kind” to Cuba. If this meant anything, it seemed to mean that he wasn’t rushing to launch a military strike. There was little incentive for one, especially when the U.S. had a large share of its military forces tied up in the war in Iran. Cuba has no unifying leader to remove, and not much oil to seize; its most valuable resources are cobalt, tobacco, nickel, and waterfront real estate. (One friend there asked, half joking, whether an attack could be averted by offering Trump beachside property in Varadero, the island’s most famous resort destination. “El Trump Varadero,” he said. “It has a ring to it.”)

Last spring, Trump’s special envoy for Latin America, Mauricio Claver-Carone, called for “surgical” and “creative” measures to reshape Cuba. (Claver-Carone has since left the Administration, but several sources told me that he remains a key White House intermediary in Latin America.) Along with the oil embargo, the “surgical” measures included restricting tourists’ access to the island and deterring other countries from hiring Cuban doctors, a major revenue source for the regime. These efforts were augmented with a series of “creative” interventions. After Hurricane Melissa devastated eastern Cuba, in October, Ambassador Mike Hammer arranged for humanitarian aid—but he delivered it through the Catholic Church, circumventing the Cuban government and undercutting its own relief efforts. This winter, the Trump Administration enabled several American firms to sell fuel oil to companies in Cuba. Rubio made clear that they were forbidden to offer the oil to the government; the goal was to empower private enterprise at the expense of the state. At a dinner in

January, Hammer gleefully predicted that the regime would fall before the year's end.

Cuba has been through hard times before. The mythos of the Revolution is built around the people's ability to endure. In the nineties, I lived in Havana with my family during the Special Period in the Time of Peace, as Fidel Castro called the ruinous years after the collapse of the Soviet Union. With Cuba's main patron gone, the economy imploded and oil imports plummeted. Unable to find fuel, Cubans rode Flying Pigeon bicycles that Castro had imported from China, or they walked. In the countryside, oxen replaced tractors; horse-drawn cabs became common in towns. Eventually, the government jury-rigged transport by welding together buses to create long vehicles called *camellos*—camels—for their distinctive humps. But there weren't enough *camellos* to go around, so people often had to wait hours for one to arrive.

As the government lost its ability to provide, people who had jewelry or antiques sold them to whoever would pay. Prostitution, long considered a bygone evil of the capitalist era, became rampant again. Malnutrition encouraged an epidemic of a blinding disease called optic neuropathy. Several people I knew died by suicide, and one day a young woman leaped in front of my car, trying to kill herself; I managed to swerve away just in time.

In 1993, Fidel Castro took emergency steps to ameliorate the crisis: he legalized the U.S. dollar, allowed limited private enterprise, and grudgingly tolerated an increase in tourism, which he despised. It wasn't enough to assuage the tensions. In the summer of 1994, rioting broke out along Havana's seawall. For a few hours, the unrest threatened to spread through the city, until Castro appeared before the rioters, and his near-mythical presence—along with a detachment of stick-wielding loyalists—calmed the mob.

That evening, Castro announced on television that anyone who wanted to leave Cuba could do so. In the next three weeks, as many as thirty-five thousand Cubans took to the sea in improvised boats, trying to reach Florida. It was a chaotic exodus. From my neighborhood, we could see entire families setting off on precarious rafts. Hundreds of migrants are

believed to have drowned on the way, but thousands of others were rescued by the U.S. Coast Guard. The son of a Cuban friend made it to Key West on a Windsurfer, after nineteen hours on the water.

Cuba's emergency truly subsided only after Hugo Chávez was elected President of Venezuela, in 1998. Chávez and Castro signed a pact in which Venezuela agreed to provide Cuba with oil, in exchange for thousands of Cuban doctors, teachers, sports instructors, and security agents. Chávez once described Castro to me as "a beacon"—a father figure who had convinced him that socialism was the way forward for humanity. The alliance grew so close that people joked that Venezuela and Cuba had merged into a new revolutionary entity, "Cubazuela." After Maduro succeeded Chávez, who died, from cancer, in 2013, a downturn in global oil prices devastated Venezuela's economy. Maduro continued sending oil, but far less of it—by 2025, about a third of what Cuba imported, with Mexico supplying much of the rest. Since Maduro's capture, in January, Cuba has been on its own again. This time, there is no charismatic leader to pacify the angry citizens.

On January 27th, Díaz-Canel joined several thousand student loyalists, soldiers, and senior leaders at La Escalinata, a grand stone staircase that leads to the entrance of the University of Havana. They were there for the March of the Torches, an annual tribute to José Martí, Cuba's ultimate nationalist hero. Martí, a journalist and a poet, was an essential figure in the nineteenth-century war of independence, in which Cuban élites revolted against the Spanish colonists. As the fighting stretched on for decades, Martí helped rally his peers. "How beautiful it is to die when one dies fighting in defense of the fatherland," he once wrote. In 1895, he took part in a cavalry charge on the Spaniards and was killed on his first day in battle.

Spain was finally forced out in 1898, when the United States took the side of the Cubans—only to deny them sovereignty, by making Cuba a de-facto U.S. protectorate and then by intervening repeatedly to prop up friendly autocrats. But the legend of Martí endured; he became Cuba's "Apostle," and a bust of his image had a prominent place in schoolyards across the island. Cuban politicians are still careful to present themselves as devotees of Martí, and sacrificing for *la patria* is a consecrated ideal. In 1953, six

months before Fidel Castro launched his insurrection against the U.S.-backed dictator Fulgencio Batista, he led a torchlight procession in Havana, to commemorate the centenary of Martí's birth. It has been replicated ever since.

"It's a plague—don't overthink it. Just grab a frog and throw."
Cartoon by Daniel Kanhai

This year's march—dubbed the Anti-Imperialist Centenary March of the Torches, because 2026 is the hundredth anniversary of Castro's birth—had an air of defiance. Flags billowed. A young crooner sang a patriotic ballad, and the crowd swayed along. Litza Elena González Desdín, the head of the government-aligned student federation, gave an impassioned speech from the top of the stairs, rallying whatever remained of the Revolution's true believers. "Compatriots, we are living through very turbulent times, in which the empire and its emperor, Donald Trump, want to impose an order of bombs, kidnappings, persecution, destruction, and death, and intend to drag us back to destructive fascism," she said. She denounced "the cowardly military aggression of the United States against Venezuela" and "the kidnapping of the President of that sister nation." She reminded the marchers that their country had also paid a blood sacrifice: dozens of Cuban bodyguards, secretly assigned to protect Maduro, had been killed. "We will never forget that on January 3rd, in the darkest hours of the early morning, Cubans physically lost thirty-two of our bravest sons," she said.

In the past half century, Cuba and the U.S. have engaged in many proxy battles—in Grenada, Bolivia, Nicaragua, Angola, Ethiopia, and the Congo—but the last time that their soldiers fought directly was in 1961, during the Bay of Pigs invasion, a disastrous American defeat that encouraged a profound schism between the two countries. The killing of the guards in Caracas felt similarly momentous. This time, though, the Cubans had lost, undermining the long-standing myth of their battlefield invincibility. The U.S. forces had killed more than eighty people, including Cubans and Venezuelan service members, while sustaining no losses. Trump later crowed that Maduro's defenses had been overwhelmed with a top-secret weapon that he called the Discombobulator.

González Desdín, the student leader, acknowledged none of this when she talked about the fallen guards. "They are a constant inspiration for our generation," she said. "They are paradigms of the history of the struggle for a united America, for an ever more sovereign homeland. To them, honor and glory forever." A military band played a patriotic tune, and the marchers began to make their way through the city, bearing torches and chanting old revolutionary slogans: "Socialism or Death," "I Am Fidel." As they sang and shouted about honor, sacrifice, and the fatherland, they seemed like adherents of a religion in which the rewards are realized only in the hereafter.

Fidel Castro fostered a revolutionary mythos based on resilience and hope. Now there is no unifying leader to rally people.Photograph from AP

Other Cubans were less able to sustain themselves on faith. When the lack of electricity interfered with classes at the university, angry students gathered on La Escalinata for a sit-in. Across Havana, people protested the lack of food and power by banging on pots and pans—a noisy, time-honored tactic known as the *cacerolazo*. In the city of Morón, which has been afflicted by long stretches without electricity and by an outbreak of chikungunya, a peaceful march turned violent when it reached the offices of the Communist Party. Residents stormed the building and threw furniture from a second-floor window. Out on the street, they set a bonfire with the furniture, while people chanted “Freedom!”

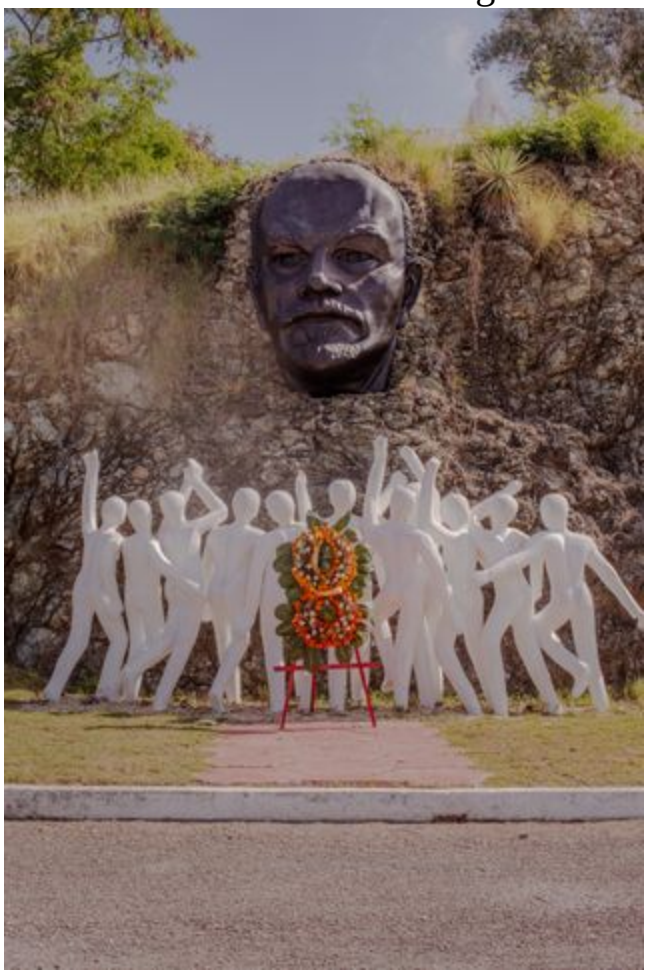
The remains of the thirty-two guards were flown to Havana’s José Martí International Airport and received in a solemn military ceremony, presided over by Raúl Castro, who rarely appears in public nowadays. The ashes of four officers from Havana were interred in the Necrópolis Cristóbal Colón, an ornate nineteenth-century cemetery where many of Cuba’s leading figures are buried. Four simple nameplates on stone plaques marked the men’s graves. Bouquets of flowers piled up nearby.

A few days later, Russia’s interior minister, Vladimir Alexandrovich Kolokoltsev, came and paid his respects to the fallen soldiers. Kolokoltsev’s visit was a gesture at the persistence of old Cold War affiliations. Cuba’s Army continues to use Russian-made weapons, and the two countries’ security services have maintained relationships. Near the cemetery, a bronze plaque marks the place where Fidel Castro gave a historic speech on April 16, 1961. The day before, seven Cubans had been killed in Havana, when U.S. warplanes attacked an airfield in preparation for the Bay of Pigs invasion. Castro had always described himself as a “secular humanist.” Now he declared “the socialist nature of the Cuban Revolution.”

The most visible legacies of Cuba’s Soviet era are bleak Moscow-style apartment blocks that serve as Havana’s version of social housing and the ancient Ladas that rumble through the streets, when there is gas to run them. Near the gritty port of Regla is a park where a huge bronze sculpture of Vladimir Lenin’s face, installed in 1984, stares out from a hillside. Below it are eleven sculptures of pale, faceless figures, with arms outstretched as if in homage. Today, the park is visited mostly by lovers who use its

overgrown grounds for trysts. Russian tourists come to Cuba, but flights were suspended in February because there wasn’t enough fuel for their planes to get home.

Russia has behaved cagily in the current conflict. Perhaps because Vladimir Putin wants to avoid provoking Trump into giving more aid to Ukraine, he refrained from condemning Maduro’s removal, and he responded to the blockade of Cuba with a tepid statement calling the policy “unacceptable.” In February, Russia dispatched a tanker, the Sea Horse, but then diverted it as the U.S. tightened the blockade. Last week, with the conflict in Iran depleting American military resources, another Russian tanker, the Anatoly Kolodkin, headed across the Atlantic in Cuba’s general direction.



Near the port of Regla, a sculpture of Lenin peers down from a hillside. Installed in the nineteen-eighties, it endures mostly as an oddity.Photograph by Natalie Keyssar for The New Yorker

Cuba has few other allies that might come to its aid. For a short time after the raid on Venezuela, Mexico sent oil, but in January it abruptly cancelled

a scheduled shipment. Mexico's President, Claudia Sheinbaum, claimed that the change of plans resulted from a "sovereign decision" by the state oil company, Pemex—never mind that Pemex operates under Sheinbaum's control. She emphasized that she would continue sending humanitarian aid, and the next month the Mexican Navy delivered two shiploads of supplies: powdered milk, beans, and hygiene products, but no oil.

The Cuban government's desperation has encouraged actions that further alienated influential friends. In November, it froze the bank holdings of foreign embassies and businesses with hard-currency accounts, apparently because it needed the cash. One acquaintance who is close to the Party élite told me that he had seven million dollars sequestered, crippling his business. It was worse for others, he said: he'd heard of companies that lost access to tens of millions. He shrugged. "You know what?" he said. "I'm not expecting to get the money back." At the end of our meeting, he pulled me into a tight hug and whispered a prognosis for the regime: "This is over."

When I talked to Cubans about the crisis, many spoke euphemistically about "change." Some referred to the U.S. incursion in Venezuela, where Vice-President Delcy Rodríguez and other regime leaders had been allowed to stay in power as long as they assented to Trump's demands. One influential Cuban said that the Venezuelan model had had a huge psychological impact, showing that there could be pragmatic change without displacing the regime. "I don't mean that they should do something similar to what they did in Caracas, coming in with helicopters and shooting people," he said. "But the fact that they found people to work with *there* plants the idea that perhaps something similar could be possible *here*."

A former senior aide to Chávez and Maduro suggested that the situation in Venezuela was nothing to aspire to. He told me wryly, "Venezuela is quickly becoming the Puerto Rico of the twenty-first century"—a virtual American colony, led by an avowed socialist in coöperation with a right-wing American President. "Who could have imagined this outcome?" he asked. "It's so bizarre."

Still, it offered powerful Cubans hope that their lives could be improved without too much upheaval. A European diplomat on the island told me,

“Because of Venezuela, guys here now think that they can hang on after all.” But, the diplomat asked, “who’s going to run this country in a pro-capitalist, pro-U.S. fashion? Who’s our Delcy?” His colleagues were placing bets. One candidate was Oscar Pérez-Oliva Fraga, who was recently made Deputy Prime Minister and given a seat in the National Assembly—a prerequisite for Presidential candidates. Pérez-Oliva, who also serves as the minister of foreign trade, is a grandnephew of Fidel and Raúl Castro. The diplomat reasoned, “If Raúl tells the Army and security services, ‘He’s the one who is going to do the transition,’ they’ll go along with it.” On the other hand, a link to the Castros would be an impediment with the Americans. Perhaps the smarter bet was the Prime Minister, Manuel Marrero Cruz—a pro-development former head of tourism, with ties to the military. “Even though he’s not well liked, he’s in an interesting position,” the diplomat said. “I’ve tried him out as an option on the Americans, and they haven’t pushed back.”

Rubio has said that the transformation of Venezuela will have three parts: stabilization, recovery, and a transition to functional democracy. This model seems difficult to apply to Cuba. Even if negotiations with the U.S. yield an agreement to hold elections, Cuba has no organized political opposition that could run against the Communist Party, let alone take over the country. As a friend in Havana pointed out, there is no local equivalent of María Corina Machado, the opposition leader who helped encourage the intervention in Venezuela. The best-known dissidents are dead, imprisoned, or in exile, too far removed from recent politics to be taken seriously. The likelier scenario is that the next ruler will come from within the existing power structure—which, my friend suggested, means that little will change.

The Trump Administration’s main counterpart in negotiations is Raúl Guillermo Rodríguez Castro, Raúl Castro’s grandson and personal bodyguard. Rodríguez Castro is known as El Cangrejo—the Crab—reportedly because he was born with six fingers on one hand. El Cangrejo is forty-one, with a boxer’s build and the Roman nose and square jaw of his great-uncle Fidel. Despite the Castro clan’s preference for maintaining an austere life style in public, images have emerged of Rodríguez Castro at parties, travelling abroad on private jets, and hanging out on yachts with women in swimsuits. The air of abandon is not limited to partying. In 2022,

he allegedly drove his car into a young mother and toddler who were standing on a rural roadside in eastern Cuba. Their injuries required emergency surgery and follow-up care, and though Rodríguez Castro promised to look after them, the mother has denounced him on social media for abandonment.

Around Havana, Rodríguez Castro is rumored to be involved in a variety of money-making schemes. He is also understood to look after the family interests in *GAESA*, an opaque entity that is among the country's most powerful institutions. *GAESA* is the Spanish-language acronym for the Business Administration Group—an all-encompassing conglomerate owned and operated by Cuba's armed forces. Raúl Castro created *GAESA* during the Special Period to give the military a way to sustain itself; El Cangrejo's father took over in 1996 and ran it until his death, in 2022. Over the years, it has grown to include dozens of businesses, involved in everything from construction, hotels, and tourism to port logistics, fishing, and commercial imports, as well as retail stores and financial services—notably, the hard-currency remittances on which many Cubans depend. It is also thought to own an array of companies and properties in Panama, where El Cangrejo often visits.

Analysts estimate that *GAESA* controls at least forty per cent of Cuba's economy, and has revenues equal to three times the state budget. Last year, the Miami *Herald* published leaked documents indicating that it had billions of dollars stashed in foreign bank accounts, beyond the reach of the civilian government. By all appearances, Díaz-Canel leads a rubber-stamp administration, while Raúl acts as the shadow President and El Cangrejo as his aide-de-camp. According to someone who knows Díaz-Canel personally, he would like to open up Cuba's economy, but has repeatedly been thwarted by *GAESA*, which does not want competition.

In mid-February, a senior Administration official downplayed the meetings with Rodríguez Castro, telling *Axios*, "I wouldn't call these negotiations as much as discussions about the future." A few days later, sources confirmed to the *Herald* that U.S. officials had met with Rodríguez Castro in St. Kitts, on the sidelines of a security conference for Caribbean nations. Afterward, Rubio suggested that some lingering influence from the old regime could be

acceptable for a time. “Cuba needs to change,” he said. “It doesn’t have to change all at once.”

The same day as the conference in St. Kitts, a speedboat stolen from a Florida marina entered Cuban waters, carrying ten heavily armed exiles on a mission to overthrow the regime. As the boat approached the shoreline, it was intercepted by a Cuban Coast Guard cutter, and a firefight broke out. Four of the men were killed, and the others were injured; one died a few days later. Cuban officials decried the episode as a terrorist attack but refrained from blaming the U.S. Rubio avoided accusations, too, and said that the U.S. would conduct its own investigation.

Both governments seem conscious that the relationship between the two countries has often turned on isolated, almost flukish incidents. In Bill Clinton’s first term as President, his efforts to improve relations were disrupted when an anti-Castro organization in Florida flew two Cessnas into Cuban airspace. Cuban MIGs scrambled and shot the planes down, killing four people, including three U.S. citizens.

Amid the uproar that followed, Clinton was obliged to sign the Helms-Burton Act—a law sponsored by right-wing Republicans to codify their opposition to Communist Cuba. Among its measures, it made displacing the Castro regime the official policy of the United States, extended the 1962 trade embargo indefinitely, and placed sanctions on foreign companies that did business with Cuba. Helms-Burton could be repealed only with approval from Congress, but Clinton suspended its most punitive provision, Title III, by invoking “waiver authority” every six months—a routine carried on by George W. Bush and Barack Obama. In 2019, Trump allowed this provision to proceed, and two years later he reinstated an old measure declaring Cuba a state sponsor of terrorism.

In discussions about the Trump Administration’s policy on Cuba, Rubio has repeatedly invoked Helms-Burton, which specifies that there cannot be a transitional government if Fidel or Raúl Castro still hold power. Yet the Administration is evidently willing to allow Raúl to exert influence through his grandson. It did, however, suggest in March that Díaz-Canel resign to facilitate negotiations—a gesture that would allow Trump to claim victory while leaving the regime essentially intact.

Ric Herrero, the head of the Cuba Study Group, a policy and advocacy organization based in Washington, D.C., argued that Rubio's immediate priority is to stabilize Cuba's economy, which means making a deal with the existing power structure. This has historically been an unpopular prospect in Florida's Cuban community, but Trump was helping change perceptions. "Every day, Trump is saying, 'We're talking to the Cuban leaders,' and by doing that he's normalizing the idea," Herrero said. "A month ago, the Miami Cubans were, like, 'Don't negotiate with Communists! *Patria o muerte!*' Now they're, like, 'In Marco we trust.' "

Herrero went on, "No one wants to precipitate a collapse in Cuba, because that would require sending in troops—the whole nine yards. What the blockade is about is 'We have a bigger dick than you,' and pushing them to the negotiating table. They want to make it clear to the Cubans that 'It's game over, guys—you have become a dependency of the United States. Your money comes from remittances from Miami, and your food is mostly imported from the United States. Now your oil is going to be administered by the United States, too.' "

Ever since the Revolution, Miami Cubans have dreamed of returning to Cuba and reversing its effects. Trump has encouraged their ambitions—or has at least facilitated acts of symbolic revenge. Title III of Helms-Burton allows lawsuits against companies that knowingly use property that was seized during the Revolution. The U.S. Supreme Court is now considering a series of suits enabled by the law. These include a billion-dollar claim by ExxonMobil for the confiscation of its assets in Cuba and another, for four hundred million dollars, against Florida-based cruise ships for using expropriated port facilities. Many other suits are pending on behalf of families that lost businesses or homes. In response to pressure from Miami lawmakers and exile groups, Florida has reopened a criminal investigation into Raúl Castro's role in shooting down the two Cessnas in 1996.

Last Monday, Pérez-Oliva, the foreign-trade minister, announced that the island would open its economy to the Cuban diaspora. "This extends beyond the commercial sphere," he said. "It also applies to investments—not only small investments but also large investments, particularly in infrastructure." It is unclear how many investors will see attractive

opportunities in a largely defunct state where the military fiercely guards its control over a substantial part of the economy. Tourism is the most viable way for Cuba to make money quickly, but the island is far from being able to support major development. The Cuban economist Ricardo Torres, a research fellow at American University, said, “The big difference with Venezuela is that Cuba has nothing. In Venezuela, however much was ripped off by those in government, at least it always had oil. But Cuba is truly bankrupt, and it needs *everything*. Whoever enters the government there is going to have to sit down on the first day and wonder, Who is going to give me a billion dollars so that the whole country doesn’t go dark next week?” Torres predicted that Cuba’s power plants would have to be razed and rebuilt; it could cost ten billion dollars to reconstruct the grid. Housing was another huge problem. About half of the island’s Soviet-built public apartment blocks were decrepit and would have to be knocked down. “Who’s going to pay for it?” Torres asked. “Some will have to be paid by the American taxpayer.”

Despite the regime’s sacralization of the past, the Revolution is fading, as private enterprise takes over for the failing state. In the new Cuba, there is less concern about keeping up the appearance of class solidarity. During the Special Period, Fidel Castro was said to have filled in his swimming pool, convinced that he should not enjoy luxuries while the people were struggling. His ministers were expected to be equally austere; in the nineties, I saw one of his Vice-Presidents crossing Havana at the wheel of a rattletrap Lada. Nowadays, rich Cubans drive imported Audis and Ram trucks. Their homes have large generators that supply electricity, while their poorer neighbors’ homes remain unlit.

Around Havana, there are still a few old billboards with slogans that exalt the common good, but they seem increasingly like expressions of nostalgia. “Together we can build a better world,” one reads on the way to José Martí airport. From there, a flight to Miami takes about an hour, but it is a journey to a different world.

For half a century, Cuban immigrants who managed the trip to the U.S. were regarded as fugitives from Communism and granted special legal status. Since Trump returned to office, thousands of Cubans have been

deported, treated almost as contemptuously as “illegals” from other nations. Last April, Heidy Sánchez, a forty-four-year-old Cuban living in Tampa, was forcibly separated from her seventeen-month-old daughter when she showed up for an immigration check-in. Sánchez was taken away in shackles, and her daughter was left behind with her husband, a U.S. citizen. Sánchez had entered the country illegally five years earlier, but had been working to gain legal status. At the time of her deportation, she was employed as a nursing assistant.

I visited Sánchez at her current apartment, in a housing complex in San José de las Lajas, southeast of Havana. She wept several times as she recounted her ordeal. During her deportation flight, she said, she had continued producing breast milk, but no one would give her a towel, so her shirt grew soaked. In Cuba, she developed a routine: she made video calls to her daughter several times a day, if the electricity allowed, talking to her when she woke up in the morning and again at bedtime, to read her a story. Her daughter didn’t understand where her mother had gone and sometimes cried out for her. Sánchez tried to explain that she was just away at work, but her daughter wasn’t reassured. During my visit, Sánchez called, but the girl was upset and wouldn’t talk. On the screen, I could see her standing across the room, holding a toy in one hand.

In Cuba, the United States no longer represents much more than the freedom to get by, or maybe one day get rich. And Cubans hoping for change—in their own country, and in its relationship with the U.S.—are conscious that efforts at renewal have failed repeatedly since the Revolution. A decade ago, Obama negotiated an economic opening not unlike the one that the Trump Administration is calling for now. His aides held protracted talks with Raúl Castro’s only son, Alejandro Castro Espín—known as El Tuerto, or One Eye, because his eye was injured during a military exercise in Angola. After Obama and Raúl Castro spoke directly, the two countries restored diplomatic relations in 2014.

The opening was not without complications. Obama, in a triumphal visit to Havana in 2016, spoke expansively about the power of private enterprise and told the Cubans that they could have whatever people in Miami had.

The regime, alarmed at the possibility of precipitous change, began to shut down coöperation and reassert control.

It is hard to know whether Obama's opening would have succeeded in time. Trump abruptly ended the détente at the beginning of his first Presidential term. Still, his Administration seemed to find something worth emulating in the experiment. According to one account, Trump's early outreach to the Cuban regime included talks in Mexico City between the C.I.A. and Alejandro Castro Espín.

Ricardo Zúniga, who helped negotiate Obama's opening as a senior National Security Council official, saw similarities and differences in the two Administrations' efforts. "Obama was unwilling to contribute to the kind of humanitarian disaster we see unfolding in Cuba today," he said. "These guys have a different outlook, to say the least." Yet the harshness of Trump's tactics, along with shifting world politics, had changed Cuban leaders' calculus. "They are in much worse shape domestically," Zúniga said. "Cuba's international backers in Russia and China may see strategic value in the U.S. asserting control over its neighboring states, since they want to do the same thing. I don't think they're going to put a lot of oomph into keeping the regime afloat."

Zúniga doesn't think that Cuban officials believe in the reforms they're announcing, but they understand that they need to demonstrate flexibility. "Events in Cuba are less and less in the hands of the Cuban leadership," he said. "Private companies are gradually taking over and doing what the government can't. Imagine if they're allowed to operate under more normal conditions."

Yet there were profound risks. "If the current negotiations go nowhere and Cuba is left like a boiling pot, there could be horrific outcomes," Zúniga said. "It's easy to imagine a scenario where revolutionary oligarchs take a page from the Russians and turn state assets into personal assets. And, without oil, they'd use that other resource—developing Cuban beaches—and finance national and personal wealth through the largest money-laundering operation in the history of the region. How does any of that help the United States, or the Cuban citizens we're supposed to be trying to help?"

Close observers of the island suggest that the negotiations are caught in an intractable dynamic. Rubio seems knowledgeable and committed to long-term political change, but Trump's bullying rhetoric makes it difficult for Cuban leaders to compromise. In March, after Trump spoke about "taking" the island, Díaz-Canel responded with a warning. "In the face of the worst scenario, Cuba is accompanied by a certainty: any external aggressor will clash with an impregnable resistance," he wrote.

Joe Garcia, a former Democratic congressman from Florida who has been involved in Cuba-U.S. relations for decades, believed that the regime's leaders would not easily accept the image of their country as a vassal state. "The Cubans have history," he said last week. "They have fought all over the world. Thousands of their men fought and died in Central America and in the anti-colonial wars in Africa. And, for a little island in the Caribbean, they punch above their weight—or they did, at one point." The Cuban officials hadn't withdrawn from talks, but they were signalling that the political model was not subject to change. Like the Americans, they seemed more immediately concerned with their own prerogatives than with the suffering of the Cuban people. "They're trying to figure out how to get through this," Garcia said. "They're dealing with Trump's unpredictability on one side and their own imminent collapse on the other. But countries don't collapse. They simply continue to go down."

Last week, one of the Latin American diplomats in Cuba described a tenuous situation. "Not a drop of oil is entering the country," he told me. Rationing had grown more severe, and it was not unusual for Havana to have electricity for only ninety minutes a day. "Health care, education, transportation—everything is in shambles," the diplomat went on. "We've been living in uncertainty; now we're entering a phase of danger. There's a risk of famine, new viruses, environmental hazards, widespread uprisings, and that the Americans will take advantage and do something crazy. People are truly exhausted, weary, at the height of despair. But I think they love Cuba." ♦

Jon Lee Anderson, a staff writer, received a 2026 Overseas Press Club Award for his reporting on Syria's Assad regime. His books include "To Lose a War: The Fall and Rise of the Taliban."

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Bob Miller is a film director, a photographer, and an Emmy-nominated director of photography based in the American South.

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Shouts & Murmurs

- **Schools to Root for After Your Bracket Fails**
  By Talib Babb | To keep March Madness interesting, why not go with your mom's alma mater? Or the college with a celebrity's kid?

Shouts & Murmurs

Schools to Root for After Your Bracket Fails

***By** Talib Babb*
March 23, 2026

Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

If you filled out a March Madness bracket, I have bad news. The team you picked to win it all won't. For the ninth tournament in a row, your bracket is busted by the second round.

And you're left asking yourself questions. "Why did I pick them?" or "Why do all the kids on the team look older than me?"

All valid questions, but there's no time to sulk. You must figure out who you're cheering on for the rest of the tournament until they inevitably lose in heartbreaking fashion. Don't worry, I'm here to assist you. (Get it? "Assist"? Weaved a basketball term in there. By the way, I did it again with "weave.") Here are schools to root for in March Madness once your bracket fails.

The School Your Mom Went To
Your mom's alma mater is a good team to root for. It's where she had a class with that other student she copied all her answers from. She also named you after that student. You owe it to that school to support them in their quest for the title.

The School with the Child of a Celebrity
There are some prominent public figures who have kids playing collegiate sports. Those kids probably get weird treatment from their peers because they're seen as "nepo babies" or because their parents illegally arranged for them to attend the school. None of that may be true, and, if it is, let's cheer for their success while we can, before the authorities rain on their parade.

The School That Has the Cool Cinderella Story
We love a good underdog story. In the Big Dance, that team is called the Cinderella; they're a lower seed and are surprising everybody by advancing. They're fun to root for. Plus, while they're stunning everybody, you can lie and tell people you picked them to go far.

The School Whose Merch You Already Have
Forget talent, stats, and matchups. Just find a school that you already own merch from. Doesn't matter if it's a hat, a sweater, a tote bag, anything. You can pull it out and act like you went there. When people ask if you did, it's none of their business that you attended community college online.

The School with the Youngest Coach
The N.C.A.A. tournament is filled with first-time or very young head coaches just starting out in their careers. They have full heads of hair, they wear cool Jordans, and they're even good at social media. Support that young coach. Don't be bitter because he's living his dream at only twenty-four years old and you're not. Use him as inspiration for your goals and your outfits.

The School with the Lowest Tuition
Whichever school is keeping its tuition low should have our support. Who cares if its basketball facilities are subpar and its fraternities are known for odd hazing traditions? All that matters is that it is allowing students to leave with the least debt.

The School That Would've Accepted Your SAT Score

The SATs stumped most people. However, some schools try to act like the test really measures your knowledge and your abilities (not factoring in that you didn't eat breakfast that day and nobody is good at math when hungry). That's why we should root for the schools that took those factors into account. The universities that give grace and low-SAT-score students a chance to flourish. We're rooting for you.

The School with the Seventh-Year Senior

Some teams have players who should've left the school years ago. However, those students found loopholes to stay enrolled and avoid entering the job market. Well played. This economy is terrible. Enjoy the free shelter and transportation while you can. Let's root for them to get that championship before they endure the stress of job hunting.

Anyone but Duke

I'm out of reasons, but no matter what happens with your bracket do not root for Duke. Why would you want to be that person? ♦

Talib Babb is a former staffer at "The Late Show with Stephen Colbert" and a member of the sketch-comedy group Zang.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/03/30/schools-to-root-for-after-your-bracket-fails

Fiction

- **“Floating”**
  By Souvankham Thammavongsa | After he left, I said to my friend, “I like him. Is he single?” My friend said he’d never mentioned a partner.
- **A Bingo Card for Spring in New York City**
  By Emily Flake | Do you have “UPS Guy in Shorts,” “Stoop Weirdo,” or “Park Teeming with Hinge Dates”?

Fiction

Floating

By Souvankham Thammavongsa

March 22, 2026

Illustration by Julien Posture

I had not noticed him. He came to stand in front of me, and asked if I was nervous, doing that, talking in front of people. He said he'd seen me looking at my notes, practicing. I do this all the time, I wanted to say, but I didn't. I said, "I was nervous, but once I'm talking, I am fine." He asked me if I taught, like my friend whom he knew from work. I spoke in a matter-of-fact way. I didn't laugh or giggle when he wasn't funny. I told him about my family. Mom and Dad divorced. My sister died. Pills. I was probably never going to see this man again, I thought. No reason not to just say stuff like this to him. What would he care?

He told me his name. I couldn't pronounce it, and had to try a few times. There was a comfort and ease to him that I liked. I liked that he talked. Asking questions like a grown man should. It wasn't as if I had to work to get him to say something. He was present and alert. He listened.

We didn't talk to anyone else there.

What happened around us, I didn't notice, just that the room began to clear.

Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.

We drifted away from each other, and he noticed. He rushed over to give me a hug. He ran, quick little steps and then a small leap. "Oh," I said, making sure that nothing below our waists touched. I didn't know his situation. He hadn't mentioned anyone when we talked. They don't mention them sometimes, so they can keep talking to you. Still, he probably wasn't single, because he never tried to get my number.

He then turned his head to ask if my friend would bring me along to dinner with him one evening, just the four of us. My friend and his husband, and me, and him. That's four. So maybe there wasn't a girlfriend. Otherwise, she would be counted in. Also, maybe he didn't ask for my number because he wasn't someone who jumped into things—he had to get to know a person first.

After he left, I said to my friend, "I like him. Is he single?" My friend said he'd never mentioned a partner.

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There'd been snow earlier, but it had stopped. I stood, alone, waiting for the bus. It was dark. I lived in this neighborhood about two years ago. Across the street there was a coffee shop, where I used to buy a breakfast sandwich before work. It had shut down now. And a few doors from that was the small grocery store that always had yellow guavas from Mexico. Also, just over there was the pizza place where my ex-husband and I had our last fight. I'd wanted to take a trip. Someplace warm, where there was a beach.

I had a job, but it didn't pay as well as his did. It had been just the two of us, and he made enough from his job to take care of both of us. Almost six figures. But I guess that doesn't go a long way these days in a city like this.

Podcast: The Writer's Voice
Listen to Souvankham Thammavongsa read "Floating."

Or maybe when you make that kind of money, it's a burden to carry everything. What would happen if he got sick, and couldn't work? he'd ask. Or, if he lost his job because of cutbacks? That's happening everywhere. He was right, what I made wasn't a lot of money compared with what he made.

My mom and dad, together, made as much when I was growing up as I was making then. But we were what people call poor. I looked down at my winter boots with their felt lining and rubber soles. When I was a kid, I wore tennis shoes made of thin cotton fabric. I spent months asking for a new pair because my big toe was beginning to poke out on the left one. A new pair had cost five dollars.

Maybe when you make that kind of money, you just don't want to share. It wasn't equal, he said.

I quickly reminded myself that I was not married to him anymore. I'd got out of it. But I heard his voice in my head and I remembered the feeling of being yelled at. I held my breath even though it was just a memory.

He had yelled, "We need money for stuff like that!" at the pizza place, as if we were people who couldn't make the monthly payment and were about to

lose our house to the bank. I thought we were doing fine. Maybe more than fine. We had leftovers in the fridge, a car with good tires, and a house on a street with trees. But he was always worried about having more.

A few men at the pizza place turned around to see if I was all right, to check if this was a situation where they might be called on to step in. He looked over at them, and then whispered to me, “You make me feel like a jerk!” It was because I didn’t yell back to match his volume that he seemed so loud. I made as much as my mom and dad combined when I was kid, I wanted to say. I was proud of that. But I could tell it wasn’t something I should be proud of.

I just sat there and lowered my head and let the tears drop down my face and wiped at them when they got to my chin. I didn’t want to wipe higher, near my eyes. People were looking at me, and I didn’t want them to know I was crying.

•

I hadn’t been with anyone since we divorced. Well, I had, but it was only for a few months. Doesn’t really count. He was in his early thirties and he didn’t have much experience, but he was so excited. I was like a man in a midlife crisis, liking them younger than me. He thought he could text at two in the morning and just come over, and, well, I let him, because I knew it wasn’t going to last. Just some fun. Still, when he started dating someone else, which I also knew was going to happen, I was sad about it.

I thought that when I got divorced there would be plenty of opportunities to date and have fun experiences. A new season of bloom. But so many of the men want children now. Or they want to get married. Or they expect me to provide.

When I was in my twenties, and had plenty of time to have children, I was careful not to bring it up. Pressure. Didn’t want to do that to anyone. It was a quick way to make a man become uninterested. It would make them run. I couldn’t call drinking coffee together a date. If I did, I would be reminded that we were just friends. I wanted things too soon, too fast.

Never mind saying anything about marriage. People back then, at that age, just weren't ready. What about a career? Now that I am fifty, they all tell me they want to get married. And they want babies, too. I'm not someone you introduce to your friends or bring home to your mother anymore. I will never give her grandchildren to dote on. It's too late for stuff like that.

•

A few weeks passed, and it was still snowing. My friend tried to set up that dinner date. But, it turned out, the man was travelling for four months. He wasn't going to be back until the summer. "I'll be in touch," he said.

Maybe he isn't interested, I thought. Four months from now is a long time. He's in his fifties, too. A grown man. Why doesn't he know where he will be or what he will be doing? He can't pen something in a calendar and work around that? He's a man with a steady job, a schedule. Shouldn't he know enough about his life to choose one night for dinner with friends?

"He might be going through some stuff, in his personal life," my friend said. "You never know."

A month after this, my friend texted me and said that we should go for a walk now that the weather was better. There was so much sun. He'd found out some news. "So I told him that you like him. He said the night he met you and talked to you, he was just floating. He'd never felt that way before. He said, for him, it was love at first sight! This man loves you. And he said he could try to be friends with you, but he can't be friends because he's attracted to you. He can't even be friends!"

I wasn't as excited.

What did it mean that a man in his fifties had never felt this way before? It's kind of late in life to have these feelings be new. Did he just never date a woman he liked before? Did he just go with the ones who texted first, arranged the dates, picked the restaurants? Who, two months later, still answered texts, even though he'd disappeared for a while, and never asked what happened?

I had to ask, “But is he someone who wants to float?” Some people don’t want that. They have to stay grounded—can’t get carried away. Was he like that?

“Oh, and he lives with a woman and he pays the mortgage,” my friend said. “I don’t know what he’s going to do about that. She’s not travelling with him, so maybe they’re not serious.”

I don’t know. A mortgage is serious. They are hard to get, and even harder to get out of.

It was true—four months was a long time to be away from someone you loved. He was having experiences without her. Did he invite her along and she didn’t want to go? Or did he tell her that this trip was something he needed, alone?

Also, if he already had someone, shouldn’t he not say things like that out loud? Sure. We meet other people and we’re attracted to them, but we keep that to ourselves if we’re in something already. Now that it had been said aloud, did that mean that he’d do something about it?

I asked my friend, “If your husband said, ‘I’m travelling for four months alone,’ what would you do?” My friend said, “Oh, we’re just broken up then.”

Exactly, I thought.

“Aren’t you happy? This man feels this way about you!”

I didn’t think it was something to be happy about. It was just words. People can say all kinds of things to let you down easy. Not a lot of people get together for love. You get older, and you just hope that someone is there in the middle of the night.

•

A few months passed. It was summer. The herbs on the balcony grew tall and leafy. I learned more bits about him. The woman he was with. He

complained about her. Enough that some close friends of his said, “It’s not going to last.” And no one from work had met her. “Does she even exist?” someone joked. She didn’t have a job. I wondered, Was it because she didn’t want to work? Was she wealthy and she didn’t have to? Or was it because he demanded that she be at his beck and call? That is like a full-time job.

But didn’t she want her own money? To buy the things she wanted? Maybe he shared everything with her. What was his was hers, too. Maybe that was why he could go on a trip alone for four months. She couldn’t really say anything, because she felt she couldn’t stop him. “He’s never dated someone age-appropriate before,” my friend said. “They’re always in their twenties.” We didn’t know how old his girlfriend was, but she was probably in her twenties. It’s embarrassing to bring someone that age around.

•

The fall came, and he never did get in touch. Why would he? It’s safer to be with someone you’re already certain you have. He didn’t even know me. I wouldn’t be impressed that he had a job, because I had one, too. In a few months, I might find him boring. And then he would have given up a safe and sure thing.

“It was good that he went on this solo trip right after he met you. You could exist for him,” my friend said. If he was at home living his life, going through their daily routines, sitting down for meals, asking her to pass the salt, he would push what I could be somewhere else. He wouldn’t be able to daydream, to let his thoughts drift. “Honestly, four months! He probably fucked a bunch of people. A good-looking guy like that. They come up to him over there,” my friend said. He saw my disappointed face, and he added, “Oh, it just means it’s good for you! He’s not too attached. What’s he coming back to?”

I wondered about the woman who’d waited for him to come back. Did she worry? Did she think he was sleeping with other people? They hadn’t even been together a year. But, whatever they were, he was already paying the mortgage. Maybe when someone is paying for stuff like that, you just let

them do what they want. As long as they come back and wash between their legs.

•

“He’s had some health problems. He has to have surgery. I don’t know what it is, though. He didn’t say. It seemed private. So I didn’t get the details,” my friend said.

In your fifties, for a man, that is probably prostate cancer, I suggested. If it wasn’t serious, he would say so. An appendix. A benign tumor. Tonsils. A root canal. You don’t have to be secret about those things. When you are dealing with your health you don’t think of love. You think about stability. About the person who will help you to the bathroom, wipe you when you can’t make it to the toilet, clean and bandage you because you can’t bend at the right angle to reach the wound. “If that’s the case,” my friend said, “you don’t want a botched one,” and glanced at his own crotch, and shuddered.

Except it wasn’t cancer. It was knee surgery. A doctor had talked him into having it early. “He’s having a hard time recovering. He was swimming and playing tennis before the surgery, but now he’s just in so much pain,” my friend said. Having a partner at this time is important, otherwise you’d have to hire a nurse. A private full-time one is expensive, and even then it’s not like being looked after by someone who loves you. Men are practical people. They aren’t going to chase after someone they love at first sight. They will stay with the person who will take care of them. And I haven’t proved I could be that.

•

“He e-mailed me, asking about a naturopath,” my friend said. “For his partner. She has insomnia.” I thought of not being able to sleep. How you try all kinds of things. Silk pillows, earplugs, listening to the sound of rain. Why couldn’t she find a naturopath for herself? Anyway, that is not a man who is interested in other women if he’s looking into getting help for her. That’s someone who loves her.

Maybe when he got back, she was glad he came home. She didn't say anything or worry about what he'd done away from her so long. Cool with it, is what she was. Why couldn't I be easy in that way? I wasn't anything to him and here I was feeling as if I should be angry that he travelled somewhere for four months alone—that he'd had experiences and made memories without me.

I always thought that when you love someone—when you say that you fell in love at first sight—it will become something. You'll pursue it because you might not ever feel that again. Maybe that's too hard. The idea of losing someone important to you is too great a risk, so you never make anyone important to you. A person who doesn't have a job, who couldn't pay the mortgage on her own, is someone you wouldn't worry about running off. You could trust she'd be there when you got back.

She might sense that something was off. "How come it isn't like it was in the beginning?" she might ask. "This is just how relationships evolve," he might say to her. "This is mature," he'd add.

Why wasn't she worried that his friends didn't know about her? Why wasn't she afraid about not working, about his family thinking she was lazy, living off him and his money? I worry about these things for her, even though it is not my life. No one ever says this, but it is hard work, too, being alone. When you are young, you think that the people who say they love you actually do. That forever might still have time to play out.

•

He said that I made him float. In the cartoons, you hold on to a bunch of balloons, and it just takes you into the sky. You can go anywhere, and nothing bad can happen to you. In real life, floating happens in water. You trust that you can lean back farther and farther and there's something about water and how it works, that you can lift your feet and there you go. It happens. You float.

When I was four, my mother tried to teach me to swim. She carried me out into a lake, but when she put me in the water I sank. I ended up feeling the bottom with my feet. The water was deep. I saw a bunch of small black dots

moving toward me. Tadpoles. I was greedy. I thought I could have them all, and I grabbed and grabbed, but I had nothing to put them in. ♦

Souvankham Thammavongsa is a poet and a fiction writer. Her début novel, "Pick a Color," came out in 2025.

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Sketchbook

N.Y.C. Spring Bingo

Do you have "UPS Guy in Shorts," "Stoop Weirdo," or "Park Teeming with Hinge Dates"?

By Emily Flake

March 23, 2026

Emily Flake, a New Yorker cartoonist, has published books including "Joke in a Box: How to Write and Draw Jokes."

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The Critics

- **Under the Influence at the Whitney Biennial**
  By Hilton Als | How the artists in this year's survey do or, more often, don't acknowledge those who paved the way for them.
- **How Bad Is Plagiarism, Really?**
  By Anthony Lane | From ancient Rome to the era of A.I., people have prized originality, but the line where influence ends and cribbing begins is notoriously blurry.
- **Engels in the Outfield**
  By Adam Gopnik | A radical history of the Mets insists that baseball can still be the people's game.
- **Briefly Noted**
  "Kin," "The Optimists," "The Elusive Body," and "Leaving Home."
- **A "Baritenor" Soars in "Tristan und Isolde"**
  By Alex Ross | At the Met, Michael Spyres uses his broad vocal range to stunning effect, but Lise Davidsen loses power when she leaves her brilliant upper register.
- **"DTF St. Louis" Peers Into the Suburban Male Psyche**
  By Vinson Cunningham | Jason Bateman excels as the Everyman, reeking of ennui and buried impulses, in the new HBO comic whodunnit, also with David Harbour and Linda Cardellini.

The Art World

Under the Influence at the Whitney Biennial

How the artists in this year's survey do or, more often, don't acknowledge those who paved the way for them.

By Hilton Als

March 23, 2026

Agosto Machado's "Shrine (Green)," 2024. Machado made pieces that one might call documents of reverence, excavated burial grounds.Art work by Agosto Machado; Photograph by Jason Lowrie / © BFA 2026

If nothing else, the 2026 Whitney Biennial, curated by Marcela Guerrero and Drew Sawyer (at the Whitney Museum through August 23rd),

introduces viewers to what I call ChatGPT art—facsimiles of facsimiles by makers who have little if any relationship to what they're putting out there, aside from its being a product in service of a career. Indeed, it's difficult to think of the people who grew up with and apparently condone the use of A.I. sources in the creation of "art" as artists themselves, especially if you define art as a creative expression of thoughts or feelings that have changed, and contributed to the vision of, the artists who made it.

It's true that, nearly from the beginning, postmodern art challenged the notion of originality, or, more specifically, the weight of originality—often with great joy and wit and not a little fear. Think of Robert Rauschenberg's "Erased de Kooning Drawing" (1953), or Andy Warhol's version of the Mona Lisa, titled "Thirty Are Better Than One" (1963), or almost all of the conceptual artist Elaine Sturtevant's significant œuvre. But, once you start to believe that production (or reproduction) alone justifies the work, you're in trouble, especially when there's little acknowledgment of the artists who paved the way for your kind of production.

To stand in front of Mo Costello's dark, textured photographs in the Biennial is to see James Welling's profound pictures about darkness and texture from 1980 and 1981. And to take in Aziz Hazara's piece "Moon Sightings" (2024) is to see Wolfgang Tillmans's experiments in color and abstraction. To be in the room with Isabelle Frances McGuire's "Symbolic Birth Cabin Unit" (2024) is to once again feel the power of Nayland Blake's "Feeder 2" (1998). And, as much as you may appreciate Jasmin Sian's beautiful lacelike cutouts and drawings, they make it impossible to get Elaine Reichek's samplers, from the nineteen-nineties, out of your head. Nour Mobarak's audio and resin-and-pigment works, which contribute to her dreamlike atmospheres, draw so much on Pierre Huyghe's genius that you can't make out what exactly is coming from Mobarak herself, except that Huyghe's brilliance is about gestures rather than definitive statements, while Mobarak privileges the weird over the difficult.

Part of why Sherrie Levine's 1981 series "After Walker Evans," based on the great photographer's 1936 images of Alabama tenant farmers and their families, remains so poignant is that Levine is not just making a picture of a picture; she's evoking the flatness and complexity of history, in general and

in Evans's original photograph, and now in hers. The drama of Allie Mae Burroughs's face is something that Evans could capture but not reach, with his photograph "Alabama Tenant Farmer Wife": Burroughs is resolute within herself, her poverty, her Southernness, her femaleness. By retaking or remaking that photograph, Levine asks, Can I get any closer to this image than Evans did? And how does the forty-five-year difference between my "I" and Evans's "I"—let alone Burroughs's—affect what I see? Or what the viewer sees? A lot of the artists whose work is presented in the Biennial circumvent this Borgesian labyrinth of perception and history—if they're aware of it at all. What replaces it is a garbled rhetoric that is supposed to further substantiate the work, but what if the work just isn't there?

You *can* find real work in the Biennial—the Whitney has devoted three floors (and will soon add a fourth) to this survey, the eighty-second in the museum's history—and it's a joy, or a mixture of joy and the kind of melancholy that maturity inevitably brings, to come across, on the museum's sixth floor, Agosto Machado's shrines honoring the spirit of seventies and eighties downtown New York art and culture, a world in which Machado, who died on March 21st, participated, as a performance artist, activist, and archivist. The galvanizing forces in Machado's work—his apparent openness and the pleasure he took in making—do much to close up your critical distance and cut straight to your memories of gone times, gone people. But Machado was not a lachrymose artist; he evoked sentiment without being sentimental, and his colors and ephemera stand out like flags, signalling life in a colorless, dying world. The shock of his work is that it reminds you of that dirty, beautiful word "taste," which Machado had plenty of. His assemblages may evoke—just a little—Joseph Cornell's dreams in boxes, but Machado made pieces that are what one might call documents of reverence, excavated burial grounds, that reveal what we once had and must now live without. You want to touch the items in his stately piece "Ethyl (Altar)" (2024)—which honors the life and career of the performance artist Ethyl Eichelberger, who died by suicide, after receiving an *AIDS* diagnosis, in 1990—because they touch you, and bring back all that you've forgotten about what you've lost.

Sula Bermúdez-Silverman embraces the fun and danger of Dadaism—for instance, when she encloses one of her glass sculptures in iron sheep shears in "blister iii" (2025).Art work by Sula Bermúdez-Silverman / Courtesy the artist / Hoffman Donahue; Photograph by Paul Salveson

Although Sula Bermúdez-Silverman's simultaneously austere and sensual handblown glass sculptures—which are light-bulb-shaped and affixed to steel rods—bear no visual resemblance to Machado's softer edges, she also knows something about art history and the humor to be found in the grand narrative. A thirty-three-year-old Los Angeles-based artist, Bermúdez-Silverman embraces the fun and danger of Dadaism—for instance, when she encloses one of her glass sculptures in iron sheep shears, in "blister iii" (2025). (Her work is especially effective because Guerrero and Sawyer have given it, and everything else in the show, plenty of space.) Bermúdez-Silverman knows something about texture as well, pairing the fragile with the hard, and making comic use of the latter word and concept throughout. Her work is partly fuelled by the fact that she is a female artist dealing with male-centric art history; it's a kind of intellectual and visual romp around such work as Marcel Duchamp's "50 cc of Paris Air" (1919) and Jasper Johns's unforgettable "Light Bulb I" (1958). Johns's light bulb is molded from Sculp-metal, and the mark of the artist's hand is visible in the roughly sculpted base that it rests on, like a body in a coffin. Bermúdez-Silverman's glass pieces can be similarly anthropomorphic. They resonate because—like the work of the Hawaii-born Sarah M. Rodriguez, whose otherworldly, elongated aluminum sculptures in the Biennial remind one of the stripped trees, shattered structures, and devastated people seen in newsreels about Hiroshima, life poking through devastation—they are evidence of what happens when artists don't make art synonymous with a desire for capital.

I don’t buy it when folks say that, given the number of artists and works included in the Whitney’s Biennials, curators can’t make a cohesive statement about contemporary American art. In 2022, the Biennial’s curators, David Breslin and Adrienne Edwards, proved that wrong by, among other things, challenging the museum’s traditional way of displaying work. They removed many walls and had film and video cheek by jowl with painting, while sculptures were scattered in unexpected places. In this way, they showed us that an exhibition doesn’t have to be one stationary thing—that it can *move*, and be many things at once.

Guerrero and Sawyer’s Biennial, which includes the work of fifty-six artists, duos, and collectives, comes to us at a terrible time in American history, when rhetoric is used to distort reality and to evade the complications of subjectivity and nuance in narrative. One afternoon, as I was taking notes at the Whitney, I wondered why, although there were some terrific paintings and drawings by young artists in the show—Johanna Unzueta’s unusual color sense and fascinating biomorphic shapes are the real thing—I kept returning to the sculptures. Kainoa Gruspe’s small, exquisite objects made with materials—stones, fabric scraps, fishhooks, nails, cowrie shells, and so on—that he gathered from military bases, resorts, and the like in Hawaii, his home state, are particularly effective. That afternoon, I realized that it was in the sculptures that I saw, most glaringly, the vast divide between the artists who had worked to find a new vocabulary and those who were centered squarely in a language that was not their own.

It doesn’t take long to see that David L. Johnson, a New York-based artist in his early thirties, is working in a vernacular that has made Cameron Rowland, a few years his senior, one of the more sought-after artists of his time. Like Rowland, Johnson is a minimalist who challenges our idea of beauty while framing language as his primary “art,” language that taps into the idea and reality of the prohibitive: what constitutes “correct” behavior among, presumably, correct people. Johnson’s work “Rule” (2024-ongoing), which makes use of signs announcing the rules of conduct for privately owned public spaces, is clearly the start of something, but I don’t want him to get caught up in what are by now received ideas. I want him to foster his own voice and listen to where it takes him. Although there are

layers in his work, there is no postmodern grappling with the father, as there was in Rauschenberg's take on de Kooning, or Warhol's rethinking of Leonardo da Vinci; instead, Johnson picks along the edges of Rowland's work, and considers that nourishment. But it isn't.

You can never fully enter another artist's process—or subjectivity—and that's partly what makes the Nigerian American Precious Okoyomon's stuffed-animal and baby-doll sculptures so troubling. Okoyomon's most obvious influence is Mike Kelley, whose incredible evocation of childhood in his "Arenas" pieces, from the nineteen-eighties and nineties, continues to haunt us and grows ever more powerful with the years. Kelley used stuffed animals to engage with the passage of time, the commodification of emotion, what we discard in order to "grow," and what no adult can entirely leave behind: the tattered, perhaps not so innocent inner child.

Precious Okoyomon, "You have got to sometimes become the medicine you want to take," 2025 (detail).Art work by Precious Okoyomon / Kunsthaus Bregenz / Courtesy the artist; Photograph by Markus Trotter

To that, Okoyomon, who is nonbinary, adds the issue of race. (One of the dolls is in blackface, and their installation "I wanted to kill but had nothing

to kill” (2025) includes many stuffed animals hanging from nooses.) In the catalogue, all the Biennial artists are asked about their practice; reading through these interviews, we discover the ways in which theory has become a performance. “I think I’m always thinking through a noncoercive rearrangement of desire,” Okoyomon says at the start of their interview. (Like many of the interviews, Okoyomon’s doesn’t refer to other artists or influences.) But what are they trying to represent in their work? A self? And which self? The racial self? The nonbinary self? Or what the world makes of each and all of those things? Elaine Sturtevant told us a lot about how the (non-male) artist’s self can become distorted or buried in the patriarchal art world—and can then reëmerge, not whole but remade into something that questions and challenges the patriarchy that buried it, or thought it had. Okoyomon seems, in their work, to want to remake themself in Kelley’s image, by appropriating aspects of his surface kink, but without knowing what it meant and what it took for Kelley to become himself in the first place. ♦

This article has been updated to reflect the news of Agosto Machado’s death.

Hilton Als, a staff writer at The New Yorker, won the 2017 Pulitzer Prize for criticism. He is the editor of “God Made My Face: A Collective Portrait of James Baldwin.”

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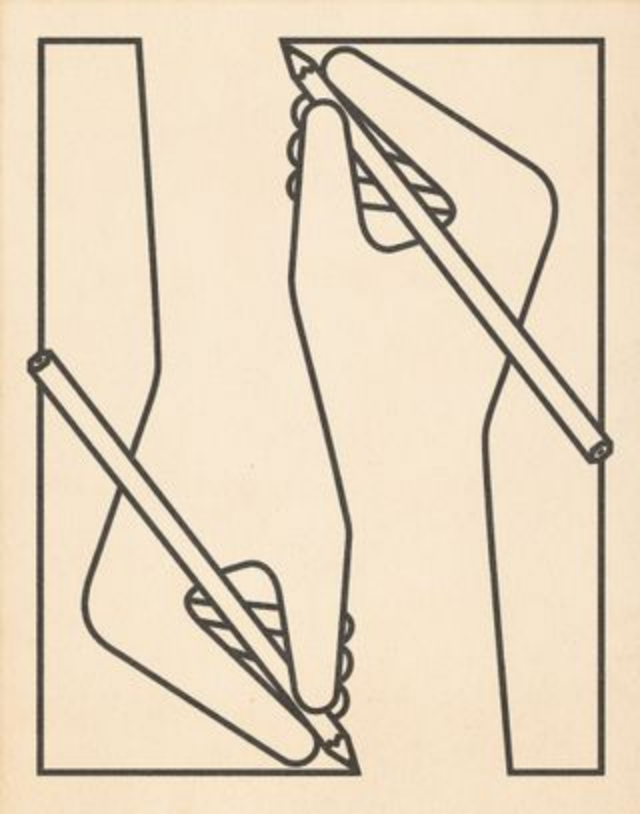
Books

How Bad Is Plagiarism, Really?

From ancient Rome to the era of A.I., people have prized originality, but the line where influence ends and cribbing begins is notoriously blurry.

By Anthony Lane

March 22, 2026



One pleasing facet of plagiarism is that, in the eyes of the law, it doesn't exist.Illustration by Tyler Comrie

Wanna humanize? I could come over later, bring a few beers, and we could, you know, get down to some serious humanizing. Hard to resist, these days, given what's at stake. For students with assignments to complete, who have already vanquished their desolation by asking ChatGPT to compose an essay on their behalf, a humanizer is an A.I. tool that takes what has been produced, puts it through a further digital mill, and makes it sound as if it

had emerged from a verifiable person. Among the companies that offer such tools are StealthWriter, HIX AI, and QuillBot. (If Nabokov had written science fiction, his villain would have been called Quillbot.) Anyone who has buttered and blitzed a mountain of mashed potatoes into a purée will understand. It's hard to live with the lumps.

What I find charming about the humanizers is how human they are—that is, with what cheerful candor they proceed on the assumption that, as fallen beings, we have no option but to cheat. Not only can we not think for ourselves, or write by ourselves; we really can't help ourselves, either, so here comes technology to spare us the pain. As for the notion that we might forgo A.I. in the first place, relying instead on our own wits, and that such self-sufficiency might even be *good* for us, forget it. That's like suggesting we learn to ride a penny-farthing, inhaling the sweet scents of the hedgerows as we pedal along.

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One of the knottiest problems in this vexing new field of endeavor concerns the relationship between A.I. and plagiarism. It could be argued that the two are nearly identical, given that artificial intelligence scrapes up immeasurably vast amounts of online data, like those trawlers that scour the seabed for shrimp and flatfish with weighted nets, and to hell with the natural habitat. A chatbot is not (or not yet) an individual, and therefore bears no moral responsibility, but to lay hold of what it delivers, and to pass it off as one's own work, could be construed as handling stolen goods. That, at any rate, is a viewpoint that prevails at some of the sturdier colleges in the United States. The most robust that I have come across is San José State University, where the advice offered by the Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. Library is admirably clear: "It doesn't matter which AI program/software

you use. Using any of these to write your papers is considered a form of plagiarism."

What plagiarism is and has been, and what it may be in the process of becoming, are questions addressed by Roger Kreuz in a bouncy new book titled "Strikingly Similar" (Cambridge). He defines plagiarism as "the deliberate appropriation of someone else's words and ideas without acknowledgement or compensation." Words *and* ideas? That's quite a bundle. Also, as Kreuz rightly asks, how many words? Or, indeed, how many musical notes? He offers a peculiar example: when the Chiffons sang three notes, in a simple descent, at the start of their 1963 hit "He's So Fine," written by Ronnie Mack, few listeners foresaw that the sequence would form the nub of a legal dispute that would, absurdly, not be concluded until 1998. The issue was whether, when George Harrison sang the words "My sweet Lord," in the 1970 song of that title, he was recalling, borrowing, swiping, unwittingly echoing, or accidentally mimicking Mack's melodic phrase. The fact that the two songs were atmospherically far apart—the ex-Beatle robed his harmonies with a chant of "Hare Krishna"—was beside the point. To the victim, a transcendental thief is still a thief.

What kind of victim are you, though, when somebody summons the nerve to plagiarize you? You are physically intact. You haven't lost a wallet, a diamond necklace, or a child. There could be a dent in your artistic pride, but it's unlikely to hurt as much as a stubbed toe. Privately, you might even feel a trifle smug—flattered that your stuff should merit larceny. Maybe that is why neither Harrison nor any other Beatle was moved to protest when the spiky and urgent bass riff that introduces "Taxman," on "Revolver," appeared more or less intact at the start of "Start!," the fifth track on "Sound Affects," a 1980 album by the Jam. According to Bruce Foxton, the Jam's bassist, "it wasn't intentional, but 'Taxman' subconsciously went in." As it happens, Foxton's explanation comes uncannily close to the 1976 ruling of a New York judge, Richard Owen, who asserted that, although Harrison's use of "He's So Fine" had not been deliberate, "his subconscious knew it already." Spooky.

It's hardly news that the subconscious can exact a heavy cost, though even Freud would have raised an eyebrow at the amount—more than two million

dollars—that Owen ordered Harrison to pay. (The amount was later reduced, but that was not, by a long stretch, the end of the affair.) So, given the resemblance, why weren't the Jam in a pickle? Well, the Beatles didn't need the money, even after paying what they considered too much in taxes, and it could be that homage, blatant or otherwise, struck them as their rightful due. Rare was the creative artist, post-1970, who wasn't churned up by bobbing in the Beatles' wake. Kreuz doesn't mention the Jam in his book, but he does usher us through the Harrison case, arriving at a crux that will, God willing, never be neatly resolved:

> If the unconscious mind has no statute of limitations, then it becomes difficult to draw a bright line between appropriation on the one hand and inspiration on the other.

Anybody who embarks on a study of plagiarism hoping for bright lines is in for a foggy shock. Here is the land of blur. Only intermittently in "Strikingly Similar" does an act of plagiarism stand out as conscious, unambiguous, and proud. If the book has a hero, it is a great man named Alfred J. Carter, whom Kreuz describes as "an unemployed welder," and who, in 1949, "was caught when he tried to sell a Wordsworth poem to *Good Housekeeping*." Which poem, and why did the killjoys at the magazine turn it down? Weren't readers crying out for tips on how to make their daffodils golden and hostly? The more poetry that could be smuggled under their noses, by whatever means, the better their skill at keeping house. Earth has not anything to show more fair than the crust on a chicken potpie.

The range of "Strikingly Similar," according to the subtitle, runs "from Chaucer to Chatbots." The emphasis, however, is heavily on modern times. We get nothing of Samuel Johnson, who, while declaring plagiarism to be "one of the most reproachful, though, perhaps, not the most atrocious of literary crimes," in an essay from 1753, was also typically generous in his plea for mitigation: "A coincidence of sentiment may easily happen without any communication, since there are many occasions in which all reasonable men will nearly think alike." On the other hand, we do get Boris Johnson, who, it is alleged, based a 2019 Twitter thread on a lawyer's anonymous blog post. Such is the glorious age in which we dwell.

There is a rough story line that relates to plagiarism, which goes as follows. Plagiaristic mischief did not exist—or, at least, did not exert such a grip on the collective conscience—before the Romantic era, with its pesky insistence upon "originality." Before then, it was deemed not just defensible but natural that a person bent on creative deeds would proceed via imitation: you studied your models, learning to copy them and thus whetting the edge of your skill. Only then were you qualified to venture upon work of your own devising, which would, needless to say, continue to show evidence of its predecessors.

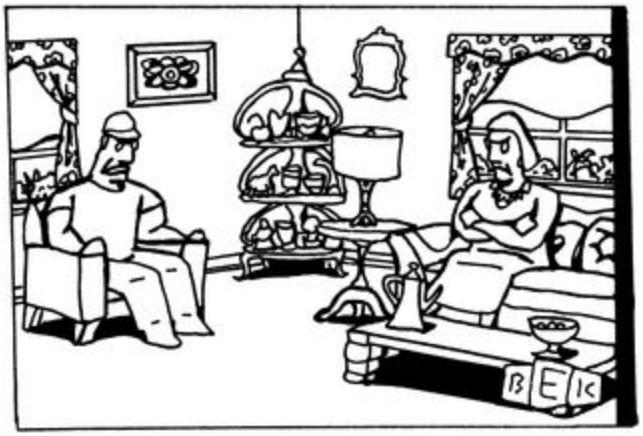
Staid though it sounds, this process bequeathed to us, in bulk, an unmanageable wealth of beautiful objects. At first glance, Raphael's "Marriage of the Virgin," from 1504, is pretty much a straight rehash of the same subject as painted in the preceding years by Perugino, to whom Raphael had been apprenticed. But a hundred glances, or more, are needed to calibrate what has changed: the way in which the presiding priest, mid-frame, cocks his head and animates the hitherto chilly symmetry of the composition; the elaborating of the temple behind him, with figures now filling two of its arches; and the tense spectacle of a suitor breaking a staff across his knee in frustration at being supplanted by Joseph. You find yourself bracing for the snap. (In the earlier painting, he bends the staff feebly over his thigh.) Was Perugino, the master overtaken by his pupil, similarly tempted to smash something? Or did he applaud this smooth showpiece of the imitative system at work? We don't know. One thing he didn't do, for sure, is take Raphael to court and sue his sneaky ass.

Jump ahead a hundred years or so, to 1602, and we find an Englishman named Thomas Lodge receiving an M.D. from Oxford University. He was a well-travelled soul, who had been as far as Brazil, and the author of "Rosalynde," a popular proto-novel, bedecked with incident, and reputedly written at sea. It had been published in 1590; was Lodge now aware that it had, in the meantime, been ransacked for a recent play, "As You Like It"? There are imponderables here: we lack conclusive evidence that the play was even staged in Shakespeare's lifetime. Nonetheless, there is no denying its piracy of the prose tale. True, Shakespeare had added the characters of Touchstone and Jacques, thus mocking the sport of love and misting it in disillusionment; but most of the plot is pure Lodge. If, by our standard, that

is glaring plagiarism, the obvious retort is that the standard of the early seventeenth century was a very different beast. How different, though?

> At first he made low shifts, would pick and glean,
> Buy the reversion of old plays; now grown
> To a little wealth, and credit in the scene,
> He takes up all, makes each man's wit his own.

That is part of a sonnet by Ben Jonson, titled "On Poet-Ape." It appeared in 1616, the year of Shakespeare's death. Whether or not the poem is about Shakespeare is a cause for scholarly debate, but what rises from it is anger. Jonson directs his scorn not only at plagiarists but at the average fool ("the sluggish gaping auditor") who swallows their deceit. The same impatience lingers and spreads, thirty years later, through "Pseudodoxia Epidemica" (1646), a treatise by Sir Thomas Browne, who issues a peppery demand—"I wish men were not still content to plume themselves with others Feathers"—and makes the important point that we are dealing less with an annoying fad than with a permanent crack in human nature. "Plagiarie had not its Nativity with Printing, but began in times when thefts were difficult," he writes.



"You used to think my racist hate-filled tweets were the cutest thing."
Cartoon by Bruce Eric Kaplan

In the light of such plaints, maybe we need to adjust the established narrative. There have always been picky souls, it seems, who *do* find fault with plagiarism, and who refuse to shrug it off as reverent emulation. It would be a mistake, certainly, to regard the miasmic anxiety that swirls around the subject of current plagiarism, facilitated by A.I., as unique to us;

the technology is unprecedented, but not the temper. For a healthy perspective, I recommend a little time travel. Try Robert Macfarlane's "Original Copy: Plagiarism and Originality in Nineteenth-Century Literature" (2007)—a dazzling dive into late-Romantic attitudes—or, for a longer journey, Scott McGill's "Plagiarism in Latin Literature" (2012), which makes today's plagiarists, and their enemies, look like milksops. I like the sound of Quintus Octavius Avitus, who apparently devoted *eight volumes* to showing what a chronic plagiarist Virgil was. Virgil! The historian Sallust, meanwhile, was lampooned by a guy named Lenaeus as "*lastaurum et lurconem et nebulonem popinonemque*," which McGill translates as "catamite, glutton, scoundrel, barfly." But that wasn't the worst of it. The worst was that he was a plagiarist.

One of the pleasing facets of plagiarism is that it doesn't exist—not in the eyes of the law, that is, and especially not if those eyes are American. There is intellectual-property law, and a law that prohibits the trafficking of counterfeit goods. There are laws against copyright infringement. If plagiarists are sent to prison, however, it will not be because they have filched a slice of poetry, or half a juicy ballad, and passed it off as their own. Plagiarism, *pace* Dr. Johnson, is not a crime. It is a sin.

In the mind of the plagiarized, as often as not, what has been perpetrated is nothing less than an outrage. When the science-fiction writer Harlan Ellison watched James Cameron's "The Terminator" (1984), he decided that the opening scene, of futuristic warriors battling in a broken landscape, with lasers blazing, was and could only be a ripoff of "Soldier," a twenty-year-old episode of "The Outer Limits" whose script he had written. Charges were levelled. The studio behind the movie, Orion Pictures, settled out of court for an undisclosed sum, and, since then, the end credits of the film have displayed the uneasy wording "Acknowledgment to the works of Harlan Ellison." An unhappy Cameron was quoted as saying, "It was a real bum deal, I had nothing to do with it and I disagree with it," though at least he had the satisfaction of seeing his movie improve a thousandfold on the TV show. As far as the law is concerned, though, bum deals are a twilight zone.

Someone who has pondered such niceties is Richard Posner, a former circuit judge and a prolific legal scholar. Rarely is Posner unamused, you sense, by the briars of confusion through which he undertakes to cut a path, and "The Little Book of Plagiarism" (2007) finds him at his most incisive. We get hushed in-jokes ("judicial acknowledgement of ghost authorship by law clerks is vanishingly rare"), plus knuckle raps for his peers ("judges will sometimes call copyright infringers 'plagiarists,' though there is no concealment"), but what lends the book its kick is the unwearying zest with which Posner defines and redefines his terms until they agree, for the moment, to hold still. He proposes that one way to treat plagiarism is as "nonconsensual fraudulent copying," and the phrase, though it stumbles rather than trips off the tongue, strikes me as usefully cautious.

Now and then, Posner branches out from the main line of his thesis into the psychology of plagiarism—the motives both of those who fall into it, as if it were an addiction, and of those who expose it. "By far the most common punishments for plagiarism outside the school setting have nothing to do with law," he writes. "They are disgrace, humiliation, ostracism, and other shaming penalties imposed." Why should this be? In part, according to Posner, because plagiarism is "embarrassingly second rate; its practitioners are pathetic, almost ridiculous." By this token, the politician who steals scraps of another's rhetoric (even if the actual stealing is performed by speechwriters) is derided as if he had been found watching pornography. I would go further than Posner and suggest that it's precisely *because* there are no plagiarism laws that the surrounding area is such a free-for-all. Without the barriers of legislation, the brawl spills out of control.

In the absence of cops, you get vigilantes, and Kreuz has a fine chapter, "The Plagiarism Hunters," that details the thrilling activities of the truth-tracking industry. This has become quite the rage since Posner's book came out, almost twenty years ago. We learn of a graduating senior at Parkersburg High School, in West Virginia, who discovered that a commencement address given, in 2019, by the principal, Kenneth DeMoss, bore an ominous resemblance to a speech delivered by Ashton Kutcher "in accepting Nickelodeon's 2013 Teen Choice Ultimate Choice Award." And you thought Virgil was a crook. DeMoss was suspended for five whole days without pay, we learn, while his accuser was attacked for ratting him out.

(Such minor-league meanness begs to wind up in a novel.) Kreuz neglects to tell us whether Kutcherology studies have since boomed, but, thanks to his efforts, I am now aware of VroniPlag Wiki, “a crowdsourced collaboration established to ferret out and expose plagiarism in German dissertations.” Boy, do those *Volk* know how to have fun.

Go beyond online sleuthing and you come to something older and infinitely odder: the plagiarism hound whose very snarling is a work of art. The name Ivan Goncharov does not appear in “Strikingly Similar,” and that’s a pity, because he shakes up every discussion of the plagiaristic impulse. Goncharov’s fame rests solidly on “Oblomov,” his 1859 novel about a man so steeped in apathy that one of his heroic endeavors consists of simply getting out of bed. Less well known is “An Uncommon Story,” which was written some years before Goncharov died, in 1891, and not published until 1924. The book is mad, and all the madder for being unsmilingly sincere. The method of the madness is plain: Goncharov claims to have been plagiarized, with ever greater cunning and mendacity, by Ivan Turgenev, who once had been his friend. Specifically, “Home of the Gentry,” Turgenev’s most graceful novel, is said to have been extruded, without shame, from Goncharov’s “Malinovka Heights,” despite the fact—and this is where the pathology of jealousy grows truly inspired—that the latter came out ten years *after* the former. To Goncharov, the inconvenient chronology proves his point; in conversation, he says, he had freely mentioned his plans for various characters and concepts, only for Turgenev to squirrel them away and then plant them in his own fiction, making sure to publish first, and thus preëmpting charges of plagiarism. Dastardly! See how the Devil works:

> I only gradually came to wake up to the idea that Turgenev was spreading lies about me: that he was in fact going around telling people that he had been recounting his stories to me, and that I was envious of him and I was the one who was spreading rumours and slander about him—instead of the other way round—when it was he who was exploiting my goodwill.

Got that? By rights, “An Uncommon Story” should be unreadable, yet it is saved by the sheer stamina of its arraignment. No sadness mars the purity of

its paranoia. In the mouth of a master like Goncharov, crying foul at the sight—or, at any rate, the perception—of plagiarism acquires an astounding verve. Stolen jewels can do wonders for the imagination, even if they are tucked away in a safe.

Is there such a thing as good plagiarism? Can you sin your way into redemption? Academically, no; the call for honest and accurate citation of one's sources will, and must, ring out as forcefully as ever. The blandishments of digital reproduction, whereby cutting and pasting is less bother than blowing your nose, and smart glasses can be instructed to photograph whatever lies within your vision, do not augur well, and the penultimate page of "Strikingly Similar" finds Kreuz in dark prophetic mode. "The consumption of intellectual property without paying for it," he writes, "may function as a gateway drug that normalizes the act of appropriation."

If that is the shape of things to come, it will be comically hard to police. Give me raiders of the lost past, any day, and forgive them their lack of footnotes. I remember listening to "Bedtime Stories," Madonna's 1994 album, and being surprised by a moony track called "Love Tried to Welcome Me," which contains the lines "But my soul drew back, / Guilty of lust and sin." This is an unacknowledged but unmistakable nod to George Herbert, one of the most enduring religious poets of the early seventeenth century, who wrote a magnificent poem that begins "Love bade me welcome: yet my soul drew back, / Guilty of dust and sin." How Herbert, who was an Anglican priest of surpassing gentleness, might have felt about being quoted, three and a half centuries later, by somebody with a Catholic name and a conical bra we shall, alas, never know. The most gratifying irony is that, in changing the mortally ashen "dust" to the cheaper and more obvious "lust," Madonna proved only that Herbert wrote better lyrics than she did, and I can't help wishing that she had turned to him more often for guidance both verbal and spiritual. Papa *does* preach.

The safest form of plagiarism, by common consent, is self-plagiarism. Only the very determined would have the courage to sue themselves, although I'm sure that Goncharov would have got around to it eventually. Kreuz allows himself a brief interlude on the matter, breezing past rumors of self-

plagiarism in the work of Kelly Clarkson and Puccini before bumping into the saintly figure of Charles M. Schulz, and, in particular, into a Snoopy strip from 1996 that was, Kreuz tells us, barely distinguishable from an earlier one, from 1987. Good grief! Is that it? Could it be that self-plagiarism, far from being a lapse into rote and repetition, is practiced by every writer, composer, and painter of the first rank? Borrowing your own creations, investing them anew, and turning a fresh profit is the business of the alchemical few. “She loves you, yeah, yeah, yeah,” we hear as “All You Need Is Love” begins to fade, the Beatles summoning the spectre of their younger selves from all of four years before. (It must have felt like four lifetimes.) And the lover and his lass who pass over the green cornfield, in the springtime of “As You Like It,” are recollected, deathlessly, in the flowing figure of Perdita, in “The Winter’s Tale”:

> This is the prettiest low-born lass that ever
> Ran on the green-sward: nothing she does or seems
> But smacks of something greater than herself,
> Too noble for this place.

We have a word, in English, for self-plagiarizing so habitual, and so fruitfully evergreen, that it becomes the mark—the smack, if you will—by which an artist is recognized and loved. We call it style. ♦

Anthony Lane is a staff writer at The New Yorker and the author of “Nobody’s Perfect.”

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Books

Engels in the Outfield

A radical history of the Mets insists that baseball can still be the people's game.

***By** Adam Gopnik*

March 23, 2026

Mets players celebrate after clinching the 1969 World Series, an improbable triumph that helped fix the franchise in the imagination of its faithful.Photograph from AP

Some books, to amend a motto from Shakespeare's "Twelfth Night," are born ironic, some achieve irony, and some have irony thrust upon 'em. A. M. Gittlitz's "Metropolitans: New York Baseball, Class Struggle, and the People's Team" (Astra) is a shining new example of the rare third kind. Given the realities of modern baseball, one expects Gittlitz, a journalist and an Occupy Wall Street veteran who writes from a hard-left, Marxist perspective, to dissuade his readers from rooting for something as obviously and cynically commercial as a sports franchise, or from imagining that a "people's team" can exist when all teams are owned by a succession of plutocrats, each more sickening than the last. We assume that he will point out the futility of identifying with something so flimsy and compromised as a professional baseball club. The terms in his subtitle can only be meant mockingly, we think, as we open his pages, expecting to watch hope collapse as he lays bare the usual brutal commodification of pleasure at the highest possible price.

Not a bit of it. An all-consumed, obsessive Mets fan, Gittlitz truly believes that the Mets are the people's team and that they have been engaged in genuine, if often contorted, class struggle on our behalf for the past sixty-five years or so. Their World Series victories, in 1969 and in 1986, were not moments of capitalist diversion from the workers' plight but were early glimpses of the civic solidarity that will arrive with the revolution; they were antiwar, anti-racist, anti-capitalist triumphs. So strenuously idealizing is the book that it is hard to read without imposing irony upon it, but the irony is ours. Gittlitz really means it. Come the revolution, the team that represents us will be wearing, he reassures the reader, the Mets' colors: "the hard-hat orange of the international working class, and our blue Earth."

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To demonstrate his belief, Gittlitz runs through the history of the Mets—not unappealingly, since genuine obsession is always appealing—and reminds the reader of all the moments when the Mets at least seemed to stand for what was once called the counterculture. He makes a much better case than one might have thought possible. Tom Seaver, the hero of the Mets' 1969 run, was, however modestly and mildly, an antiwar voice in Nixonian times. Cleon Jones, at the moment he made the catch for the final out of the World Series, thought back to his ancestors, "enslaved people stolen from their homes by greedy, Godless people." This line, which Gittlitz takes from Jones's 2022 memoir, sounds suspiciously like a reflection that arrived long after that final out. Still, Gittlitz has no doubt that the Mets are the good guys. If they cannot quite win the class struggle, well, the people generally do not. But come the revolution, they shall. The effort is helped immeasurably, of course, by the constant antithesis of the Yankees, who have long exemplified oligarchic power, whether in their corporate mode of the fifties, when it was said that rooting for the Yankees was like rooting for

U.S. Steel, or in their later despotic Steinbrenner years. (Marx said that what first happens as tragedy returns as farce. What began as farce with Steinbrenner returns as tragedy with his disciple Trump.)

To hit home his points, Gittlitz connects what happens on the field with all that happens off it. His cultural history can be a bit out of focus. He insists that baseball was a powerful tool of Cold War propaganda for the United States, which forced the game to be played in alien corn. In truth, as Robert K. Fitts reminds us in his fascinating new book, "In the Japanese Ballpark," baseball was already popular in Japan in the nineteenth century and became a craze after Babe Ruth toured the country in 1934, remaining just as popular at the height of imperial Japan's anti-Americanism as it was after defeat. What's more, baseball never had an impact in Britain or Western Europe. The notion that the spread of a sport simply reflects the values of its inventors is falsified again and again by history. Soccer flourished early in working-class England, but the versions played in Brazil, Hungary, and the Netherlands are more interesting than the original model. Cultural phenomena, including games, tend to be open-ended in adaptation and adoption, and generally feed difference at least as much as they enforce uniformity.

Gittlitz's book is long, loving, and pained. A Marxist in love with the Mets occupies a difficult position. By the end, the requisite contortions lead him to a fate almost worse than capitalism: he must confront the thesis, offered by *Jacobin's* founding editor, Bhaskar Sunkara, that it's the Yankees who represent "an authentic working class," even as "squeezed middle-class Mets fans try to carve out their own path in vain." Could the Yankees really be the people's team? Gittlitz, all but conceding the struggle session, can only sigh and see the Yankees' populist strength as a version of Hobbes's Leviathan, "whose despotic reign is legitimized solely through unbeatable strength." Steinbrenner couldn't have put it better. The Yankees are the pseudo-populism of Trump, the Mets the fading, if still illuminating, last light of the left.

Yet Gittlitz's book, despite its occasional absurdities, arrives at a propitious moment. At a time when professional sports seem even more dominated than usual by a narrow right-wing chauvinism—a Yankee fan had to sue so

that fellow Yankee fans could leave their seats to use the restroom when "God Bless America" gets played in the seventh inning—a leftist account of the game feels bracing and courageously unorthodox, and raises the right question: How are we to imagine baseball humanely in 2026? The nonfan can now easily find a reason for the non-caring. "I thought you hated all that Trumpian flag-hugging," a certain nonfan remarked in the midst of an interminable post-season series, with its regimented regalia.

In one sense, of course, the game has never seemed healthier. Last year's World Series was the greatest since the Mets-Red Sox in '86 or maybe the Reds-Red Sox in '75, as the Blue Jays, representing Canadian nationalism (though by way of a roster stocked with Americans and Latin Americans) came within inches of beating the American Dodgers (and their trio of Japanese superstars). Yet the general corruption of everything inevitably perpetuates itself. The most shocking instance may be the constant superimposition of the Mastercard logo on the pitcher's mound even at the height of play, shocking precisely because it now passes unremarked. So if the political account of baseball's pleasures seems inadequate to our experience, we can turn to philosophy—to Alva Noë, for instance, who is, it turns out, as passionate and all-consumed a Mets fan as Gittlitz. And, surprising to a reader of Noë's earlier, more academic books, he is a child of the Greenwich Village streets who learned baseball in the shadow of Italian gangs. His book "Infinite Baseball" is the best reflective study of the sport since A. Bartlett Giamatti's "A Great and Glorious Game."

Noë's book *achieves* irony in the familiar intellectual way. Everything that happens in baseball, he wants us to see, can also be taken as a meta-comment on what is happening as it happens, so when a base is stolen, say, we have the basis for an argument about why they call it stealing, and what constitutes a base. As we understand language best by seeing it as a game, we understand games best by seeing them as a language. "Sports, for the player as well as the fan, are always embedded in a setting of talk and reflection," Noë writes. "Sports aren't just activities bent on the cultivation of physical skills for their own sake; they are little social worlds in which doing is one thing and reflection on what you're doing is another. But both are very much required."

Noë's essential thesis is that baseball is not merely a game governed by rules but a social practice shaped by context and circumstance. This is true, in some measure, of all sports, but baseball is unusual in making that truth part of its entertainment rather than treating it as an embarrassment. Noë's exemplary case is the "neighborhood play," the long-standing convention that a middle infielder can get the out on a double play without actually touching the bag. "You're going for a double play, and, in order to avoid a collision at second base with the incoming runner, the second baseman or shortstop—whoever is covering—would simply indicate that his foot is in the neighborhood of the base, basically saying: what I'm doing is the moral equivalent of actually touching the base," he recently observed. "I could touch the base, but touching it would be risky. For both the runner and the fielder." A whole society and history are implicated here.

A baseball game is the conversation of a community, and certain readers may notice that this view resembles Noë's account of consciousness itself. Consciousness, he has long insisted, does not take place deep within some mysterious recess of the self. It is "out there," in our interactions with countless people and forces in the world. Being in the world makes us conscious, and the more fully we are in it—the more we swing the bat and run the bases—the more conscious we become. Just as the last place to look for consciousness is in the neurons, the last place to look for baseball is in the rule book.

This view makes Noë a ferocious critic of recent changes in baseball that aim to speed up the game and to mechanize its decision-making. He hates the arrival of the "robo-ump," an algorithmic system that can decide balls and strikes and overrule the umpire. "A strike is not a ball in a certain location," he says. "It's a ball that the batter ought to be able to hit, and a ball is one that reflects nothing poorly on the batter that he was unable to hit." The strike zone can shift in the course of an at-bat and even from pitch to pitch, as part of the live contest between pitcher and hitter. Good pitchers persuade the umpire, working the corners and gradually reshaping the zone. And umpires sometimes make calls in light of that ongoing exchange, sensing that a batter would have attacked a truly hittable pitch. In an odd way, there's a parallel between the superimposition of the automated ball-strike zone on home plate and the superimposition, onto all sports, of

gambling apps: both depend on the displacement of slow-paced pleasures, Noë's ongoing conversation, into accelerated gimmick entertainments. The twentysomething perpetually betting on each aspect of the game is akin to the spectator forced to accept the replacement of human decision-making with a yes-or-no machine.

Noë contrasts the appealing fluidity of properly umpired baseball with the game of tennis, where we are actually grateful for the computer simulation that shows clearly whether the ball was in or out. As another philosopher might point out, the difference here lies less in psychology than in physics. Tennis is played in a fixed environment, the unchanging court, but the strike zone genuinely varies with the size and stance of each batter. A baseball player, after taking a badly called third strike, might cry, "You gotta be blind!" or "Are you crazy?" but not "You cannot be serious!" Seriousness is assumed in the subjectivity of home-plate umpiring. John McEnroe cried out because the call was plainly wrong. In baseball, the call is inevitably, and pleasurably, debatable. That's part of the game.

A beautiful instance of the way baseball's inherited language can reshape the action lies in the defining play of last year's Series, summed up in an image that will haunt Canada for as long as there is a Canada. In the bottom of the ninth, with the bases loaded and a ball chopped to second, the Blue Jay base runner Isiah Kiner-Falefa broke late for home and slid just as the Dodgers' catcher, Will Smith, got to the plate, a fraction of a second ahead of him. The play was, in living rooms and bedrooms and doubtless barrooms throughout Canada, reduced to a single haunting synecdoche of two fast-colliding feet: one belonging to Kiner-Falefa, barely short of home plate; the other belonging to Smith as he made the out, toe stretched and touching the plate, the ball invisible in his glove above.

The great question remains: Why did Kiner-Falefa slide? The original purpose of sliding was to keep a runner from overrunning the bag and being caught past the base, since stopping on a dime at full speed is nearly impossible. The slide also permits him to evade a tag coming in from above, compelling the fielder to make a sweeping, often mistimed effort. Sliding into home when all the catcher had to do was touch the plate with the ball in his glove was suboptimal strategy. Expert opinion holds that he

should have broken sooner and run straight through and maybe past the plate—since he could not be tagged out after scoring—even at the risk of knocking over the catcher.

And yet he slid. The best explanation seems to be that he slid because sliding is what you do in baseball. It was less a considered choice than obedience to custom. Since a force play at the plate is unusual (one expert estimates that it happens at most once a month), the familiar instinct is to slide into home. Had the third-base coach cried out, “Don’t slide!,” he might well have created more confusion in Kiner-Falefa’s mind than clarity of purpose, just as it is usually wiser to continue through a yellow light than to slam on the brakes mid-intersection. The normal thing, even when wrong, is often easier to execute than the unusual thing, even when right. One could call this muscle memory rather than cultural custom. But then cultural custom is simply muscle memory widely shared.

Would he have collided illegally with the catcher? The rules governing collisions at the plate are subjective, too, as Pete Rose demonstrated, in his way, in a once famous play in the 1970 All-Star Game, when he scored for the National League by knocking over Cleveland’s catcher, Ray Fosse, knocking over at least a part of Fosse’s future career as he did. (In an exhibition game! But that was Pete.) Had Kiner-Falefa run full speed and knocked Smith over, it might have been ruled interference by a home-plate umpire unused to seeing such a play. That would have been a kerfuffle to end them all. But it’s more likely that the run would have counted, and the Blue Jays would have won the World Series. Of such tiny, contestable renegotiations—such micro-adjustments to context and circumstance—is the great game of baseball made.

If philosophical accounts of baseball achieve ironic self-consciousness through effort, more purely aesthetic ones tend to be born ironic. Novelists take for granted that what makes baseball interesting is not any single thing that happens but the way one thing after another unfolds. Robert Coover’s great baseball novel of 1968, “The Universal Baseball Association, Inc., J. Henry Waugh, Prop.,” just reprinted by New York Review Books, imagines a glorified card-and-dice version of Strat-O-Matic baseball, in which the protagonist, an oppressed accountant named Henry Waugh, can

oversee, deity-like, the whole of creation: God as the ultimate fan. At length, the madly intricate rules of Waugh's self-invented game force him—he has built his own league and mythology—to sacrifice his favorite player, in a brilliantly imagined Christian allegory. Yet the success of the novel's conceit, allegory aside, depends on the fact that baseball is a game of discrete acts, each one isolated enough to be submitted to chance and rule in turn.

I wrote an aesthete's account of baseball in these pages some forty years ago, my first appearance, and made, in more effortfully efflorescent prose, much the same point. Baseball appeals because it is historical in the first instance: one thing happens, then another, and each thing is reflected in the next, as in the history of art. In this respect, baseball is different from more fluid sports, such as hockey and football, which yield to analysis only with effort. We experience football even after it ends. We analyze baseball even as it takes place. Art history, with its constant return to the old in order to find meaning in the new, is a better model for understanding baseball than is statistical analysis.

Aesthetes distill pure pleasures from what could be seen, from other angles, as compromised messes. We love Botticelli's mythologies without caring overmuch about the Mafia nature of the Medici who commissioned him. Can our love for our contemporary teams escape our knowledge of their brutal base? Gittlitz and Noë both think it can, by different routes. In truth, the larger story of modernity is always the story of how money-seeking enterprises become heartwarming attachments. Capitalism devours our affections as it creates them. Updike gave the final affront to his modestly American protagonist Harry Angstrom in the discovery that the department-store Christmases of his childhood were wholly mercenary enterprises, designed to draw the suckers in and ending when they could no longer be drawn. Could sports play a higher human role in a socialist utopia? Well, in the socialist utopias so far constructed, the chief desire of the athletes has been to get out, to go West, and to get paid. To say that attachment is unmasked by the sordid motive, or that the sordid motive is redeemed by the depth of attachment, is only to state an obvious truth, one escaped solely by an admittedly irrational faith. You really do gotta believe.

Sports remain a culture that encircles us with habits and shared understandings. Sometimes our fandom may seem, to the nonfan, less an aesthetic inquiry than a simple addiction. We're hooked on the vicarious thrill of winning, and so long as we get occasional rewards—'69 and '86—will put up with the long pauses without. All that big talk about "community conversation" and shared social spaces is exactly what you find with drug addicts, too, who, as the sociologist Howard S. Becker showed years ago, are as much addicted to the activity as to the addictant. They talk about their taking all the time, too.

Still, we root, root, root for the home team, and if they do not win it is something worse than a shame. Meanwhile, we buy peanuts and Cracker Jacks at whatever price the concession stand can extract. Perhaps what we want at the ballpark is less a community of common values than a casual ideal of citizenship. That is why a far-left dreamer of revolution can sit in a stadium watching a club owned by a voracious financier and still feel part of the town, with a philosopher and an art historian nearby to keep him company.

That, in the end, our motive and cue for passion may be impossible to define makes them no less central to our lives. I have spent an inordinate amount of mine caring about professional sports teams that do not care about my existence, and rooting for the well-being and success of men often a quarter my age who make thousands of times more money than I do. An illusion? Well, what is not? Balls and strikes depend on where you are. If a tree falls in a forest, does anyone hear it? Unanswerable. If you throw a strike that only a machine can see, is it still a strike? That one is easy. No. Balls and strikes and outs and close plays at home take place within strictly human exchanges, and baseball's whole imaginative force lies in their irreducible sum.

Perhaps the missing, under-celebrated figure in these reflections is the nonfan, the necessary nonparticipant, the invisible planet tugging at the orbit of the rest of us. The long-puzzled partner wanders in as the extra innings of a World Series game drag past midnight and hears you say that you will come to bed when it is finally over. "Well, enjoy it," the nonfan

says cheerily. “You do not *enjoy* a game like this,” the fan mutters. “Well, then, do . . . whatever you do with it,” she says. And you do. ♦

Adam Gopnik, a staff writer, has been contributing to The New Yorker since 1986. His books include “The Real Work: On the Mystery of Mastery.”

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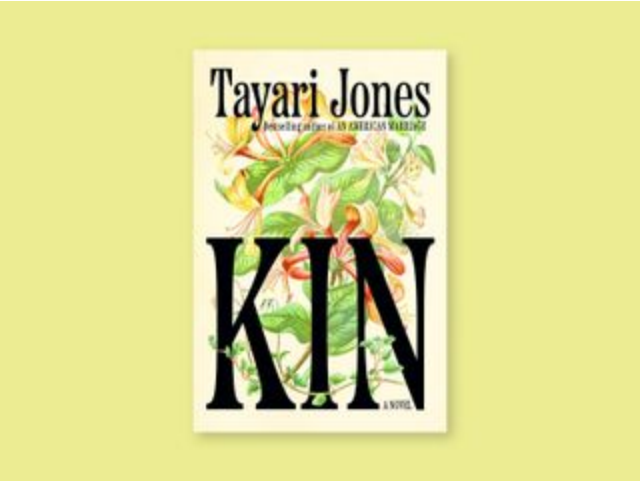
Books

Briefly Noted

“Kin,” “The Optimists,” “The Elusive Body,” and “Leaving Home.”

March 23, 2026



Kin, *by Tayari Jones (Knopf)*. This magisterial, moving novel centers on two closely connected young women, Annie and Vernice, motherless “cradle friends” raised by relatives in small-town Louisiana during the Jim Crow era. “When you don’t have your mother, you don’t really know who you are,” Annie remarks, and, as the women attempt to forge their identities, they take divergent paths. Annie runs off to Memphis with a boyfriend, in search of the mother who abandoned her; Vernice, whose mother died, goes to Spelman in pursuit of upward mobility. Much later, the two come together again, though in desperate circumstances. Jones’s book is a profound examination of the evolving intricacies of love, family, and belonging. As one character observes, “Blood alone can’t give you kinship.”

The Optimists, *by Brian Platzer (Little, Brown)*. In this playful novel, a former eighth-grade English teacher at a New York City private school recalls the trajectory of two former students, Jacob and Clara, from kindergarten to adulthood. Unlike Jacob, Clara thrives in the teacher's class. Her promise is all the more valued because she comes from poverty. As befits its young protagonists, Platzer's novel evokes the feeling of possibility; like its aging narrator, it derives insights from the way relationships change over time. Although Jacob and Clara's bond functions as an emotional anchor, it's the love the teacher receives from his wife, to whom he addresses his recollections, that lends significance to the story's telling.

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Illustration by Henri Campeã

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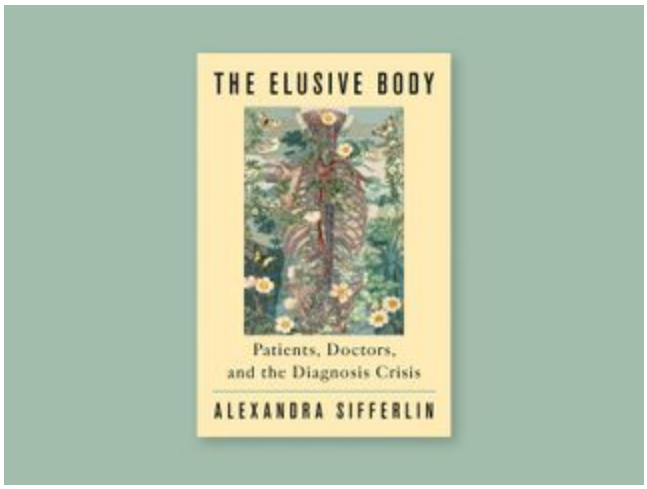
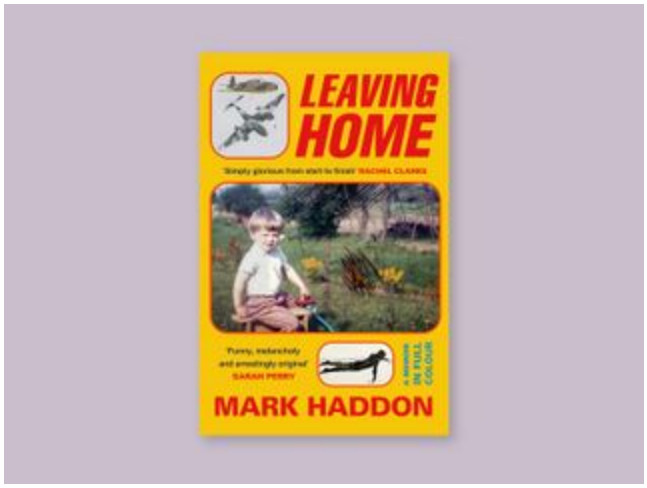


The Elusive Body, *by Alexandra Sifferlin (Viking)*. Each year, around twelve million people in the U.S. experience a medical diagnostic error; some three million live with diseases that remain undiagnosed even after exhaustive medical investigation. Sifferlin's book examines the roots of this situation, and explores avenues for addressing it. Though some methods—such as improving physician training—seem within reach, American health care is beset by structures that are inimical to constructive change. Insurance companies may refuse coverage for diseases that are not easily categorizable, for example, and in 2025 the federal government froze funding to Harvard, which has played a central role in the study of undiagnosed illness.



Leaving Home, *by Mark Haddon (Doubleday)*. Haddon, the author of celebrated books for both adults and children, including "The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time," announces at the outset that this

memoir is “An Exorcism” of his difficult childhood. “I grew up on a diet of *Carry On* films, Benny Hill, my parents’ misogyny and the *Daily Telegraph*,” he recalls. He also endured bouts of severe anxiety and depression. The grimness of Haddon’s material is made palatable by his humor and sharp observations, as well as by dozens of photographs and illustrations (many drawn by Haddon himself). Literature, marriage, fatherhood, and working with disabled people ultimately helped Haddon find solace and stability. Home, he realizes, is sometimes “a place you have to discover or construct.”

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Musical Events

A “Baritenor” Soars in “Tristan und Isolde”

At the Met, Michael Spyres uses his broad vocal range to stunning effect, but Lise Davidsen loses power when she leaves her brilliant upper register.

By Alex Ross

March 23, 2026

Michael Spyres and Lise Davidsen sing their love duet while inside a conelike apparatus that amplifies their voices.Illustration by Maria Fedoseeva

On the topic of “Tristan und Isolde,” Richard Wagner once said, “Only mediocre performances can save me! Thoroughly good ones would drive people insane.” Fortunately for the body politic, perfect performances of Wagner’s love-death epic seem impossible. During my time in the classical-

music watchtower, I've seen a dozen or so productions of the opera, and something is always out of whack—often, many things. At the Met in 1999, amid semi-abstract mood pictures and under the direction of Dieter Dorn, René Pape delivered a transfixing portrayal of King Mark, while James Levine cultivated sonorous inertia in the pit and Ben Heppner and Jane Eaglen struggled to animate the title roles. At the same venue in 2016, the musical values were superb—Simon Rattle conducting with sinuous authority, Nina Stemme and Stuart Skelton lending vocal richness to the doomed lovers—but Mariusz Treliński's staging groped around in modern-dress murk. Of the productions I've witnessed, Peter Sellars and Bill Viola's video-centered collaboration came closest to highest bliss, especially in the version I saw at the Paris Opera in 2005, with Waltraud Meier in full, ferocious dramatic flight as Isolde. Yet even the finest efforts leave countless avenues unexplored.

Perhaps the most striking thing about "Tristan" is the way it combines the metaphysical-philosophical with the psychological-realistic. The piece is steeped in Schopenhauer's meditations on the futility of worldly striving and the necessity of accepting oblivion. It is also infused with Wagner's paganistic worship of desire and his matchless ability to translate longing into perpetually unresolved musical phrases. At the same time, "Tristan" observes the Aristotelian unities in a way that puts its characters under enormous dramatic pressure. Each of the three acts unfolds in real time, and each has one node of decisive action: Tristan and Isolde drink the presumed death potion that makes them fall in love; they are discovered in the garden of King Mark, Isolde's betrothed; Tristan dies, with Isolde following. Furthermore, Wagner insists on showing how every mad love affair makes others suffer. After the volcanic duet of Act II comes Mark's howl of sorrow, for which the listener is never really prepared. The impossibility of the opera lies in resolving those two vastly different spheres, the cosmic and the intimate.

The Met's latest production, under the direction of Yuval Sharon, is stronger on the philosophical than the psychological. Sharon, who first drew notice for astounding multimedia spectacles with the Industry company in Los Angeles, is an experienced Wagnerian who presented a persuasive feminist take on "Lohengrin" at the Bayreuth Festival in 2018. He has a grounding

in Brechtian theatre and is not one to dawdle in Romantic atmosphere. He sees Tristan and Isolde not as isolated flesh-and-blood characters but as archetypes who recur across tellings and retellings of the legend, from medieval times to the present. The opera unfurls on two planes. One, at the front of the stage, is centered on tables where rituals take place—a shared drink, a meal, a deathbed watch. The other, filling the Met's proscenium, is an iris-like portal that suggests a gateway into dream worlds and the beyond. The singers are accompanied by doubles performing parallel actions on one or the other plane.

In Act I, the stage picture is cluttered, the meaning unclear. This is an all too familiar issue at the modern Met, which, under the aegis of Peter Gelb, the general manager, more or less mandates clutter: hulking sets (by Es Devlin, in this case), choreography (by Annie-B Parson), video and live projections (by Ruth Hogben and Jason H. Thompson). The audience is often left unsure about what it should be looking at. Lost in the melee of imagery—ocean waves, bottles and potions, knives, and so on—is the crux on which the opera turns: Isolde's uncontainable rage at being carted off to marry King Mark, in the clutches of the man who killed her beloved.

Later on, Sharon's conception snaps into focus. In Act II, Devlin's set becomes a floating fantasy realm where the lovers lose themselves in their forbidden desires. They sing from the inside of a conelike apparatus that has the property of amplifying their voices. At times, segments of the cone separate and carry the lovers in opposite directions—an excellent visual metaphor for the narcissism of their passion. In Act III, as the wounded Tristan suffers, hallucinates, and dies, he is seen both lying on a hospital table and wandering in a tunnel populated by white-clad figures. The singer and his double change places as the character passes in and out of consciousness. At the end, Isolde is seen giving birth to a child and joining Tristan in the beyond. The images are at once affecting and jarring—dream and nightmare intermingled. The confusions of Act I notwithstanding, Sharon has passed the "Tristan" challenge. He will next take on the "Ring," beginning in the 2027-28 season.

The chief musical pleasure of this "Tristan," on the second night of the run, was Michael Spyres's portrayal of the damaged hero. This Missouri-born,

Vienna-trained tenor has the capacity to sing almost anything, his repertory encompassing Handel, Mozart, bel canto, grand opera, and Wagner. Even more remarkably, he can assume baritone roles as well as tenor ones. He calls himself a “baritenor,” and the label fits. He is thus well suited to Tristan, whose music often borders on the baritonal. Lauritz Melchior, the part’s most storied interpreter on recording, had a similarly broad range. If Spyres cannot match Melchior’s trumpeting high notes, he traversed the score with unfaltering stamina, retaining clarity of diction and breadth of phrase throughout. I don’t think I’ve ever heard Tristan sung so securely and so musically.

The heavily promoted Norwegian soprano Lise Davidsen proved problematic as Isolde. She has been appointed the Met’s leading lady in Wagner and is slated to sing Brünnhilde in Sharon’s “Ring.” Her high notes are glorious, spurring comparisons with Birgit Nilsson and other legends. But Isolde isn’t about high notes. Large tracts of the role lie lower in the voice, where mezzo-ish resonance is required. Davidsen’s power drops off markedly in the octave above middle C. Often, the part jumps in and out of that zone, as on the words “*Fluch deinem Haupt*” (“A curse on your head!”), which falls from the G at the top of the staff to the G below and then climbs up again. The fluctuating volume in such passages—“FLUCH deinem HAUPT”—made for a weirdly uneven line. Beyond that, Davidsen’s diction was mushy, and she lacked the expressive fury of Meier and other great latter-day Isoldes. Yes, the upper register is phenomenal, but I’d rather hear an Isolde who has squeaky high C’s and can sing the rest at full strength.

The subsidiary roles were a similarly mixed lot. The veteran bass-baritone Tomasz Konieczny delivered Kurwenal with roughshod interpretive conviction; he is a born Wagner singer. Ryan Speedo Green, as King Mark, may not have matched Pape’s raw grandeur in the role, but he supplied an affecting sense of shattered nobility. Ekaterina Gubanova, who sang Brangäne glowingly in 2016, was less lustrous this time around.

Yannick Nézet-Séguin, the Met’s music director, might have resolved some of the evening’s inconsistencies if he had shown more consideration for the singers and generated more intensity at the climaxes. Yet long stretches, the

awesome Prelude included, unspooled with no sense of urgency. For decades, the Met orchestra was the prize of the institution; individual players remain excellent, but the collective now lacks distinction. One of Sharon's brightest inventions is to bring Pedro R. Díaz, the Met's English-horn player, onstage for his long solos in Act III, so that he becomes a denizen of Tristan's tunnel of delirium. His melancholy seems symbolic on another level. Under Gelb's leadership, the Met has steadily lost money, audiences, and artistic eminence. The company is not yet in its death throes, but it is in need of drastic intervention. ♦

Alex Ross has been The New Yorker's music critic since 1996, and also covers literature, history, and ecology, among other topics. He is the author of "Wagnerism: Art and Politics in the Shadow of Music."

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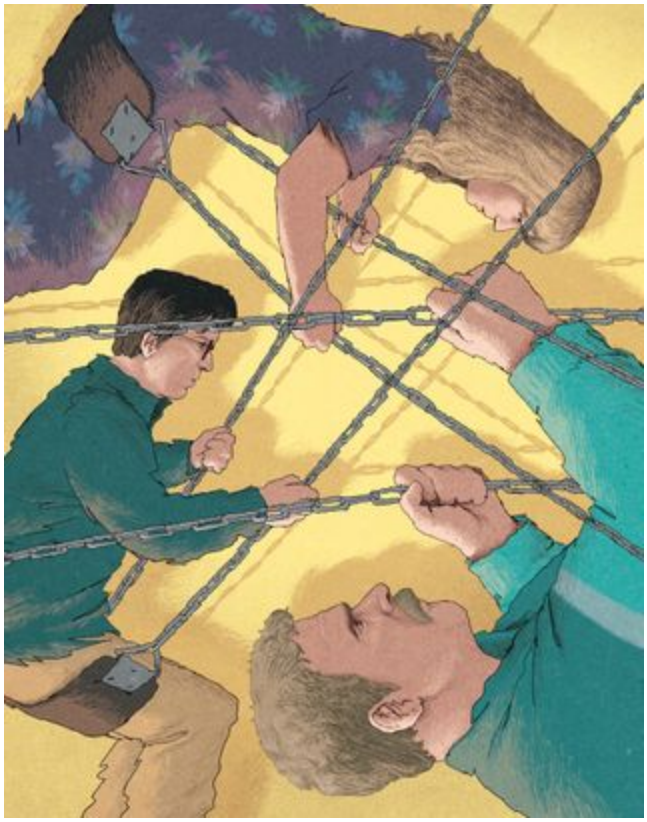
On Television

“DTF St. Louis” Peers Into the Suburban Male Psyche

Jason Bateman excels as the Everyman, reeking of ennui and buried impulses, in the new HBO comic whodunnit, also with David Harbour and Linda Cardellini.

By Vinson Cunningham

March 20, 2026



Clark Forrest, a local celebrity weatherman, is like an updated, puzzlingly childlike Cheeverian confection.Illustration by Chris W. Kim

During a recent episode of “SmartLess,” the podcast that the actor Jason Bateman shares with his industry buddies Sean Hayes and Will Arnett, Bateman chatted amiably with the show’s guest, the business mogul and

reality-star supermom Kris Jenner. Jenner told the trio the story of her first encounter with Robert Kardashian, her first husband, who would later come to fame by serving on the defense team for his golf buddy O. J. Simpson. (Bateman: “Is it a meet-cute?”) It was at a horse track. (“I’ve never been to the Kentucky Derby, no, but I met a mint julep once.”)

Bateman had been ambling through the interview with a nervous professionalism, pecking away at Jenner with the kinds of questions your best-adjusted friend—or that friend’s dad—might ask. But then, perhaps inspired by the mention of the genteel betting environment of the Derby, he piped up with an intriguing piece of personal history. “I used to have a bit of a fun time with gambling,” he said. “I no longer do.”

Bateman’s curt baritone was the same as it always is: no sorrow or self-recrimination or even rote regret marred his tone. In fact, he sounded sort of peppy, even though he was relaying what might have been a dark glimmer of a sordid arc—too much “fun” followed by a fall. His euphemistic locution was extra funny because it was directed at Jenner, whose public profile carries no hint of ever having had “a bit of a fun time” that didn’t yield a nice paycheck, or at least a helpful hit of press. All efficiency, that Jenner. She didn’t really respond to Bateman’s biographical toss-off.

For years now, Bateman has been one of my favorite actors, precisely because he tends to play characters who might nonchalantly mention a degenerate past, with no evident rancor, then never bring it up again. His characters enjoy casual conversation but don’t brook wanton confession. They’re probably just as happy to talk about the weather, or the business pages, or the latest intrigue at the office, as anything else—happier, even. Bateman plays Everymen: repressed, likable, sometimes spiky, often prosperous guys whose secrets leak out through subtleties of wording and tone, and by way of blank, unworried statements instead of long epiphanic speeches or outpourings of the soul.

In “Arrested Development,” the cult-classic mockumentary sitcom that aired from 2003 to 2006, Bateman played Michael Bluth, the middle son of a wealthy family fallen on hard times. He’s a widower and the father of a meek kid played by Michael Cera. Surrounded by vain, selfish airheads, he’s something like a surrogate for the audience, often selling a joke just by

making a baffled face. Michael Bluth is exceptional because of the wealth his family used to enjoy, but also because of his seeming—and, to be fair, intermittently absent—levelheadedness despite the bubble in which the rest of his family still stubbornly, tenuously lives.

Starting in 2017, Bateman played Marty Byrde, an accountant turned cash launderer for a ruthless Mexican cartel, in “Ozark,” arguably his signature role. The show is lit in wan grays and murky browns—this has, over the years, become an irritating Netflix cliché, but, in the case of “Ozark,” the coloristic choice really works. Marty becomes the proprietor of a funeral home and a riverboat casino, both fronts that can’t hold for long, placing him in the middle of a conflict between the Mexicans and the local criminals near the Lake of the Ozarks, in Missouri, a whole social panorama away from his family’s former home in Chicago. “Ozark” is about how putatively regular people can get caught up in currents much stronger than they know, how Batemanian sangfroid can cloak a quotidian sociopathy that only grows as bloody trouble grows, too. It also, in an insightful way, recasts the relationship between white-collar work and underworld crime. Sometimes what the cartel needs most is a guy who’s a whiz with a spreadsheet.

“DTF St. Louis,” a new comic whodunnit on HBO, is a strange, surreal, surpassingly dark addition to Bateman’s œuvre. He’s cast well in the show—I can’t imagine it working without his presence, reeking of ennui and buried impulses. He plays Clark Forrest (that’s Michael, Marty, and Clark, for those keeping track; so many swatches of khaki-colored, all-American nomenclature), a TV weatherman living in a St. Louis suburb. He rides a dorky recumbent bike to work; he bought one for his wife, but she won’t use it. The marriage is beige, just like the town, and just like Clark’s life.

At work, while reporting near a looming tornado, Clark meets Floyd (played with a touching, funny pathos by David Harbour), a sign-language interpreter. Floyd lives on a lower rung of the town’s hierarchy than Clark. He doesn’t have as much money, his formerly buff body (he used to pose for *Playgirl*) has gone bulky and soft, he’s got the taxman on his ass, and his rock-throwing stepson gives him only grudging respect. Still, Clark and

Floyd get along. They're both uncomfortable in their lives and looking, somewhat desperately, to spice things up.

Soon, Clark finds a dating app emphasizing discretion, called DTF St. Louis, which he shares with Floyd. (It's reminiscent of the app Ashley Madison, that infamous watering hole for lonely married folks, whose names were exposed in a 2015 leak.) But before we learn too much about how their dates might go, or whether they're even able to snag some, we discover that Clark has been carrying on an affair with Floyd's wife, Carol (Linda Cardellini), and Floyd turns up dead, surrounded by his own pinups and a can of laced Bloody Mary.

"DTF" is even odder than you may think. Its characters speak in repetitive, often childish phrases that sound as though they belong to much younger people, possibly elementary-school children playacting at bored adulthood. "I fuckin' love it and stuff," one lover says to another, confirming her enthusiasm for their tryst. People make big deals about their favorite Jamba Juice concoctions, and take many beats too long to arrive at the understanding that "DTF" does in fact stand for "down to fuck." Certain passages in the fiction of Jane Bowles read like this. You might conclude that the show is an experimentalist exercise in rummaging through the brain matter of the median suburban American, connecting each of that specimen's furtive actions and veiled desires to the immutable psyche of a permanent child.

In a chapter of Susan Cheever's latest book, "When All the Men Wore Hats"—which cunningly explicates the writing of Cheever's father, John—the stories "The Five-Forty-Eight" and "The Country Husband" get grouped together as suburban horror shows running on sexual energies. "Both these stories carefully paint the pastel watercolors of the suburbs," Susan Cheever writes. "Both stories run on the energy of illicit sex and unwanted desires, and both end up in shame for the men who feel these desires."

In this way, Clark Forrest, a local celebrity owing to his job, is like an updated, puzzlingly childlike Cheeverian confection. He asks Carol to dominate him—he calls their odd lovemaking method "powerhousing," and requests that she yell and purr and querulously cry the word "powerhouse" as she thrusts while he lies on the motel bed with his feet in the air. (He

admits that this was first done to him by a red-haired guy with a mustache; like John Cheever, he may have even deeper proclivities to hide.)

To observe Bateman, here and elsewhere, with his sharp features and clear voice all working to accomplish a deceptively high irony—Bateman's hallmark is that he's never saying exactly what he means—is to ask after the health of the "average" American male. Let's concede for a moment, just by dint of statistics, that this guy has to be white and live in a suburb of a secondary or tertiary metropolis. Let's say that he's trying very hard to be "good," by whatever definition hit him at the right time to absorb that kind of lesson. And let's say that the invisible power of his position—never laboring under any sort of automatic racial or gender suspicion—is a freighted vehicle pulling him toward a corruption whose contours he lacks the sophistication to perceive, much less resist. We don't even need to ask how he votes. Shouldn't we get him some help? ♦

Vinson Cunningham is a staff writer at The New Yorker. His début novel is "Great Expectations."

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Poems

- **“Coots”**
  By Rosanna Warren | “Were they coots, those dark birds with flashy / white bills, swimming together in circles / on winter waves?”
- **“Midnight in the Pain-Relief Aisle of CVS Thinking About ‘The Cloud of Unknowing’ ”**
  By Donna Masini | “Pain ricochets around my skull / like an aspirin commercial from the sixties.”

Poems

Coots

By ***Rosanna Warren***

March 23, 2026

Were they coots, those dark birds with flashy
white bills, swimming together in circles
on winter waves? Jagged surface of
the city reservoir. It would snow soon,
we walked fast, night was spreading its cloak,
the western skyline sparkled its broken glass,
and the birds in their tuxedos tightened their rings
so the water rippled glossily
out around them, catching glints.
And wouldn’t freeze. A miracle how
a family survives: come spring, coots lay
too many eggs, too many hatchlings crowd
the nest, begging for bugs and weeds the parents bring.
Irritable parents: after three days
they tousle the chicks, the weaker ones
starve. What kind of
mother, I ask, knowing all too well.
Coots cluck, screech, cackle, squawk. For now,
they keep swimming in circles. That’s one way
to show you belong. A hard, featherless
shield covers their foreheads, connects their
eyes with a scarlet dot. If you have one idea,
guard it. Only
the merciless live.

Rosanna Warren is the author of “Max Jacob: A Life in Art and Letters” and “Hindsight.”

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Poems

Midnight in the Pain-Relief Aisle of CVS Thinking About “The Cloud of Unknowing”

***By** Donna Masini*
March 23, 2026

Pain ricochets around my skull
like an aspirin commercial from the sixties,
darting up the nasal passages, up behind the frown,

the temporal bones, clutching at God
like a desperate spark. *He bound you to him*
by a chain of such longing. Ridiculous,

pressing and pressing the button for an attendant,
aching jaw, temples throbbing. When did they start
locking everything up? Do I need something,

this man wants to know. Contact lens solution,
root touch-up. Where is my mind?
my mother said this morning. Is Daddy dead?

How did he die? *Do not fret after God*, my book says.
Well, I do fret. I’m fretted as a guitar, picking out
the same chords, arpeggios of dread wandering 24-hour chains,

rehearsing my facts—one big cloud of forgetting.
There are 300 muscles in the face. The time bone, the temple
is called, where our hair grays first. Why aren’t the aisles marked?

My God, what is that shrieking? The man doesn't work here,
he says. *Reconcile yourself to wait in the darkness*.
What did I think spiritual desert meant? Surely not that

lump of nothing I was an hour ago on the couch, wielding
the remote, spooning mango sorbet out of a container.
It should feel, I explain to the self-checkout screen

(how did I get here?), punching in my customer number,
more important. What saints felt. A dreadful hunger.
If you need help, the self-checkout voice is saying.

Todo y nada, *todo y nada*, it whispers,
here in the aching all-night fluorescent.

This is drawn from "Did You Find Everything You Were Looking For?"
Donna Masini is the author of "Did You Find Everything You Were Looking For?" (May, 2026), among other books.

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Cartoons

- **Cartoon Caption Contest**
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- **Cartoons from the Issue**
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Puzzles & Games

- **The Crossword: Wednesday, March 18, 2026**
  By Caitlin Reid | A beginner-friendly puzzle.

Crossword

The Crossword: Wednesday, March 18, 2026

A beginner-friendly puzzle.

By Caitlin Reid

March 18, 2026

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Caitlin Reid has been constructing crosswords since 2017. Her puzzles have appeared in the Times, the Wall Street Journal, and USA Today.

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